UNIQUE
ENGLISH IDIOMS

- A Comprehensive Collection of Idiomatic Expressions
- The Easy, Interesting and Useful Idioms

MAZHAR HUSSAIN

All rights reserved.

Book Name: Unique English Idioms

Publishing Date: 12 October, 2020

Edition: First

Price: Rs. 300

Publisher:

AILIA RESEARCH ACADEMY

ISLAMABAD

Attribution

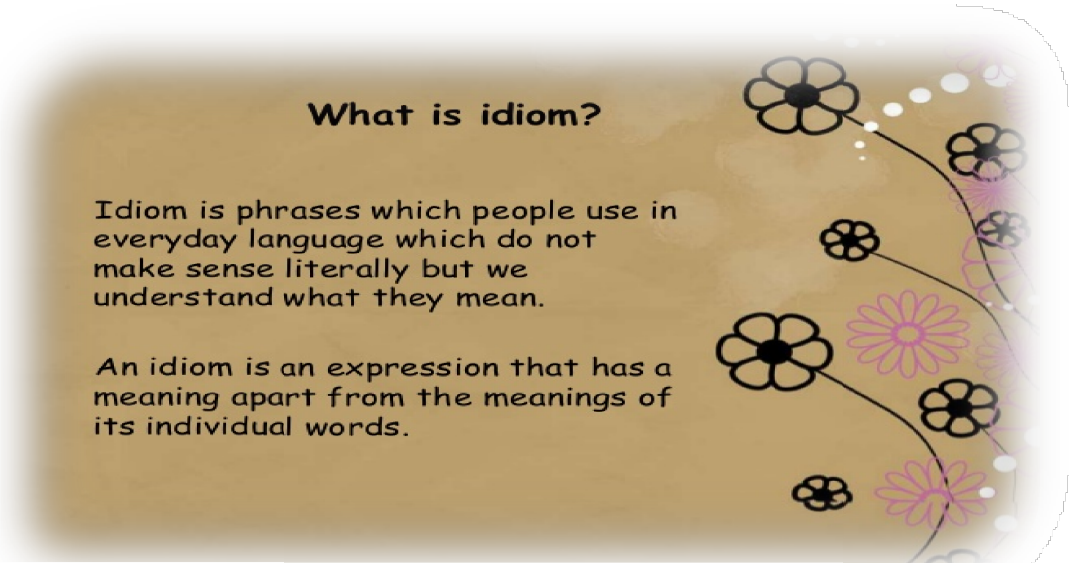
to English Linguists

who invent the

English Alphabets

Contents

Title	Page	Title	Page
Head, Mind and Mouth	*99*	*Arm, Hand and Leg Idioms*	*04*
Heart Idioms	*106*	*Blood Idioms*	*11*
Horse Idioms	*109*	*Body Idioms*	*13*
Legal Idioms	*112*	*Back Idioms*	*29*
Medical Idioms	*127*	*Bone Idioms*	*31*
Money Idioms	*130*	*Breath Idioms*	*33*
Monkey Idioms	*139*	*Business Idioms*	*36*
Mouse Idioms	*140*	*Accounting Idioms*	*48*
Neck Idioms	*141*	*Advertising Idioms*	*50*
Negotiation Idioms	*143*	*Banking Idioms*	*51*
Number Idioms	*152*	*Meeting Idioms*	*52*
Pig/Hog Idioms	*158*	*Sales Idioms*	*53*
Rat Idioms	*160*	*Cards Idioms*	*54*
Relationship and Love Idioms	*161*	*Cat Idioms*	*58*
Sheep and Goat Idioms	*167*	*Clothes Idioms*	*60*
Shoulder Idioms	*168*	*Color Idioms*	*65*
Skin Idioms	*170*	*Court Idioms*	*69*
Sports Idioms	*171*	*Cow Idioms*	*76*
Stomach Idioms	*183*	*Dog Idioms*	*77*
Sweat Idioms	*184*	*Education Idioms*	*80*
Throat Idioms	*185*	*Eye, Ear and Nose Idioms*	*86*
Wolf Idioms	*187*	*Fish, Insects and Reptiles Idioms*	*91*
		Food Idioms	*94*



Arm, Hand & Leg Idioms

all thumbs- *clumsy, have difficulty fixing things or working with one's hands*---The janitor is all thumbs and can never fix things without making them worse.

arm and a leg- *pay a very high price for something that isn't worth it*---My father paid an arm and a leg for his car but he really enjoys driving it.

at hand- *easy to reach, nearby*---I couldn't find any tools near at hand so I was unable to fix the stove.

at/on one`s heels- *close behind, as a constant follower or companion*--- The large car was on my heels during my drive into town.

bite the hand that feeds one- *turn against or hurt a helper or supporter, repay kindness with wrong*---My niece is biting the hand that feeds her if she keeps abusing the help that her parents are giving her.

burn one`s fingers- *learn caution through an unpleasant experience*---My father burned his fingers on the stock market and doesn't want to invest money there again.

cold feet- *a loss of courage or nerve*---I planned to go to Europe with my cousin but he got cold feet and decided not to go.

cool one`s heels- *be forced to wait by someone in power or authority*---I was forced to cool my heels in the lobby for an hour while I waited for the job interview.

cross one`s fingers- *cross two fingers of one hand to hope or wish for good luck*---I crossed my fingers that I would be able to get the job that I had applied for.

dirty one`s hands- *hurt one's character or good name, do a bad or shameful thing*---The politician dirtied his hands when he became involved in the questionable land deals.

drag one`s feet/heels- *act slowly or reluctantly*---Our company is dragging their feet in making a decision to hire new workers.

feet of clay- *a hidden fault or weakness in a respected person*---The new Prime Minister has feet of clay and may not last very long in his new position.

feet on the ground- *an understanding of what can be done, sensible ideas*---The new manager seems to have his feet on the ground and will probably be able to come up with a sensible solution to our problems.

get off on the wrong foot- *make a bad start, begin with a mistake*---Unfortunately my relationship with my new teacher got off on the wrong foot.

get one`s feet wet- *begin, do something for the first time*---We won't have time to finish this job today but at least we can get our feet wet and start.

give one`s right arm- *give something of great value*---I would give my right arm to be able to go to Florida with my friend next month.

give someone a hand- *help someone with something*---I gave my friend a hand moving into his new apartment.

glad hand- *a friendly handshake, a warm greeting*---The politician spent all day glad handing the crowd at the shopping center.

grease one`s palm- *pay a person for something done or given - especially dishonestly, bribe someone*---We had to grease the palm of the customs agent at the border to get our goods into the country.

green thumb- *a talent for gardening, ability to make things grow*---My sister's husband has a green thumb and has a very beautiful garden.

hand over fist- *fast and in large amounts*---We have been making money hand over fist in our new store.

hands-down- *easy, unopposed*---I won the election hands-down for the position of president of our class.

hands off- *leave something alone, do not interfere with something*---I was told to take a hands-off approach while dealing with the new employees.

high-handed- *depending on force rather than what is right, bossy*---He took a high-handed approach to the negotiations and in the end he was not successful.

in hand- *under control*---After several hours the riot police had the problems with the crowd in hand.

in hand- *in one's possession*---He arrived at the border crossing with thousands of dollars of cash in hand.

itching palm- *greed, a wish for money*---The police officer had an itching palm and took much money from criminals before he was arrested.

keep one's finger's crossed- *wish for good luck*---I will keep my fingers crossed that you are able to get the new job that you have applied for.

kick up one`s heels-- *have a good time, celebrate*---We kicked up our heels last night and had a great time at the party.

knock someone off their feet- *surprise or shock someone so much that they don't know what to do*---The singer's voice was so beautiful that I was nearly knocked off my feet.

land on one's feet- *come out of a bad situation successfully*---I was able to land on my feet even though our company had recently gone bankrupt.

lay a finger on- *touch or bother someone*---I was told not to lay a finger on the son of the boss when he comes to work for us.

lay one's hands on- *get hold of, find, catch*---If I can lay my hands on a barbecue I will barbecue some chicken for dinner.

let the grass grow under one`s feet- *be idle, be lazy, waste time*---That man is never content to let the grass grow under his feet. He is always busy.

lift/raise a finger- *do something, do one's share, help*---Her daughter will never lift a finger to help anyone.

live from hand to mouth- *live on very little money*---My friend has been living from hand to mouth since he lost his job.

near at hand- *easy to reach, nearby*---If there is a grocery store near at hand I will buy some milk.

off one`s hands- *no longer in one's care or possession*---I would like to get my old refrigerator off my hands so that I can buy a new one.

one foot in the grave- *near death*---The man next door is suffering from cancer and has one foot in the grave.

on hand- *nearby, available, ready, in one's possession*---We had some bread on hand so we made some sandwiches for the hiking trip.

on hand- *present*---She is always on hand when we need someone to help us.

on one`s feet- *recovering, getting better from sickness or trouble*
Our teacher was back on her feet shortly after she had her accident.

on one`s last legs- *failing, near the end*---My car is on its last legs and I will soon have to buy a new one.

on one`s toes- *alert, ready to act*---The speaker kept the audience on their toes by asking many interesting questions.

palm off- *sell or give something away by pretending it is something more valuable than it is, sell or give by trickery*---I think that the man palmed off a television set that doesn't work.

play into one`s hands- *be or do something that another person can use against one*---If you become angry at his extreme actions it will only play into his hands.

pull one`s leg- *fool someone with a humorous account of something, trick someone*---The man was pulling my leg when he told me that I would not be able to enter the movie theater after the movie had started.

put one's fingers on something- *locate precisely, remember exactly*---I was finally able to put my fingers on the problem and find someone to help me fix it.

put one's foot down- *object strongly, take firm action*---My sister finally put her foot down and stopped paying for the gas for her daughter's car.

put one's foot in one's mouth- *say something that is the wrong thing to say in a situation*---I put my foot in my mouth and said that I didn't like fish just before my friends served fish at their dinner party.

raise a hand- *do something, do one's share, help*---I am a little angry at my friend as he didn't raise a hand to help me clean up the mess in the kitchen.

shake a leg- *go fast, hurry*---"Please try and shake a leg. We are already late for the concert."

shoe is on the other foot- *opposite is true, places are changed*---He always criticized me for being late for meetings but now the shoe is on the other foot and he is the one who is late and is being criticized.

shot in the arm- *something inspiring or encouraging*---The latest opinion polls were a shot in the arm for the mayor's campaign to become re-elected.

stand on one's own two feet- *be independent*---My sister needs to do something to make her daughter stand on her own two feet.

step/tread on one`s toes- *do something that embarrasses or offends someone else*---I don't want to tread on my supervisor's toes as he has not been in a good mood lately.

(have) sticky fingers- *the habit of stealing things*---Everyone thinks that the new woman at work has sticky fingers as many things have been stolen recently.

sweep off one`s feet- *make someone have feelings of love or happiness too strong to control*---The woman was swept off her feet when she met the young man at the party.

tail between one`s legs- *state of feeling beaten, ashamed, or very obedient, as after a scolding or a whipping*---The salesman was forced to leave the office with his tail between his legs after he admitted telling a lie about his sales figures.

throw up one`s hands- *give up trying, admit that one cannot succeed*---I threw up my hands in frustration when I was unable to complete the telephone call.

try one`s hand- *make an inexperienced attempt at something*---I tried my hand at golf last summer but I didn't really like it.

turn on one`s heel- *turn around suddenly*---The dog suddenly turned on his heel and ran away.

turn thumbs down- *disapprove or reject, say no*---The building committee turned thumbs down on our plans to make the office larger.

twiddle one`s thumbs- *do nothing, be idle*---She has been twiddling her thumbs all year and is now unable to pass her courses at school.

twist/wrap someone around one`s little finger- *have complete control over*---My sister has her boss wrapped around her little finger and she is able to do anything that she wants.

twist one`s arm- *force someone, threaten someone to make him do something*---I had to twist my friend's arm to get him to let me borrow his car.

under one`s thumb- *obedient to someone, controlled by someone*---She has her husband under her thumb and never gives him any freedom at all.

up in arms- *very angry and wanting to fight, equipped with guns or weapons and ready to fight*---The students were up in arms over the school's plan to make them wear uniforms.

upper hand- *controlling power, advantage*---The union had the upper hand in the negotiations with the company

wait on hand and foot- *serve someone in every possible way, do everything for someone*---I always wait hand and foot on my sister when she comes to visit me.

wash one`s hands of- *withdraw from or refuse to be responsible for something*---I decided to wash my hands of the problem with the new secretary and let someone else deal with it.

with open arms- *warmly, eagerly, show that one is glad to see someone* The author was welcomed with open arms when he came to visit the city.

work one`s fingers to the bone- work very hard---The woman who lives next door worked her fingers to the bone in order to make enough money to feed her children.

Blood Idioms

bad blood (between people)- *anger or a bad relationship due to past problems with someone*---There has always been a lot of bad blood between the two supervisors.

blood is thicker than water- *family members are closer to one another than to others*---Blood is thicker than water and people usually support and help their family in times of trouble.

blood runs cold- *one is terrified or horrified*---My blood ran cold when I saw the poison spider on my bed.

blood, sweat, and tears- *great personal effort*---We put a lot of blood, sweat, and tears into fixing our old house.

blue blood- *the blood (family line) of a noble or aristocratic family*---Many blue bloods attended the opening of the new opera series.

curdle (someone's) blood- *frighten someone*---The sight of the accident scene curdled my blood.

draw blood- *make a wound that bleeds*---The older boxer was the first to draw blood during the boxing match.

(one's) flesh and blood- *a close relative (father, daughter, brother etc.), a living human body*---The man's own flesh and blood refused to help him when he needed money.

go for the jugular-*attack someone in a way that you know will harm them most (the jugular is a large vein in the neck)*---As soon as the political candidate was having problems the other candidates decided to go for the jugular and attack.

have (someone's) blood on one's hands- *be responsible for someone's death*---The driver of the car who was going too fast had the passengers' blood on his hands after two people were killed in an accident.

in cold blood- *without feeling*---The family was murdered in cold blood by a group of criminals.

in one's blood- *built into one's personality or character*---My cousin has music in her blood and she has always been very good at it.

like getting blood out of a stone- *very difficult to get something from someone or something*---It is like getting blood out of a stone to try and ask my friend for anything.

make (someone's) blood boil- *make someone very angry*---It makes my blood boil to think about what the supervisor did to one of the employees.

make (someone's) blood run cold- *shock or horrify someone*---It made my blood run cold when I saw the little boy run into the road.

new blood- *new members brought into a group, new workers in a company*---We have got lots of new blood in our club recently.

out for blood- *be very determined to defeat/punish someone, be very angry at someone*---My boss was out for blood when he discovered that someone had deleted some files on his computer.

smell blood- *realize that you have to defeat or harm an opponent and be eager to try and do this*---The reporters could smell blood when they began to investigate the politicians and the scandal.

sweat blood- *be very anxious and tense*---I began to sweat blood when I heard that some of our staff would be transferred to another city.

taste blood- *be able to harm an opponent and therefore want to try to do even more harm*---I could taste blood when I discovered the weak points of the supervisor who I hated.

too rich for (someone's) blood- *be too expensive for someone*---The holiday in the very expensive resort was too rich for our blood so we didn't go.

Body Idioms

able to breathe easily/freely again- *able to relax after a busy and stressful time*---I was able to breathe easily again when I knew that I would not miss my flight.

as broad as a barn door- *very broad/fat*---The flight attendant at the airport was as broad as a barn door.

as dry as a bone- *very dry*---The river bed was as dry as a bone at the end of the summer.

as soft as a baby's bottom- *very soft and smooth*---My new silk pajamas are as soft as a baby's bottom.

at each other's throats- *fight/argue all the time*---The two boys were at each other's throats as soon as they entered the room.

at the top of one`s lungs- *with a very loud voice*---I yelled at the top of my lungs to get the man's attention.

back-to-back- *next to each other and touching backs*---The students were sitting back-to-back as they did their exercises for the gym class.

bad blood (between people)- *anger or a bad relationship due to past problems with someone*---There has always been a lot of bad blood between the two supervisors.

bare bones (of something)- *the most basic and important parts of something*---The company had to restructure and most services were cut to the bare bones of the operation.

behind one`s back- *do something when one is absent or without one's knowledge, secretly*---I don't like people who talk behind my back.

(go/be) belly up- *(a company) fails or goes bankrupt*---The small video store near my house went belly-up last month.

blood is thicker than water- *family members are closer to one another than to others*---Blood is thicker than water and people usually support and help their family in times of trouble.

blood runs cold- *one is terrified or horrified*---My blood ran cold when I saw the poison spider on my bed.

blood, sweat, and tears- *great personal effort*---We put a lot of blood, sweat, and tears into fixing our old house.

blue blood- *the blood (family line) of a noble or aristocratic family*---Many blue bloods attended the opening of the new opera series.

a body blow- *something that causes something to be badly damaged or destroyed*---The small food store was hit with a body blow when the large supermarket moved in next door.

a bone of contention- *something that people disagree about*
The issue of working on Saturday evenings is a bone of contention between the store and the workers.

break into a cold sweat (about something)- *become nervous or frightened about something*---I broke into a cold sweat when I went to tell my teacher what I had done wrong.

break one`s back/neck (to do something)- *do all one possibly can, work very hard to do something*---I broke my neck to try and get the report finished on time.

a breath of fresh air- *someone brings new ideas/new energy/new ways of doing something to a situation*---The new manager is a breath of fresh air around those who never like to change anything.

not breathe a word (about someone or something)- *keep a secret about someone or something*---"Please don't breathe a word about my new job to my supervisor."

breathe down (someone`s) neck-*watch someone closely (often by standing right behind them), pressure someone to do something*---My boss

has been breathing down my neck all day to try and get me to finish the report.

breathe easy/easier- *relax after a busy and stressful time*---I could breathe easy when I finished my essay and gave it to my teacher.

breathe one's last- *to die, breathe one's last breath before dying*---The elderly man breathed his last late yesterday evening.

broad in the beam- *wide hips or large buttocks*---The woman is broad in the beam but she doesn't worry about it at all.

a bundle of nerves- *someone who is very nervous and anxious*---I was a bundle of nerves after I finished studying for my exams.

bust a gut (to do something)- *work very hard, strain oneself to do something*---I had to bust a gut to get my work done before the weekend.

by the sweat of one's brow- *by one's hard work or effort*---The restaurant owner built his business by the sweat of his brow.

can't stomach (someone or something)- *dislike someone or something very much*---I can't stomach the new woman who I have to work with.

carry one's (own) weight- *do one's share of something*---Everyone in the group had to carry his or her own weight during the project.

carry the weight of the world on one's shoulders-*appear to be dealing with all the problems in the whole world*---My friend has a lot of stress and thinks that he is carrying the weight of the world on his shoulders.

catch one's breath- *return to normal breathing after breathing very hard*--I stopped at the top of the stairs to catch my breath.

chilled to the bone- *very cold*---I was chilled to the bone when I came out of the cold lake.

close to the bone- *something (a story/remark) that is embarrassing or upsetting*---The remarks of my boss hit close to the bone when he began to criticize my work habits.

contemplate one's navel- *spend a lot of time thinking about one's own problems rather than being concerned about more important things*---I spent the summer contemplating my navel and didn't do a thing.

cover one's back- *do something to protect yourself from criticism or future blame*---I was very careful to cover my back when dealing with the lawyers.

a crick in one's back/neck- *a painful cramp in one's back/neck*---I woke up this morning with a crick in my neck.

curdle (someone's) blood- *frighten someone*---The sight of the accident scene curdled my blood.

cut a fine figure- *dress and look good*---I cut a fine figure as I walked through the doors to interview for the job.

cut/slit one`s (own) throat-*experience certain failure, do something that will cause problems now or in the future*---He is cutting his own throat if he doesn't make an effort to find a new job quickly.

cut/pare (something) to the bone- *cut down severely (on something)*---The company had no money so all of the extra expenses were cut to the bone.

dead from the neck up- *very stupid*---My boss seems to be dead from the neck up.

difficult to stomach (someone or something)-*be unable to accept someone, be unable to accept something that you think is unpleasant or wrong*---It is difficult to stomach my friend when she begins to complain about her apartment.

Don't hold your breath.- *Don't stop breathing to wait for something (because it will never happen)*---"Don't hold your breath," I said when my friend asked when he would be able to borrow our friend's car.

down to the bone- *entirely, to the core*---The rain and snow chilled me right down to the bone.

draw blood- *make a wound that bleeds*---The older boxer was the first to draw blood during the boxing match.

drop/dump (something) in (someone's) lap- *give a problem that you have to someone else to solve*---My supervisor dumped some extra work in my lap just before I was going to go home.

eyes are bigger than one's stomach- *take more food than one can eat*---My eyes were bigger than my stomach when I went to the buffet table and put too much food on my plate.

fall/drop into one's lap-*an opportunity or chance comes to you by chance and good luck and without any effort on your part*---The chance to go on the training course dropped into my lap suddenly last weekend.

feel (something) in one's bones- *sense something, have an intuition about something*---I feel it in my bones that I am not going to get the job that I want.

(one's) flesh and blood- *a close relative (father, daughter, brother etc.), a living human body*---The man's own flesh and blood refused to help him when he needed money.

flex one's muscles- *do something that shows that you have power and intend to use it*---The new president of our company was flexing his muscles when he threatened to close one of the factories.

get/have a frog in one's throat- *get soreness in your throat that prevents you from talking well*---I got a frog in my throat just as I answered the phone to talk to my professor.

get/have a lump in one's throat-*feel like there in something in your throat as if you were going to cry*---I got a lump in my throat as I listened to the tragic story of the woman's family.
get off (someone`s) back- *stop criticizing or nagging someone*---I wish that my mother would get off my back about trying to find a better job.

get on (someone's) nerves- *irritate someone*---The constant complaints of my coworkers get on my nerves.

get (someone's) back up- *make someone become angry*---I got my friend's back up when I again asked her to borrow her notes from school.

get (something) off one's chest- *tell something that has been bothering you*---I talked to my parents and I was able to get some things that were bothering me off my chest.

get (something) out of one's system- *eliminate some food or medicine out of one's body, get rid of the desire to do something (usually by doing what you want to do)*---My friend went travelling last year and finally got travelling out of her system. Now she is happy to stay home and work.

get the cold shoulder (from someone)- *be ignored, be rejected*---Yesterday, one of the women who I work with gave me the cold shoulder all day.

get under (someone`s) skin- *bother/irritate someone*---She is beginning to get under my skin with her constant complaining about the noise.

gird up one's loins- *get ready to do something that will be difficult*---I got ready to gird up my loins and begin to work on some of my problem accounts.

give (someone) the cold shoulder- *ignore someone, reject someone*---The office staff gave me the cold shoulder when I did not go to the farewell party.

give (someone) the shirt off one's back- *be very generous to someone*---My friend is the most generous person that I know and he will be happy to give you the shirt off his back.

go for the jugular-*attack someone in a way that you know will harm them most (the jugular is a large vein in the neck)*---As soon as the political candidate was having problems the other candidates decided to go for the jugular and attack.

goose bumps- *the bumpy skin (like a goose) that one gets because of excitement or fear*---I got goose bumps when the woman began to talk about her sick child.

grab (someone) by the throat- *a performance/book/idea makes one feel very interested/excited/frightened*---The ballet performance grabbed the audience by the throat and everyone left the auditorium speechless.

grate on (someone's) nerves- *annoy/bother someone*---The woman who I work with grates on my nerves. She is very irritating.

a gut feeling/reaction/response- *a personal/intuitive feeling and response*---I had a gut feeling that my friend was not going to come to our meeting place at the right time.

hard to stomach (someone or something)-*be unable to accept something or do something that you think is unpleasant or wrong*---I find some of my classmates and their attitude to studying hard to stomach.

hardly have time to breathe- *be very busy*---I hardly had time to breathe while I was preparing for the summer barbecue.

hate (someone's) guts- *hate someone very much*---I think that my neighbor hates my guts. He will never say hello to me.

have a chip on one's shoulder- *have a tendency to try to get in a conflict with others*---Our supervisor has a chip on his shoulder and is not an easy person to work with.

have broad shoulders- *have the ability to work hard and take on responsibilities and accept criticism (because you are strong with broad shoulders)*---The man has broad shoulders and does much more than his share of work in our company.

have/get butterflies in one`s stomach- *have/get a feeling of fear or anxiety in one's stomach*---The little boy had butterflies in his stomach when he had to give the speech in front of the class.

have one's back to the wall/up against the wall- *be in a defensive position*---I have my back to the wall at work and I must decide how to deal with the criticism that I am receiving.

have (someone's) blood on one's hands- *be responsible for someone's death*---The driver of the car who was going too fast had the passengers' blood on his hands after two people were killed in an accident.

have (someone's) hide- *scold or punish someone (a hide is the skin of an animal)*---The woman promised to have the little boy's hide if he didn't behave well.

not have the stomach for (something)---*have no desire to do something because you think that it is unpleasant or wrong*---I do not have the stomach to talk with my friend about his work and financial problems.

head and shoulders above (someone or something)- *be superior to someone or something*---Our soccer coach is head and shoulders above the other coaches in the city.

hold one`s breath- *stop breathing for a moment, stop doing something and wait until something happens*---I held my breath and waited to see if my name had been called for an interview with the movie company.

huff and puff- *breathe very hard*---I was huffing and puffing when I reached the top of the stairs.

in cold blood- *without feeling*---The family was murdered in cold blood by a group of criminals.

(all) in one breath- *something spoken rapidly without stopping to breathe* I told my friend all in one breath what had happened at the party.

in one's blood- *built into one's personality or character*---My cousin has music in her blood and she has always been very good at it.

in the flesh- *really present, in person*---I finally was able to see my favorite movie actor in the flesh.

in the same breath- *almost at the same time*---My friend was complaining about her teacher but in the same breath she said that she wanted to continue with the class.

joined at the hip- *two people spend all their time together*---The two boys are joined at the hip and never spend any time apart.

jump down (someone`s) throat- *suddenly become very angry at someone*---The man's wife jumped down his throat when he came home late for the third day in a row.

jump out of one`s skin- *be badly frightened, be very surprised*---I almost jumped out of my skin when I saw my boyfriend at the movie theater with another girl.

keep body and soul together- *keep alive, survive*---He has been working very hard to try and keep body and soul together after his illness.

a kink in one's neck- *a cramp in one's neck that causes pain*---I have a kink in my neck and it hurts every time that I turn my head.

know (something) in one's bones- *know and sense something, have an intuition about something*---I know it in my bones that I am not going to pass my English exam.

know where all the bodies are buried- *know all the important details and secrets about something*---Our new boss knows where all the bodies are buried in our company and knows how to keep a secret well.

land in one's lap- *additional work comes to you and you now have to deal with it*---Several resignations from our company landed in the lap of the personnel director last Friday.

like getting blood out of a stone- *very difficult to get something from someone or something*---It is like getting blood out of a stone to try and ask my friend for anything.

look over one's shoulder- *be worried that something dangerous or bad may happen to you*---I always look over my shoulder when I am walking next to a construction site.

make a clean breast of (something)- *get something off one's chest, confess something*---I talked to my supervisor and I tried to make a clean breast of my past problems at the company.

make no bones about (something)- *make no mistake about something, do not doubt something*---"Make no bones about it; I am not going to lend my friend any more money."

make (someone's) blood boil- *make someone very angry*---It makes my blood boil to think about what the supervisor did to one of the employees.

make (someone's) blood run cold- *shock or horrify someone*---It made my blood run cold when I saw the little boy run into the road.

make (someone's) flesh crawl- *become frightened so that your skin feels funny or you get goose bumps*---The movie was very weird and from the beginning it made my flesh crawl.

a millstone around (someone's) neck- *a burden or handicap for someone*---My parents' condominium is a millstone around their neck and I hope that they can sell it.

not move a muscle- *do not move at all*---I did not move a muscle when the large dog approached me on the street.

neck and neck- *exactly even in a race or contest*---The two horses were running neck and neck at the end of the race.

new blood- *new members brought into a group, new workers in a company*---We have got lots of new blood in our club recently.

No sweat!- *No problem! No difficulty!*---It was no sweat for me to finish work early and then drive my friend to the airport.

off one`s back- *not bother someone, remove someone or something as an annoyance*---I wish my boss would get off my back and stop bothering me.

off one`s chest- *remove something so it doesn't bother one anymore*
I talked to my friend for a long time and was able to get some problems off my chest.

on (someone`s) back- *constantly criticizing someone, pressuring someone*

My sister is always on her daughter's back to clean up her room.

on (someone's) shoulders- *someone's responsibility*---I don't want to have the failure of the project on my shoulders.

out for blood- *be very determined to defeat/punish someone, be very angry at someone*---My boss was out for blood when he discovered that someone had deleted some files on his computer.

out of breath- *breathing fast and hard*---I was out of breath when I ran to catch the train.

over my dead body- *not if I can stop you*---I told my friend that I will lend him money only over my dead body.

a pain in the neck- *an annoying or bothersome person or event*---The customer is a pain in the neck and is always complaining about something.

a pat on the back- *praise, congratulations, encouragement*---The man was given a pat on the back for his efforts to stop pollution in the river.

play one's cards close to one's chest- *negotiate in a careful and private manner*---I played my cards close to my chest when I went to talk to my supervisor about changing jobs.

press the flesh- *(a politician) shakes hands with people in order to become more popular*---The politician spent most of the weekend pressing the flesh in the shopping mall.

pull one's (own) weight- *do one's share of something*---The woman at the bank never pulls her own weight so nobody likes her.

put flesh on (something)- *add details to something so that it becomes clearer and more detailed*---I worked all weekend to try and put flesh on my ideas for a new company education committee.

put one's back into (something)- *use great physical or mental energy to do something*---We put our backs into trying to move the freezer out of the basement.

put one's shoulder to the wheel- *get busy and do some work*---We must put our shoulders to the wheel and get our work done on time.

risk one's neck (to do something)- *risk harm in order to do something*---The fireman risked his neck to save the young child.

rub elbows/shoulders with (someone)- *be in the same place as others, meet and mix with others*---We went to the party in order to rub shoulders with some interesting artists.

save one`s breath- *keep silent because talking will not do any good*---"You can save your breath and not bother talking to him. He never listens to anyone."

save (someone`s) neck/skin- *save someone from danger/trouble/ embarrassment*---The worker tried to save his own neck without thinking of any other people.

say (something) under one's breath- *say something so softly that almost nobody can hear it*---I think that the clerk in the store said something under her breath about me.

scratch (someone`s) back- *do a favor for someone in the hope that they will do something for you*---If you scratch the supervisor's back he will help you when you need help.

shoot from the hip- *speak directly and frankly, fire a gun that is held at one's side and against one's hip*---The manager always shoots from the hip and everyone likes her because of that.

a shoulder to cry on- *someone who you can tell about your problems and ask for sympathy and advice*---I gave my friend a shoulder to cry on when I met him at the coffee shop.

shoulder to shoulder- *side by side, with a shared purpose*---The children were standing shoulder to shoulder during the exercise class.

shove/force/ram (something) down (someone`s) throat-*force someone to do or agree to something that they don't want or like*---The workers were

angry because the boss tried to shove the new regulations about uniforms down their throats.

a skeleton in the closet- *a hidden and shocking secret*---The politician had a skeleton in the closet that he did not want anyone to know about.

skin and bones- *a person or animal that is very thin/skinny*---The dog was skin and bones after his owner stopped giving him food.

skin-deep- *only on the surface, not having any deep or honest meaning*---I believe that the speaker's interest in the environment is only skin-deep.

smell blood- *realize that you have to defeat or harm an opponent and be eager to try and do this*---The reporters could smell blood when they began to investigate the politicians and the scandal.

soaked to the skin- *one's clothing is wet right through to the skin*---I was soaked to the skin after walking in the rain for only a few minutes.

split one's sides (with laughter)- *laugh so hard that one's sides almost split*---I split my sides with laughter when I heard the story about my friend.

stab (someone) in the back- *betray someone*---My friend stabbed me in the back although I made an effort to help him get a job.

stick in (someone's) throat/craw-*an idea or situation is difficult for you to accept and irritates or displeases you*---The customer's attitude sticks in my throat and I am always happy to see him leave.

stick one`s neck out (for someone or something)-*do something dangerous or risky for someone*---My friend will never stick his neck out to try and help other people.

stick to one's ribs- *food that lasts a long time and fills one up*---The rice and beans stuck to my ribs and I wasn't hungry for a long time.

straight from the shoulder- *an open and honest way of speaking*---He was speaking straight from the shoulder when he told the workers about the possible factory closing.

sweat blood- *be very anxious and tense*---I began to sweat blood when I heard that some of our staff would be transferred to another city.

sweat it out- *wait patiently until something bad or unpleasant ends*---We had to sweat it out in a small town with no food while our car was being repaired.

take (someone's) breath away-*overwhelm someone with beauty or grandeur, cause someone to be out of breath*---The beauty of the mountain lake took my breath away.

take (someone's) pulse- *measure the frequency of the beats of a person's pulse*---The ambulance driver took the pulse of the woman in the car accident.

tan (someone's) hide- *spank/beat someone*---The angry mother threatened to tan her child's hide.

taste blood- *be able to harm an opponent and therefore want to try to do even more harm*---I could taste blood when I discovered the weak points of the supervisor who I hated.

tear/rip (someone) limb from limb- *attack someone in a violent way*---The dogs attacked the cat and tore it limb from limb.

thick-skinned- *insensitive, not easily upset or hurt*---You really must be thick-skinned if you decide to get involved in politics.

thin-skinned- *easily upset or hurt, very sensitive*---My friend is rather thin-skinned and is always upset about something that someone may have said to her.

a thorn in (someone's) side- *a constant bother or annoyance to someone*---The teacher is a thorn in the principal's side and is always complaining about something.

throw one's weight around- *give orders, attempt to boss people around*---The new supervisor likes to throw his weight around the company.

time to catch one's breath- *enough time to relax or behave normally*---I didn't have time to catch my breath while I was getting ready for the convention.

to the bone- *entirely, to the core*---He was wet to the bone after staying out in the rain for two hours.

too rich for (someone's) blood- *be too expensive for someone*---The holiday in the very expensive resort was too rich for our blood so we didn't go.

touch/hit/strike a raw nerve- *upset someone by talking about a subject that upsets or embarrasses them*---The criticism from the supervisor touched a raw nerve in the woman at our office.

turn one`s back on (someone or something)- *refuse to help someone in trouble or need*---The woman turned her back on her friend when the friend asked her for some money.

turn (someone`s) stomach - *make one feel sick, disgust someone*---The sight of the dead dog on the road turned my stomach.

up to one's neck/ears/eyeballs (in something)---*having a lot of something, much involved/ busy with something*---I am up to my neck in work at the moment and won't be able to attend the dinner tonight.

vent one's spleen- *get rid of one's feelings of anger by attacking someone or something*---I went for a coffee with one of my coworkers and she spent the whole time venting her spleen about her job.

wait with bated breath- *wait anxiously for something*---I waited with bated breath for the results of my exams.

warts and all- *including all one's faults and disadvantages*---I opened my heart to my friend and told him everything - warts and all.

waste one's breath- *waste one's time talking, talk in vain*---I think that I will be wasting my breath to try and ask my parents to use the car this weekend.

wet one's whistle- *have a drink (one's whistle is one's throat)*---I stopped at a small cafe near the beach in order to wet my whistle.

with every (other) breath- *saying something repeatedly or continually* My friend always tells me with every other breath that he does not like my girlfriend.

words stick in one's throat- *one can hardly speak because he or she is so overcome by emotion*---I tried to ask the girl in my class out for a date but the words stuck in my throat and I couldn't say a thing.

wring (someone's) neck- *be extremely angry at someone*---I plan to wring my friend's neck for breaking my new laptop computer.

yellow-bellied- *extremely timid, cowardly*---Everyone thinks that the new boss handled the matter in a yellow-bellied manner.

a yoke around (someone's) neck- *a burden, something that oppresses people*---The legal problems of my friend were a yoke around his neck which he wanted to deal with.

You scratch my back and I'll scratch yours.- *You do a favor for me and I'll do a favor for you*---"You scratch my back and I'll scratch yours," I said to my customer as we tried to reach a new sales agreement for our product.

Back Idioms

back-to-back- *next to each other and touching backs*---The students were sitting back-to-back as they did their exercises for the gym class.

behind one`s back- *do something when one is absent or without one's knowledge, secretly*---I don't like people who talk behind my back.

break one`s back/neck (to do something)- *do all one possibly can, work very hard to do something*---I broke my neck to try and get the report finished on time.

cover one's back- *do something to protect yourself from criticism or future blame*---I was very careful to cover my back when dealing with the lawyers.

a crick in one's back/neck- *a painful cramp in one's back/neck*---I woke up this morning with a crick in my neck.

get off (someone`s) back- *stop criticizing or nagging someone*---I wish that my mother would get off my back about trying to find a better job.

get (someone's) back up- *make someone become angry*---I got my friend's back up when I again asked her to borrow her notes from school.

give (someone) the shirt off one's back- *be very generous to someone*
My friend is the most generous person that I know and he will be happy to give you the shirt off his back.

have one's back to the wall/up against the wall- *be in a defensive position*---I have my back to the wall at work and I must decide how to deal with the criticism that I am receiving.

off one`s back- *not bother someone, remove someone or something as an annoyance*---I wish my boss would get off my back and stop bothering me.

on (someone`s) back- *constantly criticizing someone, pressuring someone*
My sister is always on her daughter's back to clean up her room.

a pat on the back- *praise, congratulations, encouragement*---The man was given a pat on the back for his efforts to stop pollution in the river.

put one's back into (something)- *use great physical or mental energy to do something*---We put our backs into trying to move the freezer out of the basement.

scratch (someone`s) back- *do a favor for someone in the hope that they will do something for you*---If you scratch the supervisor's back he will help you when you need help.

stab (someone) in the back- *betray someone*---My friend stabbed me in the back although I made an effort to help him get a job.

turn one`s back on (someone or something)- *refuse to help someone in trouble or need*---The woman turned her back on her friend when the friend asked her for some money.

You scratch my back and I'll scratch yours.- *You do a favor for me and I'll do a favor for you*---"You scratch my back and I'll scratch yours," I said to my customer as we tried to reach a new sales agreement for our product.

Bone Idioms

as dry as a bone- *very dry*---The river bed was as dry as a bone at the end of the summer.

bare bones (of something)- *the most basic and important parts of something*---The company had to restructure and most services were cut to the bare bones of the operation.

a bone of contention- *something that people disagree about*---The issue of working on Saturday evenings is a bone of contention between the store and the workers.

chilled to the bone- *very cold*---I was chilled to the bone when I came out of the cold lake.

close to the bone- *something (a story/remark) that is embarrassing or upsetting*---The remarks of my boss hit close to the bone when he began to criticize my work habits.

cut/pare (something) to the bone- *cut down severely (on something)*---The company had no money so all of the extra expenses were cut to the bone.

down to the bone- *entirely, to the core*---The rain and snow chilled me right down to the bone.

feel (something) in one's bones- *sense something, have an intuition about something*---I feel it in my bones that I am not going to get the job that I want.

know (something) in one's bones- *know and sense something, have an intuition about something*---I know it in my bones that I am not going to pass my English exam.

make no bones about (something)- *make no mistake about something, do not doubt something*---"Make no bones about it, I am not going to lend my friend any more money."

a skeleton in the closet- *a hidden and shocking secret*---The politician had a skeleton in the closet that he did not want anyone to know about.

skin and bones- *a person or animal that is very thin/skinny*---The dog was skin and bones after his owner stopped giving him food.

to the bone- *entirely, to the core*---He was wet to the bone after staying out in the rain for two hours.

Breath Idioms

able to breathe easily/freely again- *able to relax after a busy and stressful time*---I was able to breathe easily again when I knew that I would not miss my flight.

at the top of one`s lungs- *with a very loud voice*---I yelled at the top of my lungs to get the man's attention.

a breath of fresh air- *someone brings new ideas/new energy/new ways of doing something to a situation*---The new manager is a breath of fresh air around those who never like to change anything.

not breathe a word (about someone or something)- *keep a secret about someone or something*---"Please don't breathe a word about my new job to my supervisor."

breathe down (someone`s) neck-*watch someone closely (often by standing right behind them), pressure someone to do something*---My boss has been breathing down my neck all day to try and get me to finish the report.

breathe easy/easier- *relax after a busy and stressful time*---I could breathe easy when I finished my essay and gave it to my teacher.

breathe one's last- *to die, breathe one's last breath before dying*---The elderly man breathed his last late yesterday evening.

catch one's breath- *return to normal breathing after breathing very hard*---I stopped at the top of the stairs to catch my breath.

Don't hold your breath.- *Don't stop breathing to wait for something (because it will never happen)*---"Don't hold your breath," I said when my friend asked when he would be able to borrow our friend's car.

hardly have time to breathe- *be very busy*---I hardly had time to breathe while I was preparing for the summer barbecue.

hold one`s breath- *stop breathing for a moment, stop doing something and wait until something happens*---I held my breath and waited to see if my name had been called for an interview with the movie company.

huff and puff- *breathe very hard*---I was huffing and puffing when I reached the top of the stairs.

(all) in one breath- *something spoken rapidly without stopping to breathe* ---I told my friend all in one breath what had happened at the party.

in the same breath- *almost at the same time*---My friend was complaining about her teacher but in the same breath she said that she wanted to continue with the class.

out of breath- *breathing fast and hard*---I was out of breath when I ran to catch the train.

save one`s breath- *keep silent because talking will not do any good*--- "You can save your breath and not bother talking to him. He never listens to anyone."

say (something) under one's breath- *say something so softly that almost nobody can hear it*---I think that the clerk in the store said something under her breath about me.

take (someone's) breath away-*overwhelm someone with beauty or grandeur, cause someone to be out of breath*---The beauty of the mountain lake took my breath away.

time to catch one's breath- *enough time to relax or behave normally*---I didn't have time to catch my breath while I was getting ready for the convention.

wait with bated breath- *wait anxiously for something*---I waited with bated breath for the results of my exams.

waste one's breath- *waste one's time talking, talk in vain*---I think that I will be wasting my breath to try and ask my parents to use the car this weekend.

with every (other) breath- *saying something repeatedly or continually*---
My friend always tells me with every other breath that he does not like my girlfriend.

Business Idioms

across the board- *including everyone or everything*---The computer company decided to give the workers an across-the-board increase in their salary.

(to sell something) at a loss- *(to sell something) and lose money*---We were forced to sell the computers at a loss.

to bail a company out- *to help or rescue a company with financial problems*---The government decided to bail out the bank in order to maintain stability in the economy.

a ball park figure/estimate- *a rough estimate or figure*---The contractor gave us a ball park figure for the cost of repairing the new building.

bang for the buck- *value for the money spent*---We were able to get a big bang for our buck when we advertised on the Internet.

banker's hours- *short work hours (similar to when a bank is open)*---My sister's husband owns his own company and works banker's hours most days.

to bankroll someone- *to supply someone with money, to finance someone* ---The movie actor bankrolled his son while he was producing his first movie.

a bean counter- *an accountant*---We asked the bean counters to look over the figures in the new budget.

a big gun/big cheese/big wheel/big wig- *an important person, a leader*---The new director was a big wheel in his previous company but is not so important now.

the bottom falls out/drops out- *to fall below an earlier low price*---When the bottom fell out of the coffee market many companies had to stop doing business.

the bottom line- *the total, the final figure on a balance sheet, results*---When we examined the bottom line of the company we decided not to invest in it.

the bottom line- *the central issue of a discussion*---My friends wanted to open a small restaurant but for me the bottom line was that if we didn't do some research I didn't want to invest any money.

to bottom out- *to reach the lowest or worst point of something*---The value of the stock has begun to bottom out and should soon begin to increase in value.

the boys in the backroom- *a group of men making decisions behind the scenes*---The boys in the backroom told us that we must close down the factory as soon as possible.

to break even- *to have expenses equal to profits*---After only three months the company was able to break even and started to make a profit.

a budget squeeze/crunch- *a situation where there is not enough money in the budget*---We have been going through a severe budget squeeze at our company and must stop wasting money.

to buy a stake in something- *to buy part ownership of a company or other enterprise*---The large bank is planning to buy a stake in the small stock trading company.

to buy off (someone)- *to use a gift or money to divert someone from their duty or purpose (sometimes similar to a bribe and therefore illegal)*---The land developer tried to buy off the politician but he was not successful.

to buy out (someone or something)- *to buy the ownership or a majority share of something*---The large company decided to buy out the small textile company.

by a long shot- *by a big difference*---The soap company beat out the bids of the other companies by a long shot.

a calculated risk- *an action that may fail but has a good chance to succeed*---They took a calculated risk when they put the new computer screen on the market.

to call a meeting to order- *to start a meeting*---Our supervisor called the meeting to order when everyone arrived in the conference room.

a captain of industry- *a top corporation officer*---The president of our company was a captain of industry and after he retired he was appointed to many government boards.

to carry over- *to transfer (a figure) from one column or book to another*--- Our company is facing difficult times and we must carry over last year's losses to this year.

to carry over (something)- *to save or postpone for another time*---We decided to carry over the sale to the Monday after the national holiday.

to carry the day- *to win complete support*---The president's new idea carried the day and everyone supported him with enthusiasm.

to carry through with/on (something)- *to put into action*---The steel company carried through with their plan to restructure operations.

to close out- *to sell the whole of something, to sell all the goods*---They decided to close out the store and sell the remaining stock very cheap.

to close the books- *to stop taking orders, to end a bookkeeping period* They usually close the books at the end of December every year.

to close up shop- *to stop doing business (for a variety of reasons - not only financial reasons)*---The university bookstore had to close up shop when the rents were increased.

(to make) a cold call- *to visit or telephone a potential but unknown customer from a list of people*---When he first started to work at his company he was asked to make cold calls from the telephone book.

to come down in price- *to lower the price of one's product*---We were forced to come down in price in order to sell our target number of cars for the month.

to come on strong- *to overwhelm someone with very strong language or personality*---The salesman came on strong at the meeting and angered the other members of the team.

a company man- *a person who always works hard and agrees with his employers or company*---My father was a company man and always put in an extra effort for his company.

a company town- *a town dominated by one industry or company*---When the coal mine closed the company town faced severe economic times.

to crunch numbers- *to do mathematical calculations*---Our accountant loves to crunch numbers and is one of the top managers in our company.

to cut a deal- *to make a business arrangement or contract*---I was able to cut a deal with the contractor and we paid very little for our new kitchen.

to cut back- *to use fewer or use less of something*---The company has been cutting back on entertainment expenses recently.

to cut corners- *to economize*---We have been forced to economize on stationary expenses during these severe economic times.

to cut off- *to interrupt or stop*---The speech by the president was cut off when the electricity went off in the building.

to cut one's losses- *to do something in order to stop losing money/time etc*---We should sell the old machinery as soon as possible and try to cut our losses.

to deliver the goods- *to succeed in doing a good job of what is expected*---The new manager is not very popular but he is able to deliver the goods.

to double-check (something)- *to check something again to confirm if it is correct*---We were unable to double-check the costs of the new products before the price list was printed.

to draw up a contract- *to make/draft a contract*---The lawyer spent several hours drawing up a contract.

the face value (of something)- *the official value or worth of something*---Although the face value of the postage stamp was very low it sold at the auction for much money.

fair play- *justice, equal and correct action toward someone*---The company is very good to work for as they always use fair play when they are bargaining with their employees.

to figure (something) out- *to find an answer by thinking about something*---Everyone is trying to figure out what our boss is going to do with the new equipment.

to fill the bill- *to be just what is needed*---That new machine should fill the bill for what we need to finish the job.

(to have one's) finger in the pie- *to be involved in something, to receive money for something*---The new manager has his finger in the pie of many small businesses.

to float someone a loan- *to loan someone money*---I wanted the bank to float me a loan so that I could buy a new car.

to gain ground- *to go forward, to make progress*---Our company has been gaining ground in its attempt to be the best in the industry.

to get a break- *to get an opportunity or good deal*---We were able to get a break on the price of the paint and saved much money.

to get a raise- *to get an increase in one's salary*---My sister worked hard and quickly got a raise in her new job.

to get off the ground- *to make a successful beginning*---We were unable to get the new product off the ground but we will try again next year.

to give (someone) the green light- *to give permission to go ahead with a project*---Our boss gave us the green light to begin work on the new sales campaign.

to go belly up- *to go out of business because of financial problems*---The small computer company went belly up several months ago.

to go over the books- *to check and analyze the accounting records of a company*---We hired an outside accountant to go over the books.

to go public- *to sell shares of a privately owned company to the public*---The stock of the Internet Company rose very quickly after they went public.

to go through with (something)- *to finish, to do as planned or as agreed* ---We have decided not to go through with our plans to build the new product until we solve several problems.

to hang out one's shingle- *to open one's own business (usually as a professional)*---Our neighbor decided to hang out his shingle as a dentist soon after he finished school.

a hard sell- *a way of selling something that is very aggressive and uses much pressure*---The car salesman was giving us a hard sell so we went to another dealer.

to have a stake in something- *to have part ownership of a company or other business*---The oil company has a stake in the new undersea oil exploration company.

to have the floor- *to have permission to speak in a meeting*---The president had the floor for almost an hour during the meeting.

heads will roll- *someone will be punished*---Heads will roll when our boss learns about the money that we have lost.

to hold a meeting- *to conduct a meeting*---We plan to hold a meeting next week to discuss the problems with our new product.

in black and white- *in writing*---The company refused to deal with the customer's complaints until they were in black and white.

(to be) in charge of (someone or something)-*to be in control of someone or something, to be responsible for someone or something*---My sister has been in charge of buying supplies at her company for many years.

(to be) in short supply- *to not have enough, to be less than the amount or number needed*---Experienced computer programmers are in short supply in our company.

(to be) in stock- *to have something ready to sell or use*---The store didn't have any printer ribbons in stock.

(to be) in the black- *to be successful or to be making money*---The new company has been in the black for many years now.

in the long run- *over a long period of time*---The company has been losing money recently but in the long run they should do very well.

(to be) in the loop- *to be involved or taking part in a job or in information sharing with one's colleagues etc*---I began to work in the evenings and was no longer in the loop at our company.

(to be) in the market for (something)- *to be ready to buy something*--- We have been in the market for a new computer for a long time.

(to be) in the red- *to be losing money, to be unprofitable*---The company has been in the red since the price of oil began to rise rapidly.

(to be) in the works- *to be in preparation, to be in the process of being planned or developed*---The camera company has a new automatic camera in the works but nobody knows about it.

to jack up (the price of something)- *to make a price higher*---The steel company decided to jack up the price of steel at the beginning of the year.

to keep books- *to keep records of money gained and spent*---The new sales manager has no experience to keep books and has made many mistakes.

to keep track of (something)- *to keep a count or record of something, to stay informed*---They have been making a great effort to keep track of the number of visitors to their store.

a kickback- *an amount of money paid illegally for favorable treatment*--- The construction company was giving kickbacks to the local politicians.

to knock down the price- *to lower the price*---I bargained hard so that I could knock down the price of the stereo.

to land an account- *to acquire an account*---The salesman landed a large account on his first day of work.

to lay something on the table- *to present a matter for discussion*---I went to the meeting and laid my concerns about the new product on the table.

lead time- *the time available to prepare for an event or put a product on the market*---The lead time to get a book published is sometimes very long.

a line of products- *a group/category of products that are similar to each other*---Our company will introduce a new line of products in the autumn.

liquid assets- *property or belongings that can easily be converted into cash*---The company had to sell some of its liquid assets in order to raise cash.

to make a go of (something)- *to produce good results, to succeed*--- Although he works very hard in his small business he cannot make a go of it and may soon go out of business.

to make an offer- *to make a financial proposal for a product or service*--- We want to buy the house so we plan to make an offer on Saturday.

to make money hand over fist- *to make a lot of money on a continuous basis*---The small ice cream shop has been making money hand over fist since it first opened.

to mean business- *to be serious*---Our boss means business when he tells everyone to work harder.

to move to do something- *to propose to do something*---I moved to have another meeting next week when we were able to gather more information.

a number cruncher- *an accountant, someone who works with numbers*---

Our president is a good number cruncher and understands the finances of our company.

(to be) on hand- *to be in one's possession, to be ready*---We didn't have enough supplies on hand and were unable to finish the job.

(to buy something) on credit- *to buy something without paying cash*--- My friend had no money so he decided to buy the furniture on credit.

(to be/go) on the block- *to be for sale, to go on sale*---As soon as we bought the company we began to put some of the equipment on the block.

out-of-pocket (expenses)- *the direct expenses that one must personally pay*---I was out-of-pocket a lot of money when I decided to change jobs.

(to be) out of the loop-*to be not involved or taking part in a job or in information sharing with one's colleagues etc*---I was out of the loop during the negotiations and did not know what was going on.

to outsource (something)- *to use outside sources rather than those within a company or its facilities*---The manufacturing company outsourced many of their products to several cities in Asia.

to overnight (something)- *to send a document or package somewhere for delivery the next day*---We decided to overnight the new contract to our supplier.

to pay off- *to make a profit, to be successful/beneficial*---A good education usually pays off over a long period of time.

to pay off a loan- *to finish paying back the money that one has borrowed from a bank/store etc*---The furniture manufacturer was unable to pay off their loan so they went out of business.

a piece/slice of the action- *a share in the activity or the profits of something*---The inventor wanted a large piece of the action from the new computer that he had invented.

to plug a product- *to promote a product*---The soccer star makes a lot of money when he agrees to plug a product.

a preferred customer- *a customer who does much business with you and who you give special discounts to*---The man is a preferred customer and always gets his products soon after he orders them.

to put one's nose to the grindstone- *to work diligently*---I put my nose to the grindstone and finished the job before the weekend.

to put (someone) on hold- *to disconnect someone temporarily from the telephone*---I phoned the bank but they put me on hold for twenty minutes before someone spoke to me.

to put (something) on hold- *to postpone a project*---The construction project was put on hold while they researched the problem with the bridge.

to put (someone) through- *to transfer someone to someone else's telephone*---I phoned the credit card company and they quickly put me through to a supervisor.

red ink- *debt (the red ink on a financial statement)*---The automobile company has been drowning in red ink because of the bad economic conditions.

red tape- *rules and regulations that seem unnecessary (often from the government)*---There is a lot of red tape when you try to start up a new business.

to rule someone out of order- *to rule that someone is not following the rules of a meeting*---The chairwoman ruled the salesman out of order when he began to disrespect the other members who were attending the meeting.

to run an ad- *to place/put an advertisement in a publication*
The government decided to run an ad to tell the public about the new gas tax.

to run short- *to not have enough of something*---They ran short of gasoline at the gas station and had to close early.

(to be) saddled with debt- *to be burdened with debt*---Our company is saddled with debt and must do something about it quickly.

to second a motion- *to agree with a proposal*---I seconded the motion where we decided to start one hour early every morning during the summer.

to sell like hotcakes- *to sell very quickly*---The children's toys were selling like hotcakes at the end of the year.

to sell out- *to sell all of a product*---Every year our company is able to sell out most of our summer goods.

to strike while the iron is hot- *to take advantage of an opportunity*---I decided to strike while the iron was hot and applied for the job as soon as I heard about it.

a sweetheart deal- *a deal made between friends so that both may make a big profit*---We made a sweetheart deal with our landlord and got our rent reduced.

to table a discussion- *to postpone a discussion until a later time*---We tabled the discussion about the salary decrease until the next meeting.

to take a nosedive- *to collapse, to fail, to decrease in value*---The stock market took a nosedive when the earnings of the oil company decreased.

to take a pay cut- *to accept a decrease in one's salary*---The telephone workers were forced to take a pay cut after the strike.

to take on (someone)- *to give a job to someone or to hire someone*---The company took on many new workers during the busy holiday season.

to take over- *to take control or possession of something, to take charge or responsibility of something*---The government decided to take over the bank after it declared bankruptcy.

to take (a company) public- *to sell shares in a company to the general public*---We decided to take our company public in order to raise money to expand our factory.

to take (something) at face value- *to take something that is said on its surface*---I took what my friend said at face value.

to take stock- *to count the items of merchandise or supplies in stock, to take inventory*---The department store closes down for three days every March in order to take stock.

to throw cold water on (something)- *to discourage or forbid something*---The manager threw cold water on the plan to close down the factory for one week in August.

to throw money at (something)- *to try to solve a problem by spending money on it*---The president of our company is willing to throw a lot of money at the problem to try and solve it.

a tight spot- *a difficult situation*---The computer company has been in a tight spot since the shortage of computer chips appeared.

to turn a profit- *to make a profit*---The supermarket has been turning a profit since the day that it opened.

turnover- *the selling and replacing of an amount of goods, the replacement of workers*---The turnover of workers in the restaurant business is very high.

to turn over- *to buy and then sell something to customers*---We turned over most of our stock last month.

to work out- *to plan, to develop*---I spent the weekend trying to work out the budget estimates for next year.

to work overtime- *to work more than one's regular hours*---I had to work overtime every Friday last month.

to write off (a loan/debt)- *to remove from a business record, to cancel a debt*---It was impossible for the bank to collect the money so they were forced to write off the loan.

Accounting Idioms

a bean counter- *an accountant*---We asked the bean counters to look over the figures in the new budget.

the bottom line- *the central issue of a discussion*---My friends wanted to open a small restaurant but for me the bottom line was that if we didn't do some research I didn't want to invest any money.

to break even- *to have expenses equal to profits*---After only three months the company was able to break even and started to make a profit.

a budget squeeze/crunch- *a situation where there is not enough money in the budget*---We have been going through a severe budget squeeze at our company and must stop wasting money.

to carry over- *to transfer (a figure) from one column or book to another*---Our company is facing difficult times and we must carry over last year's losses to this year.

to close the books- *to stop taking orders, to end a bookkeeping period*---They usually close the books at the end of December every year.

to crunch numbers- *to do mathematical calculations*---Our accountant loves to crunch numbers and is one of the top managers in our company.

to figure (something) out- *to find an answer by thinking about something*---Everyone is trying to figure out what our boss is going to do with the new equipment.

to go over the books- *to check and analyze the accounting records of a company*---We hired an outside accountant to go over the books.

(to be) in the black- *to be successful or to be making money*---The new company has been in the black for many years now.

(to be) in the red- *to be losing money, to be unprofitable*---The company has been in the red since the price of oil began to rise rapidly.

to keep books- *to keep records of money gained and spent*---The new sales manager has no experience to keep books and has made many mistakes.

a number cruncher- *an accountant, someone who works with numbers*---Our president is a good number cruncher and understands the finances of our company.

red ink- *debt (the red ink on a financial statement)*---The automobile company has been drowning in red ink because of the bad economic conditions.

(to be) saddled with debt- *to be burdened with debt*---Our company is saddled with debt and must do something about it quickly.

to write off (a loan/debt)- *to remove from a business record, to cancel a debt*---It was impossible for the bank to collect the money so they were forced to write off the loan.

Advertising Idioms

bang for the buck- *value for the money spent*---We were able to get a big bang for our buck when we advertised on the Internet.

to plug a product- *to promote a product*---The soccer star makes a lot of money when he agrees to plug a product.

to run an ad- *to place/put an advertisement in a publication*---The government decided to run an ad to tell the public about the new gas tax.

Banking Idioms

to bail a company out- *to help or rescue a company with financial problems*---The government decided to bail out the bank in order to maintain stability in the economy.

banker's hours- *short work hours (similar to when a bank is open)*---My sister's husband owns his own company and works banker's hours most days.

to bankroll someone- *to supply someone with money, to finance someone* ---The movie actor bankrolled his son while he was producing his first movie.

to buy a stake in something- *to buy part ownership of a company or other enterprise*---The large bank is planning to buy a stake in the small stock trading company.

a calculated risk- *an action that may fail but has a good chance to succeed*---They took a calculated risk when they put the new computer screen on the market.

to float someone a loan- *to loan someone money*---I wanted the bank to float me a loan so that I could buy a new car.

to have a stake in something- *to have part ownership of a company or other business*---The oil company has a stake in the new undersea oil exploration company.

Meeting Idioms

to call a meeting to order- *to start a meeting*---Our supervisor called the meeting to order when everyone arrived in the conference room.

to have the floor- *to have permission to speak in a meeting*---The president had the floor for almost an hour during the meeting.

to hold a meeting- *to conduct a meeting*---We plan to hold a meeting next week to discuss the problems with our new product.

to lay (something) on the table- *to present a matter for discussion*---I went to the meeting and laid all of my concerns about the new product on the table.

to move to do (something)- *to propose to do something*---I moved to have another meeting next week when we were able to gather more information.

to rule (someone) out of order- *to rule that someone is not following the rules of a meeting*---The chairwoman ruled the salesman out of order when he began to disrespect the other members who were attending the meeting.

to second a motion- *to agree with a proposal*---I seconded the motion where we decided to start one hour early every morning during the summer.

to table a discussion- *to postpone a discussion until a later time*---We tabled the discussion about the salary decrease until the next meeting.

Sales Idioms

to (make a) cold call- *to visit or telephone a potential but unknown customer from a list of people*---When he first started to work at his company he was asked to make cold calls from the telephone book.

to come down in price- *to lower the price of one's product*---We were forced to come down in price in order to sell our target number of cars for the month.

a hard sell-*a way to sell something that is very aggressive and uses pressure tactics*---The car salesman gave us a hard sell so we decided to go to another dealer.

to knock down the price of (something)- *to lower the price of something* ---I bargained hard so that I could knock down the price of the stereo.

to land an account- *to acquire an account*---The salesman landed a large account on his first day of work.

a line of products- *a group/category of products that are similar to each other*---Our company will introduce a new line of products in the autumn.

to make an offer- *to make a financial proposal for a product or service*--- We want to buy the house so we plan to make an offer on Saturday.

a preferred customer- *a customer who does much business with you and who you give special discounts to*---The man is a preferred customer and always gets his products soon after he orders them.

to sell like hotcakes- *to sell very quickly*---The children's toys were selling like hotcakes at the end of the year.

Cards Idioms

above board- *honest, not secret (originally players showed their honesty by keeping their hands above the board when playing a game)*---The real estate agent was always above board when dealing with people who were trying to buy a house.

according to Hoyle- *according to the rules (Hoyle wrote a well-known book about card games)*---According to Hoyle we were not permitted to enter the convention site but in reality we were able to enter easily.

an ace in the hole- *something that you can use to gain an advantage (when playing cards an ace is face down so the other players in a card game can't see it)*---The team had an ace in the hole and decided to use it when they brought out their star goalkeeper to play.

ante up- *produce or pay a necessary amount of money*---We all had to ante up quickly in order to collect the money for our holiday.

call a spade a spade- *call a person or thing a name that is true, speak in plain language*---I decided to call a spade a spade and tell our supervisor what was wrong with our workplace.

call someone's bluff- *challenge someone to show that they are not being deceptive and can actually do what they say they can do (from poker where one makes an opponent show his or her cards to show that they are weaker than they are pretending them to be)*---My girlfriend always said that she didn't want to get married so I called her bluff and asked her to marry me. She said yes.

cash in ne's chips- *to die (the chips in many gambling games are changed into cash at the end of a game)*---After an honorable and fruitful career the judge cashed in his chips at the age of ninety years.

come/turn up trumps-*have a better performance or outcome than is expected (trumps are the playing cards that are chosen to be ranked higher than the others)*---We entered the contest with little hope of success but our performance came up trumps which were a big surprise to everyone.

deal someone in- *include someone*---I hope that my friend will deal me in on his new computer business.

be dealt a bad hand/deal someone a bad hand-*receive or give someone bad cards in a card game, receive disadvantages in something*---The boy was dealt a bad hand when he was a child and always was at a disadvantage in his life.

follow suit- *play a card of the same suit, follow the example of another*---The small university followed suit with the other universities and decided to raise their tuition fees.

force someone's hand- *make someone do something that they don't want to do at that time*---The man threatened to quit his job so the company decided to force his hand and make him either continue or quit.

have an ace up one's sleeve-*something that you can use to gain an advantage (in a card game the ace is often the most valuable card and a cheater could have an ace up their sleeve to use against an opponent)*---When the football players were ready to go on strike, the team owners had an ace up their sleeve and offered more money and stopped the strike.

have a card up one's sleeve- *have a reserve plan or a secret advantage*---The man had a card up his sleeve when he went to the bank to ask for more money for his business.

hold all the aces- *have all the advantages (from the ace which is the most valuable card in many card games)*---The employer held all the aces when they began to negotiate with the small union.

hold all the cards- *be in a strong or advantageous position (like a winning hand in a card game)*---The company held all the cards when the union decided to go on strike to achieve their goals.

hold all the trumps- *have the best chance of winning, have all the advantages*---The striker holds all the trumps and should easily be elected as captain of the football team.

house of cards- *a poorly thought out plan, something that is badly put together and easily knocked over*---The large company was like a house of cards and when there were financial problems in one area the whole business was hurt.

in spades- *as much or more than you could want (spades are the highest ranking cards in the game of bridge)*---The sick child was hoping to receive some cards when he was in the hospital but when the radio talked about his illness he received them in spades.

in the cards- *possible or likely (as in using playing cards or tarot cards to tell the future)*---Although the airport expansion was in the cards nobody knew exactly when it would begin.

lost in the shuffle- *be overlooked in a confused or crowded situation*---When we moved to a new office all of our sales receipts were lost in the shuffle of the move

not playing with a full deck- *mentally deficient (like a deck of playing cards with some cards missing)*---The student told unlikely stories about his life which made us believe that he was not playing with a full deck.

play one's ace- *use one's best resources (like an ace in cards)*---The lawyer played his ace when he showed the judge the new information.

play one's cards close to one's chest- *be extremely secretive and cautious about something (holding playing cards close to your chest so the other players can't see them)*---My boss always plays his cards close to his chest when he is negotiating with another company.

play one's cards right- *make the best use of your opportunities or what you have*---I told my friend that if he plays his cards right he will be able to go on the business trip to Europe.

poker face- *a face with no expression (done in the game of poker so that nobody knows if you have good cards or not)*---The politician had a poker face when he tried to defend himself against the scandal.

put (lay) one's cards on the table- *be open and honest about one's intentions or resources*---I put my cards on the table and told my boss about my plans to return to school and study economics.

raise the ante- *increase what is at stake or under discussion in a dispute or conflict (an ante is the amount of money that you put on the table before beginning a card game)*---The government raised the ante when they decided to cancel the contract of the health care workers.

show one's hand- *reveal one's plans*---I didn't want to show my hand but I was forced to tell my family about my plans to go overseas to study.

shuffle the cards/deck- *change policy*---The government was in the middle of an economic crisis so they did not want to shuffle the deck and cause any more uncertainty.

stack the deck- *unfairly arrange things for or against someone so that a person has an unfair advantage or disadvantage*---The league stacked the deck against the new team so that the older, more established teams could advance to the playoffs.

trump card- *something that you hold back to use to win success if nothing else works (a trump card is a card that is chosen to temporarily be stronger than the other cards)*---The boxer's trump card in his desire for another fight was his great popularity with the fans.

up the ante- *increase what is at stake or under discussion in a dispute or conflict (an ante is the amount of money that you put on the table before beginning a card game)*---The actor upped the ante in his dispute with the movie studio when he refused to appear for the movie preparation.

when the chips are down- *when one is in a difficult or serious situation (chips are used in gambling), when the winner or loser of a card game or a bet is decided*---The man is a good manager and when the chips are down he is always able to overcome his difficulties.

Cat Idioms

alley cat- *stray cat*---He began to feed the alley cat and now it comes to his house every day.

as conceited as a barber's cat- *very conceited, vain*---My friend has been as conceited as a barber's cat ever since she won the award at school.

as weak as a kitten- *weak, sickly*---The girl was as weak as a kitten and couldn't carry the pile of books.

**cat gets one`s tongue**- *can`t speak because of shyness*---The cat got the woman's tongue and she couldn't say anything at all.

a cat nap- *a short sleep taken during the day*---I had a cat nap during the afternoon so I would feel refreshed in the evening.

a cat on a hot tin roof- *full of lively activity*---The boy was jumping around like a cat on a hot tin roof and we couldn't make him be quiet.

a copycat- *someone who copies another person`s work etc*---The boy is a copycat according to the other students in the class.

curiosity killed the cat- *being too nosy may lead a person into trouble*--- "You shouldn`t worry about what your friend is doing. Remember, curiosity killed the cat."

fight like cats and dogs- *argue and fight with someone (usually used for people who know each other)*---The two children were fighting like cats and dogs when we entered the room.

a fraidy-cat- *someone who is easily frightened (used by children usually)* The little boy called his friend a fraidy-cat because he wouldn`t climb the tree.

let the cat out of the bag- *tell something that is supposed to be a secret*---She let the cat out of the bag when she began talking about the plans for the new school.

look like something the cat dragged in- *look tired/shabby/worn out*---I was very tired and I am sure that I looked like something the cat dragged in.

look like the cat that swallowed/ate the canary-*look very self-satisfied, look as if you have just had a great success*---"You look like the cat that swallowed the canary. What happened?"

not enough room to swing a cat- *not very much space*---There was not enough room to swing a cat in the small apartment.

play cat and mouse with someone-*tease or fool someone, change between different types of behavior when dealing with someone*---He is playing cat and mouse with his company about his plans to quit or not.

rain cats and dogs- *rain very hard*---It has been raining cats and dogs all day.

rub (someone/someone's fur) the wrong way-*irritate someone (just as you would irritate a dog or cat if you rub their fur the wrong way)*---The woman who I work with rubs me the wrong way when I speak to her.

a scared-cat- *someone who is easily frightened (used by children usually)*---The children called their friend a scared-cat because she wouldn`t go into the empty house.

there is more than one way to skin a cat- *there is more than one way to do something*---I knew that there was more than one way to skin a cat so I didn't worry about being restricted by the rules and time limit of my project.

when the cat's away, the mice will play-*when you are not watching someone they may get into trouble*---When the cat's away, the mice will play and as soon as the teacher left the classroom the students began to move around.

Clothes Idioms

**air one`s dirty linen in public**- *tell about one`s private quarrels or problems where others can hear*---His personal problems are nobody else`s business and he doesn`t like his wife to air his dirty linen in public when they go out with friends.

ants in one`s pants- *restlessness, nervousness*---You are moving around as if you have ants in your pants the teacher said to the little boy.

at the drop of a hat- *without waiting, immediately, promptly*---He will stop working and help you at the drop of a hat if you ask him politely.

bee in one`s bonnet- *an idea that seems strange or crazy*---She has a bee in her bonnet about going to live on an island and starting a herb farm.

below the belt- *in an unfair or cowardly way*---I think that he was hitting below the belt when he began to criticize me after I told him my true feelings on the matter.

bet one`s boots- *bet everything that one has*---I will bet my boots that he is not able to save up enough money to come with us to Greece this winter.

birthday suit- *complete nakedness*---The little boy was running around the picnic site in his birthday suit.

buckle down- *give complete attention or effort to do something*---I told her that it was time that she buckled down and began to work harder than before.

burn a hole in one`s pocket- *money likely to be quickly spent*---The money that he made at his part-time job is burning a hole in his pocket and he will probably spend it quickly.

burst at the seams- *too full or too crowded*---The train station was bursting at the seams as everyone was waiting to go away for their holidays.

**card up one`s sleeve**- *another plan or argument kept back and produced if needed*---I don`t know what he is planning to say at the meeting but I think that he has another card up his sleeve and will make an important announcement.

catch with one`s pants down- *surprise someone in an embarrassing situation or a guilty act*---He was caught with his pants down when he was asked for the figures but was unable to produce them.

come into fashion- *become fashionable*---Recently in some areas the mini-skirt has come into fashion again.

decked out- *dressed in fancy clothes*---I saw her at the concert last night and she was all decked out in a beautiful silk dress.

**die with one`s boots on**- *die while still active in one`s work*---He worked hard all his life and died with his boots on when he had a heart attack and died in the factory.

dressed to kill- *wear one`s finest clothes*---She was dressed to kill when I saw her at the sales convention.

dressed to the nines (teeth)- *dressed elegantly*---They were dressed to the nines when they went to the opening of the new theater production.

dress up- *put on one`s best clothes*---I decided to dress up to go to dinner on Saturday night.

feather in one`s cap- *something to be proud of, an honor*---Winning the speech contest was a feather in his cap and the greatest honor that he has ever won.

fill one`s shoes- *take the place of another and do as well as he or she would*---It will be difficult for him to fill the shoes of the previous supervisor.

fine-tooth comb- *great care, careful attention so as not to miss anything*---We went over the room with a fine-tooth comb but were unable to find the missing credit card.

fit like a glove- *fits perfectly*---Her new dress fit like a glove so she was very happy.

fly by the seat of one`s pants- *do something by instinct rather than by knowledge or logic*---He was forced to fly by the seat of his pants when nobody was in the office to help him fix the computer.

handle with kid gloves- *treat very gently and carefully*---You must handle the new employee with kid gloves as he is very sensitive.

hand-me-down- *clothing that is given away after another person doesn`t need it*---During his childhood growing up on a farm he wore many hand-me-down clothes.

if the shoe fits wear it- *that what is said in general can also be said of an individual person*---You shouldn`t criticize others for something that you would do yourself. Remember, if the shoe fits wear it.

**in one`s shoes**- *in another`s place or position*---I would hate to be in his shoes now that he has lost his job.

**keep one`s shirt on**- *calm down, keep from losing one`s temper or getting excited*---Keep your shirt on. You shouldn`t get so excited about small problems.

keep (something) under one`s hat- *keep something secret*---I plan to keep my plans to apply for a new job under my hat.

**lose one`s shirt**- *lose all or most of one`s money*---He lost his shirt gambling and now he is in serious financial difficulty.

off the cuff- *without preparation*---He made a very interesting off-the-cuff speech at the party last night.

old hat- *not new or different, old-fashioned*---We have been using the new computer program for many months. It is old hat now.

on a shoestring- *on a very low budget, with little money to spend*---We went to China and Japan on a shoestring and enjoyed it very much.

**on one`s coat-tails**- *as a result of someone else doing something*---She was elected to city council by running on her well-known husband`s coat-tails.

pull out of a hat- *get something as if by magic, invent, imagine*---At first he said that he didn`t have any of the information but then it suddenly appeared as if he had pulled it out of a hat.

pull up one`s socks- *make a greater effort*---It is time that you pull up your socks and begin to work hard and take this job seriously.

put on one`s thinking cap- *think hard and long about something*---I will put on my thinking cap and try to find a solution to the problem by next week.

**roll up one`s sleeves**- *get ready for a hard job, prepare to work hard or seriously*---Let`s roll up our sleeves and begin to work so that we can finish early.

shoe is on the other foot- *the opposite is true, places are changed*---For a long time my friend laughed at my problems at work. Now the shoe is on the other foot and he also has serious problems.

stuffed shirt- *a person who is too rigid or too formal*---I don`t want to invite him to go with us because he is a stuffed shirt and not very interesting to spend time with.

take one`s hat off to someone- *admire, respect, praise*---You have to take your hat off to him. He has started a small business and now it is very successful.

**talk through one`s hat**- *say something without knowing or understanding the facts*---He is talking through his hat again and doesn`t really know what he is talking about.

tighten one`s belt- *live on less money than usual*---If we want to go on a holiday to Europe this year we will have to tighten our belts and begin to save some money.

too big for one`s breeches/boots- *think that you are more important than you really are*---He is too big for his breeches and needs someone to make him realize that he is not very important.

**under one`s belt**- *in one`s experience or possession; gained by effort and skill*---Now that you have experience working for an international company under your belt you will have more chances to apply for a better job.

**up one`s sleeve**- *kept secretly ready for the right time or for a time when needed*---I don`t know what he has up his sleeve but I am sure that he is planning to say something at the meeting.

wear one`s heart on one`s sleeve- *show one`s feelings openly*---She is wearing her heart on her sleeve and everyone knows that she is having problems with her boyfriend again.

wear the pants in one`s family- *be the boss of a family or household*---She seems to wear the pants in her family and is always telling her husband what to do.

wolf in sheep`s clothing- *a person who pretends to be good but is really bad*---He is a wolf in sheep's clothing and someone that you should be very careful around.

you bet your boots- *most certainly, yes indeed*---You can bet your boots that I am going to go and apply for my passport as early as possible.

Color Idioms

black and white- *thinking of everything or judging everything as either good or bad*---He tries to see everything in black and white although he knows this is impossible.

black out- *darken by putting out or dimming electric lights*---During the war people in the cities were forced to black out their windows so that the enemy aircraft could not see them.

black out- *prevent or silence information or communication*---The government decided to black out all of the information related to the political prisoner.

black out- *lose consciousness*---Suddenly the man blacked out during the parade and had to be helped to a quiet place.

black sheep (of the family)- *a person who is a disgrace to a family or group*---The man is the black sheep in his family and is the only member who has not made a success of his life.

blue in the face- *very angry or upset, excited and very emotional*---He argued with her until he was blue in the face.

brown bag it- *take a lunch to work*---I have had to brown bag it every day this week as the company cafeteria is closed for repair work.

catch (someone) red-handed- *catch someone in the middle of doing something wrong*---The woman was caught red-handed at the store trying to steal some cosmetics.

give someone the green light- *give permission to go ahead with a project* ---We were finally given the green light to begin setting up the new project.

grass is always greener on the other side-*a place that is far away or different seems better than where we are now*---He realized that the grass is always greener on the other side when he saw that his new job wasn`t perfect and had its own problems too.

green- *inexperienced, immature*---He is rather green and doesn`t have enough experience to drive the large piece of machinery yet.

green belt- *an area of fields and trees around a town*---The city has a policy of increasing the green belt around the city.

green thumb- *a talent for gardening, ability to make things grow*---She has a green thumb and is able to grow one of the best gardens in our neighborhood.

green with envy- *very jealous, full of envy*---I was green with envy when I heard that she would be going to London for a week while I had to stay and work.

horse of a different color- *something totally separate and different*---I know that he would like to discuss that issue now but it is a horse of a different color and we should discuss it at another time.

in the black- *successful or profitable*---The company has been in the black since they began to adopt many new ideas to cut costs.

in the red- *lose money, unprofitable*---The company has been in the red for three years now - ever since their exports to Asia decreased by 35 per cent.

look at/see the world through rose-colored glasses- *see only the good things about something, be too optimistic*---He always looks at the world through rose-colored glasses and is never able to understand that some people are dishonest.

off-color- *in bad taste, rude, dirty*---He told an off-color joke at the party that made his wife very angry.

once in a blue moon- *rarely*---We go out for Italian food once in a blue moon although we enjoy it very much.

out of the blue- *without any warning, by surprise*---I don`t understand what the problem is. Right out of the blue he decided to quit his job and go and live in Europe.

paint the town red- *go out and party and have a good time*---When my cousin came to visit us we decided to go out and paint the town red.

pink slip- *termination notice from a job*---I received my pink slip last week and am now looking for a new job.

pot calling the kettle black- *the person who is criticizing/accusing someone else is as guilty as the person he criticizes/accuses*---She was criticizing me for not looking for a new job but that is like the pot calling the kettle black. She isn`t looking for a new job either.

red herring- *an unimportant matter that draws attention away from the main subject*---Suddenly talking about the strike was a red herring and didn't do anything to deal with today's problems.

red-letter day- *a day that is memorable because of some important event*---It was a red-letter day when she finally received her graduation diploma.

red tape- *excessive formalities in official business*---Many businesses have been complaining about the amount of red tape that they must deal with in order to get anything done with the government.

roll out the red carpet- *greet a person with great respect, give a big welcome*---When the President of Egypt visited Paris, they rolled out the red carpet and gave him a great welcome.

see red- *become very angry*---He really saw red last night when I told him that I wouldn`t be coming to work today.

**show one`s true colors**- *show what one is really like*---I know that she doesn`t like me but she was showing her true colors when she began yelling at me on the telephone.

tickled pink- *be very pleased, thrill, delight*
She was tickled pink that you made the effort to go and visit her when you were in town.

white elephant- *a useless possession/undertaking*---The new airport is a white elephant and nobody likes it at all.

white as a ghost- *very pale because of fear, shock, illness*---My sister became white as a ghost when she saw the man at the window.

white lie- *a harmless lie (told to be polite or to do something not seriously wrong)*---I told my boss a white lie and said that I was sick yesterday when actually I was not.

white sale- *the selling at a reduced price of towels or sheets etc*---We went to the white sale at the department store to buy some new sheets before my parents come to visit.

with flying colors- *with great or total success*---She passed the course with flying colors and now wants to go out and celebrate.

yellow-bellied- *extremely timid, cowardly*---He is a yellow-bellied coward and never is willing to fight for what is right.

yellow streak- *cowardice in one`s character*---He has a yellow streak running down his back and is not a good person to support you if things become difficult.

Court Idioms

abide by a decision- *follow the orders that a court/judge has given*---The company was forced to abide by the decision of the judge.

as sober as a judge- *alert and completely sober, not drunk, very formal*---My father is always as sober as a judge when he gets into his car to drive.

at the mercy of (the court/someone)- *having no defense against the court/someone*---My friend was at the mercy of the court when he went before the judge.

beat the rap- *escape conviction and punishment for a crime*---The man hired a good lawyer and was able to beat the rap easily.

cast doubt on (someone or something)- *cause someone or something to be doubted*---The evidence presented at the trial cast doubt on the truthfulness of the woman's testimony.

clear (someone's) name- *prove that someone is not guilty of a crime*---The woman went to court to clear her name of the false charges.

come down hard on (someone)- *scold/punish someone severely, attack someone vigorously*---The judge came down hard on the boy who had been arrested for breaking into a house.

cop a plea- *plead guilty to a crime or decide not to fight against a charge in order to try and receive a light punishment, the same meaning as plea bargain (usually done in a negotiation between the defendant and his or her lawyer and the prosecutor)*---The man copped a plea and went to hear what the judge would decide regarding his case.

cross-examine (someone)- *question a suspect or a witness in a trial*
The lawyer was very careful when he began to cross-examine the witness.

a cut-and-dried (case/decision)- *fixed, determined beforehand*---The case was cut-and-dried and it ended in less than an hour.

decide in favor of (someone)- *determine that someone is not guilty or is the winner of something*---The court decided in favor of the government in their dispute with the striking workers.

face the music- *receive punishment or judgment for something wrong or illegal that you have done*---The young man was forced to face the music for the crimes that he had committed.

fair and impartial- *a fair and unbiased look at something*---The judge made a fair and impartial decision in the case against the small store.

find (someone) guilty- *decide that someone is guilty in a court of law*---The judge found the young man guilty of breaking and entering a small store.

find (someone) innocent- *decide that someone is innocent in a court of law*---The woman went to court but the judge found her innocent of all charges.

for the record- *say something so that there will be a record of a particular fact*---I was told, for the record, that my case had very little chance of succeeding in a court of law.

get a slap on the wrist- *get light punishment for a crime or wrongdoing*---The boy got a slap on the wrist for causing the damage to the public washroom.

get a tongue-lashing- *get a severe verbal scolding for doing something wrong*---The girl got a tongue-lashing from the judge over her role in the crime.

get down to the facts- *begin to discuss things that matter, get to the truth*---As soon as the trial began the lawyers began to get down to the facts of the case.

get off (easy/lightly)- *receive very little or no punishment for something*---The young man got off easy and did not have to go to jail for his crime.

get one's knuckles rapped- *receive punishment for something*---The boy got his knuckles rapped after a stern lecture from the judge.

get (something) out in the open- *stop hiding a fact or a secret*---The lawyers were able to quickly get things out in the open during the trial.

get the benefit of the doubt-*receive a judgment in your favor when the evidence is neither for you nor against you*---The girl got the benefit of the doubt and was not found guilty of the crime.

give (someone) a fair shake- *give someone fair treatment*---The man did not believe that the judge would give him a fair shake at his trial.

give (someone) a slap on the wrist- *give someone light punishment*---The young offender was given a slap on the wrist by the judge but was required to do some community work as compensation for his crime.

give (someone) the benefit of the doubt-*make a judgment in someone's favor when the evidence is neither for nor against the person*---The police gave the man the benefit of the doubt and did not arrest him as a suspect for the crime.

give (someone) their freedom- *set someone free*---The court decided to give the man his freedom because of his good behavior in prison.

go by the book- *follow the rules exactly*---The court clerks always go by the book when they are dealing with court matters.

go easy on (someone or something)- *be kind or gentle with someone or something*---The judge wanted to go easy on the young man but his bad attitude made it difficult to try and help him.

go scot-free/get off scot-free- *go unpunished or be acquitted of a crime*---The lawyer was able to get off scot-free in the case involving his illegal transactions.

a grain of truth- *the smallest amount of truth*---There was only a grain of truth in what the witness said during the trial.

hand a verdict/decision down (to someone)- *announce or deliver a legal decision or verdict in a court*---The court clerk announced that the judge would hand the verdict down in the morning.

hang in the balance- *be in an undecided state*---The future of the criminal was hanging in the balance as he waited for the judge's decision.

have/get one's day in court- *have an opportunity to say or explain something or give your opinion in court*---The business executive had his day in court and was cleared of any suggestion of wrongdoing.

a hung jury- *a jury that is divided and unable to agree on a verdict*---The trial ended in a hung jury which made another trial necessary.

in absentia- *when someone is absent from a court etc*---The judge looked at the evidence and sentenced the man in absentia.

in contempt of court- *disobedience of the orders and authority of the court, disrespect for the court process*---The man refused to answer the questions of the judge and was found to be in contempt of court.

in defiance of (someone or something)- *in resistance to someone or someone's orders*---The union was in defiance of the court order and was given a large fine.

in session- *a court is operating or functioning*---The court was in session when we arrived at the courthouse.

in (someone's) favor- *to someone's advantage*---The judge ruled in the favor in our dispute with the hospital.

judge (someone or something) on its/their own merit(s)-*judge or evaluate someone or something on their own achievements and virtues*---We judged the man on his own merits and not by what other people were saying about him.

jump to conclusions- *judge or decide something without having all the facts*---The manager had jumped to conclusions when she accused the employee of stealing from the company.

the jury is still out (on someone or something)- *a decision has not been reached on someone or something (used often and in a casual*

manner when one has not made a decision about something)---The jury is still out on whether or not we will move or not.

a kangaroo court- *an illegal court formed by a group of people to settle a dispute among themselves*---There was a kangaroo court in the movie where the ranchers decided to make their own court.

keep one's own counsel- *not tell other people about one's thoughts and plans*---Our lawyer was keeping his own counsel about how to proceed with our defense.

laugh (something) out of court- *dismiss something as ridiculous*---The lawyer wanted to sue the man for hitting the dog but the judge laughed the case out of court.

a leading question- *a question to a witness that is designed to suggest or produce the reply that is wanted by the questioner*---The judge reprimanded the lawyer for continuing to ask leading questions during the trial.

let (someone) off (easy)- *release someone without punishment*---The judge let the man off easy in spite of the strong case against him.

a miscarriage of justice- *a wrong or mistaken decision made in a court of law*---The trial was a miscarriage of justice and nobody was happy with the result.

the moment of truth- *the point at which someone has to face the reality of a situation*---The moment of truth in the trial came when the lawyer presented the last piece of evidence.

not hold water- *make no sense, be illogical*---The argument by the lawyer did not hold water.

on the bench- *a judge is sitting and directing a session of court*---There was no indication by the court of who would be sitting on the bench during the important trial.

on trial- *being tried in court*---The man is on trial for stealing money from his company.

an open-and-shut case- *a legal matter that is simple and uncomplicated*---It was an open-and-shut case after the lawyer presented the evidence to the judge.

pick holes in an argument- *find all the flaws in an argument*---The experienced lawyer found it very easy to pick holes in the argument of the main witness.

plea bargain- *plead guilty to a crime or decide not to fight against a charge in order to try and receive a light punishment (usually done in a negotiation between the defendant and his or her lawyer and the prosecutor)*---The man decided to plea bargain in order not to have to endure a long trial with an uncertain result.

poetic justice- *the appropriate but chance reward or punishment by someone who deserves it*---It was poetic justice when the supervisor who was harassing the workers lost his job because the president did not want him to work for the company anymore.

raise an objection (to/about someone or something)- *make an objection about someone or something*---The defense lawyer stood up during the trial to raise an objection about the testimony of the witness.

the responsible party- *legally or morally obliged to do something or accept the blame for something*---The judge determined that the man was the responsible party for the damage and must pay a large penalty.

send (someone) up the river- *send someone to prison*---The judge sent the man up the river for three years.

settle (something) out of court- *reach an agreement without having to go through a court of law*---It was very difficult but we were finally able to settle the dispute out of court.

sit in judgment of (someone)- *make a judgment of someone*---The tribunal members were sitting in judgment of the group involved in the trade dispute.

to stand trial- *to be tried in court*---The man had to stand trial for stealing the credit cards.

swear on a stack of bibles- *pledge to tell the truth about something (in a court of law someone may swear to tell the truth by placing his or her hand on a bible or other religious text)*---The man swore on a stack of bibles that he had never seen the accused criminal before.

take an oath- *make an oath, swear to something*---Before the trial began I had to take an oath and promise to tell the truth.

take the Fifth- *in the United States a witness at a trial has the right to refuse to incriminate him or herself because of the protection of the Fifth Amendment of the Constitution of the United States*---The business executive decided to take the Fifth rather than give testimony at the trial.

take the stand- *sit in the witness chair in a courtroom*---The main witness at the trial took the stand after the other witnesses were finished.

throw oneself at the mercy of the court- *ask a judge for mercy when being sentenced for a crime*---The man knew that he had no excuse for what he had done so all that he could do was throw himself at the mercy of the court and hope for a light sentence.

throw the book at (someone)- *charge or convict someone of as many crimes or for as much time as possible*---The criminal showed almost no remorse so the judge decided to throw the book at him.

a travesty of justice- *a legal action that is an insult to the system of justice*---The trial was a travesty of justice and nobody was happy with the result.

under oath- *to take and be bound by an oath*---The man explained what had happened at the scene of the crime while he was under oath at the trial.

Cow Idioms

as awkward as a cow on roller skates- *very awkward*---The little girl was as awkward as a cow on roller skates when she first began riding a bicycle.

a bull in a china shop- *a tactless person who upsets others or upsets plans, a very clumsy person*---He is like a bull in a china shop so you should be careful if you invite him to your house.

a cash cow- *a good way to make money*---The new business is a cash cow. We are making a lot of money now.

have a cow- *become very angry and upset about something*---Our teacher had a cow when he discovered that nobody had prepared for the class.

hit the bulls-eye- *reach the main point*---I think that he hit the bulls-eye when he talked about the real problems in the company.

Holy cow- *used to express strong feelings like astonishment/pleasure/ anger*---"Holy cow", he said when he saw the car that had hit the street lamp.

a sacred cow-*a person or thing that is never criticized or changed even if it should be (from a cow which is sacred in India)*---The school lunch program is a sacred cow which they will never change.

take the bull by the horns- *take decisive and direct action*---My aunt decided to take the bull by the horns and begin preparations for the family reunion.

until the cows come home- *until very late, for a long time*---We can talk until the cows come home this weekend.

Dog Idioms

as clean as a hound's tooth- *very clean*---The three students had the classroom as clean as a hound's tooth before they went home.

as crooked as a dog's hind leg- *dishonest*---The politician was as crooked as a dog's hind leg and everybody disliked him.

as sick as a dog- *very sick*---My friend was as sick as a dog when he left the restaurant last night.

one's bark is worse than one's bite- *one's words are worse than one's actions*---You shouldn`t worry about her. Her bark is worse than her bite and she is really a very nice person.

bark up the wrong tree-*choose the wrong course of action, ask the wrong person (a hunting dog may make a mistake when chasing an animal and bark up the wrong tree)*---My boss is barking up the wrong tree. I did not cause the computer problem because I was away at the time.

call the dogs off- *stop threatening/chasing/hounding someone*---The police decided to call the dogs off and stop hunting for the man.

dog and pony show-*something that you disapprove of because you think that it has only been organized to impress you (like a dog and pony show in a circus)*---We had serious questions about the viability of continuing with the project but all we got was a dog and pony show when we asked for answers from our business partners.

dog-eat-dog- *ready or willing to fight and hurt others to get what one wants*---It's a dog-eat-dog world in our company.

dog in the manger-*someone who prevents others from doing what they don't want to do (in Aesop's Fables a dog that cannot eat hay lays in the hayrack and prevents the other animals from eating the hay)*---My friend always acts like a dog in the manger and often tries to prevent us from enjoying ourselves.

every dog has his day- *everyone will have his chance or turn, everyone will get what he deserves*---Don`t worry about him. Every dog has his day and he will eventually suffer for all the bad things that he is doing.

fight like cats and dogs- *argue and fight with someone (usually used for people who know each other)*---The two children were fighting like cats and dogs when we entered the room.

go to the dogs- *deteriorate, go to ruin*---Everything in our city has gone to the dogs during the last ten years.

the hair of the dog that bit one- *a drink of alcohol that one takes when recovering from a hangover*---The man woke up and had the hair of the dog that bit him before he ate breakfast.

to hound someone- *to pursue/chase someone, to harass someone*---The manager is always hounding the younger members of her staff to make sure that they work hard.

in the doghouse- *in disgrace or disfavor, in trouble*---He is in the doghouse with his wife because he came home late last night.

**lead a dog`s life**- *lead a miserable life*---He is leading a dog`s life since he married the woman who everyone told him not to.

let sleeping dogs lie- *don`t make trouble if you don`t have to*---You should let sleeping dogs lie and not ask him any questions about the dispute.

put on the dog- *dress or entertain in a luxurious and extravagant manner* ---We put on the dog for my parents when they came to visit us.

rub (someone/someone's fur) the wrong way-*irritate someone (just as you would irritate a dog or cat if you rub their fur the wrong way)*---The woman who I work with rubs me the wrong way when I speak to her.

see a man about a dog- *leave for some unmentioned purpose (often to go to the washroom)*---I left the table in the restaurant to go and see a man about a dog.

a shaggy dog story-*a long and often pointless story told as a joke that often ends in a very silly or unexpected way*---My friend told me a shaggy dog story about how he lost his bicycle.

(have one's) tail between one`s legs-*feel beaten or humiliated (like a frightened or defeated dog as it walks away)*---He left the meeting with his tail between his legs after he was criticized by the company president.

the tail wagging the dog- *a situation where a small part controls the whole thing*---When the small group of managers began to run the whole company, it was like the tail wagging the dog.

top dog- *the most important person*---My uncle is the top dog in his company.

turn tail- *to run away from trouble or danger*---We decided to turn tail and leave the restaurant before there was an argument.

you can't teach an old dog new tricks- *it is difficult for older people to learn something new*---You can't teach an old dog new tricks and I don't think that my father will ever change his eating habits.

Education Idioms

A for effort-*recognize that someone tries hard to do something even though they may not be successful*---The students received an A for effort for their work on the class project.

above average- *better or higher than average*---The boy received above average marks in all subjects except history.

as easy as ABC- *very easy*-Learning how to use a computer was as easy as ABC for the children.

back to basics-*an approach in education which uses traditional ideas or methods that have been successful in the past*---The teacher believed that back to basics was important in her classroom and the parents were happy with the results.

below average- *worse or lower than average*---Most members of the class were below average in the math test.

bookworm- *someone who reads a lot*---My sister is a bookworm and is always reading a book.

brainstorm something- *try to develop an idea or think of new ideas*---The students got into groups to brainstorm ideas for the school play.

call the roll- *call the names of students on a roll and usually expect them to answer if they are there*---Every morning before the class started the teacher called the roll.

cap and gown- *the special cap called a mortarboard and the robe that is worn during academic ceremonies such as graduation*---All of the students wore a cap and gown to the graduation ceremony.

catch up to (so/st)- *move fast or work hard to reach someone or something that is ahead of you*---After my illness I had to study to catch up to the rest of the class.

copycat- *someone who copies the work of another*---The children called the girl a copycat when they discovered that she had copied part of the test from another student.

count noses- *count the number of people*---The teacher stopped to count noses several times during the field trip.

cover a lot of ground- *complete a lot of material in a class or course*---We covered a lot of ground during the first month of the science class.

cow college- *a school where farming/agriculture is studied*---My cousin plans to go to a cow college when he finishes high school.

crack a book-*open a book to study (usually used in the negative)*---I did very well in the course even though I didn't crack a book until the last week of classes.

crank out a paper- *write out a paper in a mechanical way*---I had to crank out a paper almost every week to pass the course.

cut class- *not go to class*---I decided to cut class in order to study for my geography test.

draw a blank- *get no response from someone when you ask them a question*---The teacher drew a blank when she asked about the boy's plans for the weekend.

drop out of school- *stop attending school*---My friend dropped out of school when he was seventeen and began to drive a truck.

eager beaver- *someone who works very hard and is very enthusiastic*---The young girl was an eager beaver and always came to class before the other students.

fill in the blanks- *supply the missing words or information on a test or other exercise*---We had to fill in the blanks for most of the questions on the test.

flunk out- *fail a course or fail out of school*---The boy was very smart but he always flunked out of his language class.

from the old school- *having ideas that were popular in the past but which are no longer popular or common*---My grandmother was from the old school and always made her children make their own lunches and walk to school.

get credit for (a course)- *receive official recognition and credits after passing a course*---I was able to get credit for the course even though I had taken a similar course before.

get through (a course or set of material)- *finish (a course or set of material)*---The boy was a very good student and quickly got through every course that he started.

goof off- *waste time*---My sister spent most of the week goofing off and was not prepared for her test.

have one's nose in a book- *be reading a book*---The boy loves to read and always has his nose in a book.

higher education- *education after graduating from high school - usually college or university*---The government has recently invested a lot of money in higher education.

hit the books- *begin to study hard*---After playing all weekend I had to hit the books on Sunday evening.

honor roll- *a list of people/students with exceptional achievements*---My neighbor was on the honor roll during his last year in high school.

in pen- *written or signed with a pen*---The teacher asked the students to make sure that they wrote the essay in pen.

in pencil- *written or signed with a pencil*---I wrote the test in pencil so that I could erase my mistakes easily.

Ivy League- *a small group of older and famous eastern United States colleges and universities such as Harvard, Yale and Princeton*---Several of the company executives had gone to an Ivy League school.

know one's ABCs- *know the alphabet or the most basic things about something*---The students worked hard and had a good teacher and soon everyone knew their ABCs very well.

learn by heart- *memorize something so you can repeat it without thinking*---The children learned all of the songs by heart for the school play.

learn by rote- *learn or memorize something without thinking about it*---We learned many verbs by rote in the foreign language class.

live in an ivory tower- *not be aware of the realities of everyday life*---The university professors lived in an ivory tower and had no idea what was going on around them.

make the grade- *be satisfactory and of an expected level*---My final assignment didn't make the grade and I was forced to do it again.

meet the requirements (for something)- *fulfill the requirements (for something)*---The young woman was unable to meet the requirements to enter medical school.

off campus- *at a different location than the grounds of a college or university*---Most of the students went to a restaurant off campus when they had the chance.

old boy network- *the situation where people (usually men) who went to the same school help each other get good jobs*---It was an old law firm and being part of an old boy network was necessary to get a job there.

on campus- *located on the grounds of a college or university*---There was a small bank on campus which many of the students used.

pass with flying colors- *pass something easily and with a high score*---I was able to pass the science test with flying colors.

play hooky- *not go to school when you should*---The boys played hooky and went to the video game center for the afternoon.

publish or perish- *university professors often have to publish books or articles in journals or they will not be successful in their jobs at the*

university---As a university professor his father wrote many scientific papers. He was forced to publish or perish.

put one's thinking cap on- *start thinking in a serious manner*---The boys put on their thinking caps and tried to think of a new name for the school newspaper.

read out loud- *read something so that other people can hear you*---The students each had a chance to read out loud from the book of poems.

read to oneself- *read without saying anything so that other people cannot hear you*---I spent the morning in the library reading to myself.

read through something- *read all of something*---I read through the test briefly before I started to answer any questions.

school of hard knocks- *the ordinary experience of learning from work and daily life*---She left school early and began to learn about life in the school of hard knocks.

school of thought- *a particular way or a philosophy of thinking about something*---There are many schools of thought related to the different ways to learn a foreign language.

show-and-tell- *in the lower grades of school children bring something interesting to show to the rest of the class*---The little girl brought in a turtle shell from her holiday to show-and-tell at school.

show of hands- *raise hands in a classroom or other group to vote or see what people think about something*---After a show of hands the class voted to go on a field trip the next week.

(in) single file- *stand in a line with one person behind the other*---The students lined up in single file before they entered the auditorium.

take attendance- *record the names of persons who are attending school or something similar*---After our teacher took attendance we began to do our math lesson.

take the roll- *call the names of students in an attendance book and expect them to answer if they are there*---The teacher took the roll and then we started the lesson.

teach one's grandmother to suck eggs-*try to tell or teach someone who knows more than you do how to do something*---Teaching some of the children how to use a computer is like teaching my grandmother to suck eggs. Many of them know more than I do.

teach someone a lesson- *do something to someone in order to punish them for their bad behavior*---My friend was always late so I taught her a lesson and left our meeting place before she had arrived.

teacher's pet- *the teacher's favorite student*---My sister was always the teacher's pet when she was in the first grade at school.

the three R's- *the three basic skills for a basic education - reading, (w)riting, and (a)rithmetic*---My father studied in a small country school where they studied the three R's and almost nothing else.

town-and-gown- *the relations (often bad) between a town and its people and the university and university students who are located in that town*---There were town-and-gown conflicts every year around graduation time when many parties were held for the new graduates.

university of life- *learning from daily life and work rather than going to university*---My grandfather began to work on the family farm when he was fourteen and learned everything from the University of Life.

work one's way through college- *work at a job to help pay for your college or university expenses*---My brother worked his way through college at the local supermarket.

Eye, Ear & Nose Idioms

all ears-*very eager to hear, very attentive*---My sister was all ears last night when I began to talk about starting a home business.

all eyes- *watching very closely, wide-eyed with surprise*---He is all eyes when he goes to a basketball game.

**apple of one`s eye**- *a cherished person or object*---The young girl is the apple of her father`s eye.

bat an eye/eyelash- *show surprise, fear or interest; show one`s feelings (neg.)*---Our boss didn`t bat an eyelash when we told him that we were going to go home early today.

**believe one`s ears**- *believe what one hears, become sure of (something)*---I couldn`t believe my ears when I heard that I had won a holiday in Mexico.

**believe one`s eyes**- *believe what one sees, become sure of seeing something*---We couldn`t believe our eyes when we saw the three bears on the highway.

**bug in one`s ear**- *a hint, an idea*---We put a bug into our parent`s ear when we said that we would like to go to Greece with them.

**catch one`s eye**- *attract one`s attention*---I tried to catch my friend`s eye at the movie theater but he didn`t notice me.

cut off one`s nose to spite one`s face-*make things worse for oneself because one is angry - usually at someone else*---When he decided not to go to the party he was cutting off his nose to spite his face. He was the one who lost out on a good opportunity to meet many new people.

ear to the ground- *direct one`s attention to the way things are going or to the way people feel and think*---I have been keeping my ear to the ground to see what is going to happen with the new owners of this company.

eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth- *every crime or injury should be punished or paid back*---Some politicians are always calling for an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth when they hear of a terrible crime.

eyes are bigger than one`s stomach- *one takes more food than one can eat*---His eyes were bigger than his stomach when he went to the restaurant and ordered too much food.

**eyes in the back of one`s head**- *ability to know what happens when one`s back is turned*---The teacher has eyes in the back of her head and always knows what is going on in the classroom.

eyes pop out- *one is very surprised*---My eyes popped out when I saw the new computer that I had gotten for my birthday.

**flea in one`s ear**- *an idea or answer that is not welcome*---The idea about changing the schedules is a flea in the supervisor`s ear that we wish he would forget.

get the eye- *be looked at - for interest and liking or unfriendliness*---We got the eye from the manager of the restaurant when we entered in our old clothes.

give someone the eye- *look at someone*---I gave the woman in the restaurant the eye but she totally ignored me.

hard-nosed- *not weak or soft, stubborn*---The union took a hard-nosed position in the contract negotiations.

have an eye for- *be able to judge correctly, have good taste in*---My father has an eye for ceramic plates and has a large collection of them.

have eyes only for- *see or want nothing else, give all one`s attention*---He only has eyes for the woman who works in his office.

have one's nose in something- *unwelcome interest in something, impolite curiosity*---My boss always has his nose in other peoples' business so he is not very well-liked.

hit between the eyes- *make a strong impression on, surprise greatly*---The news about the accident hit us between the eyes and totally shocked us.

in one`s mind`s eye- *in one`s imagination*---I tried to relax and in my mind`s eye pretend that I was on a beautiful island.

keep an eye on- *watch carefully, continue paying attention to*---I asked my aunt to keep an eye on our apartment when we went away for our holiday.

**keep one`s nose clean**- *stay out of trouble*---The judge told the young man that he must keep his nose clean if he didn`t want to go to jail in the future.

**keep one`s nose out of something**- *keep out of or away from*---I wish that the secretary at our office would keep her nose out of other people`s business.

keep one`s nose to the grindstone- *work hard or keep busy for a long time*---He has been keeping his nose to the grindstone all year so that he can save up enough money for a new car.

lay/set eyes on- *see*---I have not set eyes on his new car yet even though he bought it last month.

lead by the nose- *make or persuade someone to do anything you want*---My sister has been leading her husband by the nose since they got married.

lend/give an ear to- *listen to*---I try to lend an ear to all of my friends when they have a personal problem that they want to talk about.

look down one`s nose at- *think of as worthless, feel scorn for*---She looks down her nose at people who she thinks are not as smart as she is.

make eyes at- *try to attract someone, flirt*---The woman in the restaurant is always making eyes at the customers who she likes.

nose about/around- *look for something private or secret, explore, pry*---The reporters spend a lot of time nosing around in the business of famous people.

pay through the nose- *pay too much*---My mother paid through the nose for her new dress but she is very happy with it.

play by ear- *decide what to do as one goes along to fit the situation*---I don`t know what time I will be back on Sunday so we should play it by ear as to a good time to meet.

play by ear- *play a musical instrument by remembering the tune - not by reading the music*---My sister learned to play the piano by ear when she was 8 years old.

**pull the wool over one`s eyes**- *deceive, fool someone into thinking well of someone*---The girl tried to pull the wool over her mother`s eyes when she said that she had been studying all weekend.

raise eyebrows- *cause surprise or disapproval*---I raised many eyebrows when I came in to work two hours late this morning.

see eye to eye- *agree fully, hold the same opinion*---I never see eye to eye with my wife about what television program to watch.

skin off one`s nose- *matter of interest, concern or trouble to one*---It is no skin off my nose as to whether or not I get invited to the party or not.

stars in one`s eyes- *an appearance or feeling of very great happiness*---She had stars in her eyes when she won first prize in the speech contest.

thumb one`s nose- *look with disfavor or dislike, refuse to obey*---My friend thumbed his nose at me when I asked him to stop talking so loud.

to the naked eye- *as it is seen, apparently*---To the naked eye it looked like there was no damage to the car but actually there was a lot of damage.

turn a deaf ear to- *pretend not to hear, not pay attention*---I turned a deaf ear to the complaints of my friend about the heat.

turn up one`s nose at- *refuse as not being good enough for someone*---My sister turned up her nose at the chance to go to nursing school.

under one`s nose- *in sight of, easily seen*---I thought that I had lost my house keys but I found them right under my nose.

wet behind the ears- *inexperienced, new in a job or place*---He is still wet behind the ears and doesn`t know very much at all about this company.

Fish, Insects & Reptiles Idioms

ants in one`s pants- *nervous over activity, restlessness*---The teacher asked the little boy if he had ants in his pants when he kept moving around in his seat.

**bee in one`s bonnet**- *a fixed idea that seems crazy*---She has a bee in her bonnet and she won`t stop talking about moving to a new apartment.

big fish in a small pond- *an important person in a small place*---He wasn`t so important in the big city but in the small town he is a big fish in a small pond.

birds and bees- *facts about sex and birth*---The girl`s mother told her daughter about the birds and the bees during the summer holidays.

bug-eyed- *wide-eyed with surprise*---The little boy was bug-eyed when he got a new bicycle for a birthday present.

**bug in one`s ear**- *a hint, an idea*---You put a bug in his ear about a holiday to France and he won`t stop talking about it.

bug someone- *annoy or irritate someone*---My friend is beginning to bug me with his constant questions.

butterflies in one`s stomach- *feeling of fear or anxiety in the stomach*---I had butterflies in my stomach on the day that I was to receive the award.

can of worms- *complex problem or complicated situation*---It opened up a large can of worms when the company decided to talk about the union contract.

clam up- *stop talking*---He had to clam up during the meeting so his boss wouldn`t become angry with him.

cold fish- *person who is unfriendly or doesn`t mix with others*---He is a real cold fish and has no friends at his company at all.

crocodile tears- *a show of sorrow that is not really felt*---He cried crocodile tears when he discovered that he couldn`t go to the meeting.

fish for- *try to find out some information or ask for a compliment*---He has been fishing for a compliment about his new Italian suit.

fish out of water- *someone who does not fit in*---She felt like a fish out of water when she went to the party in her formal dress while everyone else was wearing jeans.

flea in one`s ear- *an idea or answer that is not welcome*---I think that I put a flea in his ear when I told him about the computer problems.

flea market- *place where antiques, secondhand things and cheap goods are sold*---We go to the flea market every Sunday to look for old phonographs.

fly in the ointment- *something small that spoils one`s fun*---His complaints about the food were a fly in the ointment and gave everyone a bad feeling about the gathering.

holy mackeral- *used to express a strong feeling of surprise*---"Holy mackeral! Look at the size of that man`s motorcycle."

kettle of fish- *the way something is (often used when one is irritated)*--- That`s a fine kettle of fish. Now I will be late for the next meeting.

louse up- *make a mess of or spoil something*---Please try not to louse up the computer again. It was working fine this morning.

mad as a hornet- *very angry, in a fighting mood*---He was as mad as a hornet when he came to work this morning.

make a beeline for- *go in a straight line*---Whenever he goes to a football game he always makes a beeline for the food stand.

neither fish nor fowl- *something or someone that does not belong to a definite group*---I don`t know what you should call it. It is neither fish nor fowl.

**snail`s pace**- *very slow movement forward*---We went away for the weekend but the cars were moving at a snail`s pace when we came home on Sunday.

**stir up a hornet`s nest**- *make many people angry*---He really stirred up a hornet`s nest when he went to the meeting and started talking about the garbage problem.

**world is one`s oyster**- *one can get anything that one wants*---When you graduate from university the world will be your oyster so don`t worry about the future.

Food Idioms

**apple of one`s eye**- *someone or something that one likes a lot*---The little girl is the apple of her grandfather`s eye.

back to the salt mines- *back to work, humorous expression to express going back to unpleasant work*---"Well, lunch is over so let`s go back to the salt mines for the afternoon."

bad egg- *a bad person, bum*---That man is a bad egg so you should try and avoid him if you can.

big cheese- *an important person, a leader*---He is a big cheese in his company so you should be very nice to him.

bread and butter- *basic needs of life (food, shelter, clothing)*---The voters are worried about bread and butter issues like jobs and taxes.

bring home the bacon- *earn your family`s living*---Recently he has been working very hard trying to bring home the bacon. He has no time to do anything else.

butter up- *flatter someone to try to get their favor or friendship*---He spends most of his free time trying to butter up his boss so that he won`t have to work so hard.

carrot and stick- *promising to reward and punish someone at the same time*---The government took a carrot and stick approach to the people who were illegally protesting against the construction of the dam.

chew the fat- *chat*---We stayed up very late last night chewing the fat about our university days.

coffee break- *a break from work to rest and drink coffee*---We usually take a 15-minute coffee break every morning about 10 o`clock.

cool as a cucumber- *calm, not nervous or anxious*---He is always as cool as a cucumber and never worries about anything.

cream of the crop- *best of a group, the top choice*---The company is well-known as a good place to work and is always able to hire the cream of the crop of university graduates.

cry over spilt milk- *cry or complain about something that has already happened*---You shouldn't cry over spilt milk. The past is past and you can`t do anything to change it.

cup of tea- *something one enjoys or does well (usually used in the negative)*---Going to art galleries is not my cup of tea so I think that I will stay home this evening and not go with you.

cut the mustard- *succeed, do adequately what needs to be done*---He wasn`t able to cut the mustard so he had to leave the army after only one year.

duck soup- *a task that doesn`t require much effort*---It was duck soup. I was able to finish everything early last night.

eat crow- *admit one is mistaken or defeated, take back a mistaken statement*---I was forced to eat crow and had to apologize for the mistake that I made about the restructuring of our company.

eat dirt- *act humble, accept another`s insult or bad treatment*---We made him eat dirt after he accused us of lying about the salary cut.

eat humble pie- *be humbled, admit one`s error and apologize*---Our boss was forced to eat humble pie after everyone realized that he had made the wrong budget estimate for next year.

eat one`s cake and have it too- *use or spend something and still keep it*---He refuses to give up anything and always wants to eat his cake and have it too.

eat one`s words- *take back something one has said, admit something is not true*---I told my boss that I would be quitting but later I had to eat my words and tell him that I wanted to stay.

egg on- *urge someone on*---Many people at the football game were egged on by the drunken fans.

finger in the pie- *participate in something that is happening*---He always tries to keep his finger in the pie so that he can control everything.

full of beans- *feel energetic, in high spirits*---She is full of beans tonight and doesn`t want to stop talking.

gravy train- *a job or work that pays more than it is worth*---For many years his job was a real gravy train but now the company has become very strict and will not pay overtime.

half-baked- *not thought out or studied carefully*---He has a half-baked idea about starting a new business but most of us think that it will fail.

hand to someone on a silver platter- *give a person something that has not been earned*---His education was handed to him on a silver platter and now he is very spoiled and selfish.

hard nut to crack- *something or someone difficult to understand or do*---He is a very serious person and is a very hard nut to crack.

(get or) have egg on one`s face - *be embarrassed*---He has egg on his face because everyone knows that he was sick at the party.

hit the sauce- *drink alcohol (usually regularly)*---I think that she has begun to hit the sauce since her husband lost his job.

hot potato- *a question or argument that is controversial and difficult to settle*---The issue of building the nuclear power plant is a real hot potato for the local town council.

in a nutshell- *briefly, in a few words*---We went to the meeting and they told us in a nutshell what would be happening to everyone next year.

in the soup- *in serious trouble, in disorder*---She is really in the soup now. She told her boss that she was sick but he saw her downtown shopping.

make one`s mouth water- *look or smell very good, want to eat or drink very much*---The restaurant is supposed to be wonderful and every time that I see the menu it makes my mouth water.

nutty as a fruitcake- *crazy*---He is a very nice man but he acts strange sometimes and I often think that he is as nutty as a fruitcake.

out of the frying pan and into the fire- *go from something bad to something worse*---She quit the job because of some small problems but she has jumped out of the frying pan and into the fire because now her problems are much worse.

out to lunch - *crazy, mad*---She is totally out to lunch and you should never believe what she tells you.

piece of cake- *a task that is easily accomplished*---It was a piece of cake. I had everything done before lunch this morning.

polish the apple- *flatter someone*---Nobody likes her because she is always trying to polish the apple with her teacher.

souped up- *change something to make it faster or more powerful by changing or adding something*---The new car that his neighbor bought is a souped up model of the one that he had last year.

salt away - *save money*---He has been working there for seven years and has been able to salt away quite a lot of money.

sell like hotcakes- *sell quickly or rapidly*---The new CD has only been released for about a week but already it is selling like hotcakes.

spill the beans- *tell a secret to someone who is not supposed to know about it*---Please don`t spill the beans about my plans to quit working and go back to school next year.

stew in one`s own juice- *suffer from something that one has caused to happen*---He is the one who caused the problem for himself and he is now being forced to stew in his own juice.

take with a grain of salt- *accept or believe only part of something*---You should take everything that he says with a grain of salt as everyone knows that he likes to exaggerate things when he is speaking.

upset the applecart- *ruin a plan or event by surprise or accident*---Everything was going well at the company gathering until he came along and upset the apple cart.

worth one`s salt- *being a good worker, worth what one is paid*---He has only been working here for a month but over and over he has proved that he is worth his salt.

Head, Mind & Mouth Idioms

absent-minded- *forgetful*---Our neighbor is very absent-minded and is always getting locked out of his house.

armed to the teeth- *fully armed, having many weapons*---The robbers were armed to the teeth when they robbed the bank.

at or on the tip of one`s tongue- *at the point of being said, almost remembered*---My former teacher's name is on the tip of my tongue and I will soon remember it.

bad-mouth- *say bad things about someone*---The football players are always bad-mouthing their coach.

beat into one`s head- *teach by telling again and again, drill*---I have been trying to beat the history material into the student's head.

beat one`s brains out- *tire oneself out by thinking too much*---I have been beating my brains out all day trying to remember who we should invite to the party.

beat one`s head against a wall- *struggle uselessly against something, not succeed after trying very hard*---You are beating your head against the wall trying to figure out what the new boss wants.

big head- *too high an opinion of one's own ability or importance, conceit*---He has a big head since he won the speech contest at university.

blow one`s mind- *become wildly enthusiastic over something as if understanding it for the first time in an entirely new light*---My friend told me that if I read the new book it would blow my mind.

blue in the face- *very angry or upset, excited and very emotional*---He argued with the supervisor until he was blue in the face.

boggle the mind- *stop the normal thinking process by being fantastic or incredible, unbelievable*---It really boggles the mind when you think how quickly the Internet began to have a major impact on people's lives.

born with a silver spoon in one`s mouth- *born to wealth and comfort, born rich*---The boy was born with a silver spoon in his mouth and has never had to work at all in his life.

bonehead- *an unusually dense or stupid person*---He is such a bonehead. He never understands what other people are trying to tell him.

brain drain- *the loss of talented and educated people of one country to other countries where conditions are better*---There is a brain drain from many countries to the United States where some conditions are very good.

button one`s lip- *stop talking, keep a secret, be quiet*---Please button your lip so that we can hear what the speaker is saying.

by the skin of one`s teeth- *by a narrow margin, barely*---We were able to catch the train by the skin of our teeth.

by the sweat of one`s brow- *by hard work*---He built up the business by the sweat of his brow.

by word of mouth- *orally, from person to person by the spoken word*---I learned that there would be a holiday next week by word of mouth.

cat get`s one`s tongue- *one is not willing to talk because of shyness*--- The cat seemed to have gotten her tongue and she was not able to say anything.

cheek by jowl- *side by side, close together*---The boxes were placed in the room cheek by jowl and nothing else could fit in.

cross one`s mind- *be a sudden or passing thought, come to one's mind*--- It suddenly crossed my mind that the store would be closed all day on Monday.

curl one`s hair- *shock, frighten, horrify*---The movie is very realistic and many of the scenes will curl your hair.

foam at the mouth- *be very angry (like a mad dog)*---The girl's father was so angry that he was almost foaming at the mouth.

get through one`s head- *understand or believe*---It was difficult to get it through the bank manager's head that I didn't want to borrow any more money.

give someone a piece of one`s mind- *scold angrily, say what one really thinks to someone*---I gave the store manager a piece of my mind when I told him about the broken product.

go to one`s head- *make someone too proud, make a person think that he or she is too important*---I think that his new job has gone to his head and he thinks that he is better than everyone else.

go to one's head- *make one dizzy*---The alcohol quickly went to his head and he had to sit down for awhile.

hair stands on end- *the hair of one's head rises because of fright*---My hair stood on end when I saw the large dog run out and begin to bark at me.

have rocks in one`s head- *be stupid, not have good judgment*---He must have rocks in his head if he thinks that I am going to lend him any more money.

head above water- *out of difficulty, clear of trouble*---My brother has been having a hard time keeping his head above water since he lost his job.

head-hunting- *search for qualified individuals to fill certain positions*---The company has been head-hunting for many months in order to try and find a new president.

head-on- *with the head or front pointing at something, with the front facing something*---There was a head-on crash last night near our house that left three people dead.

head over heels- *upside down, head first*---The little boy fell head over heels in love with the girl in his class.

head shrinker- *psychiatrist*---When I was a child my next door neighbor was a head shrinker.

hide/bury one`s head in the sand- *keep from seeing, knowing or understanding something dangerous or unpleasant, refuse to see or face something*---His father always buries his head in the sand and never wants to deal with any problems.

hold one`s tongue- *be silent, not talk*---"Please hold your tongue", the teacher said to the young boy.

in one`s face- *abruptly, unexpectedly*---The plan to have a going away party for our boss blew up in our face when we heard he would not attend.

in one`s hair- *bothering one, always annoying someone*---My sister's small son is always in her hair when she is making dinner.

keep a stiff upper lip- *be brave, face trouble bravely*---We managed to keep a stiff upper lip when the company announced that they would close down our office.

keep one`s chin up- *be brave, be determined, face trouble with courage*---My brother is trying to keep his chin up even though he has lost his job.

keep one`s head- *stay calm when there is trouble or danger*---Everyone tried to keep their head during the fire at the hotel.

keep one`s mouth shut- *be or stay silent*---I tried hard to keep my mouth shut during the salesman's speech.

leave a bad taste in one`s mouth- *make a bad impression, make or feel disgusted*---The way that the company treated the workers left a bad taste in our mouth.

let one`s hair down- *act freely and naturally, relax*---We were able to let our hair down at the party and have a good time.

lip service- *support for something shown by words but not by actions*---The politician paid lip service to the proposal to build a new subway system but he didn't really want one.

long face- *a sad or disappointed look*---He had a long face after he was fired from his job.

lose face- *be embarrassed or ashamed by an error or failure, lose self-respect*---The manager lost face when the person that she hired to help her was useless as a worker.

loudmouth/bigmouth- *a noisy, boastful or foolish talker*---My friend is a loudmouth and is always making foolish plans that he never carries out.

make head or tail of something (usually negative) - *find meaning in , understand*---I was unable to make head nor tail of our company's plans to restructure our department.

make one`s mouth water- *look or smell very good, make one want to eat or drink something one sees or smells*---The smell of the fish cooking in the restaurant made my mouth water.

make up one`s mind- *choose what to do, decide*---I have still not been able to make up my mind as to whether or not to return to school.

melt in one`s mouth- *be so tender as to seem to need no chewing, taste very good*---The pasta served at the new restaurant melted in our mouth.

off the top of one`s head- *without thinking hard, quickly*---I was unable to remember the name of the restaurant off the top of my head.

on/upon one`s head- *on one's self*---The little boy brought the anger of his parent's upon his head.

out of one`s hair- *get rid of a nuisance or annoyance*---My sister wants to get her daughter permanently out of her hair.

over one`s head- *not understandable, beyond one's ability to understand*---The mathematics lectures went over my head during the first few weeks.

pick the brains of- *get ideas or information about something by asking an expert*---We picked the brains of the official who was sent to talk about the pollution problem.

put one`s foot in one`s mouth- *get into trouble by saying something embarrassing or rude*---My colleague put his foot in his mouth when he told everyone that he didn't like the new manager.

put our heads together- *confer, discuss, talk*---We put our heads together with the other members of the department to try and find a solution to the problem.

put (something or someone) out of one's head/mind- *try to forget someone or something*---I was forced to put my holidays out of my head when we had the emergency problems at our company.

put words into one`s mouth- *say without proof that another person has certain feelings or opinions*---My boss was putting words into my mouth when he told me what he thought that I wanted to do.

rack one`s brain- *try one's best to think, make a great mental effort*---I racked my brain for over an hour to try and figure out what to do about the problem with the new computer.

ram (something) down someone's throat- *force one to do or agree to something not wanted*---The lawyer rammed the settlement down our throats even though we were not happy with it.

save face- *save one's good reputation, popularity or dignity when something has happened to hurt him or her*---The government was unable to save face after they failed to reach an agreement with the union over pension benefits.

say a mouthful- *say something of great importance or meaning, say more by a sentence than the words usually mean*---The little boy said a mouthful when he began to talk about the complicated history material.

sink (get) one`s teeth into something- *have something real or solid to think about, struggle with*---I was finally able to sink my teeth into the problem and began to find a solution.

slap in the face- *insult*---The fact that an extreme candidate won the election was a slap in the face to the moderate voters.

slip of the tongue- *the mistake of saying something one had not wanted or planned to say, an error of speech*---I made a slip of the tongue when I told the woman who everyone hates that we would have a party.

split hairs- *find and argue about small and unimportant differences*---My boss is always splitting hairs when I try and talk to him about something important.

swelled head- *a feeling that one is very important or more important than one really is*---My sister has a swelled head since she got the new job that many people had applied for.

take it on the chin- *be badly beaten or hurt, get into trouble*---He was forced to take it on the chin when he got into the fight with the man at the store.

take the words out of one`s mouth- *say what another was just going to say, put another's thoughts into words*---He took the words right out of my mouth when he said that he wanted to go and get something to eat.

tooth and nail- *fiercely, fighting as hard as possible*---We fought tooth and nail to get the new wing of the hospital opened.

turn the other cheek- *let someone do something to one and not do it in return, not hit back when hit*---We were told in school that we should always turn the other cheek when we were attacked by someone.

up to the chin in- *very busy with, working hard at, having very much or many of*---She has been up to her chin all morning in work to try and get ready for the party.

use one`s head- *use one's brain or mind, think, have common sense*---Sometimes I think that the manager of the video store never uses her head at all when you ask her a question.

Heart Idioms

**after one`s own heart**- *well-liked for agreeing with one`s own feelings, interests and ideas*---My new boss loves to go fishing every weekend. He is a man after my own heart.

at heart- *in spite of, in reality*---He seems to be very angry all the time but at heart he is a very gentle person.

break one`s heart- *make very sad or hopeless*---It broke my heart to see the woman fall down during the race after she had tried so hard.

change of heart- *a change in the way one feels about something*---I had a change of heart about not going to Europe for my holiday and finally decided to go.

cross one`s heart and hope to die- *say that what one has said is surely true (often used by children)*---"I promise that I will meet you tomorrow. Cross my heart and hope to die."

**eat one`s heart out**- *grieve long and hopelessly for something, want something*---"You can eat your heart out but I won`t give you a piece of this chocolate bar."

**from the bottom of one`s heart**- *with great feeling, sincerely*---My sister thanked the man from the bottom of her heart for saving her dog`s life.

from the heart- *sincerely, honestly*---The President gave a speech from the heart after the terrible earthquake.

get to the heart of (a matter)- *understand the most important thing about something*---It took a long time but we finally got to the heart of the matter about the new employee.

heart goes out to- *one feels very sorry for, one feels sympathy for*---My heart goes out to the victims of the hurricane that recently struck.

heart is in the right place- *kindhearted, sympathetic or well-meaning*---Although she makes a lot of mistakes her heart is in the right place.

heart of gold- *a kind, generous or forgiving nature*---My grandmother has a heart of gold and is always willing to help a stranger.

heart of stone- *a nature without pity*---The man who murdered his wife and children has a heart of stone.

heart skips a beat- *be startled or excited from surprise, joy or fright*---My heart skipped a beat when I saw my name on the television screen.

heart stands still- *be very frightened or worried*---My heart stood still when the truck on the highway almost hit our car.

heart-to-heart- *speaking freely and seriously about something private*---I had a heart-to-heart talk with my girlfriend last evening.

heavy heart- *a feeling of being weighed down with sorrow, unhappiness* We left the meeting with a heavy heart when we heard that our boss would soon have to leave the company because of illness.

lose heart- *feel discouraged because of failure, lose hope of success*---I tried not to lose heart even though I had failed my driver`s exam for the second time.

**open one`s heart**- *talk about one`s feelings honestly, confide in someone*---She suddenly opened her heart when I began talking to her on the bus.

**search one`s heart/soul**- *study one`s reasons and acts, try to discover if one has been fair and honest*---I spent a lot of time searching my soul in order to try and find out why my girlfriend had left me.

set/have one`s heart set on- *want very much*---I had my heart set on getting a dog for my birthday when I was a child but I never got one.

take heart- *be encouraged, feel braver and want to try*---He took heart in the fact that his son was still going to school even though he was failing most of his courses.

wear one`s heart on one`s sleeve- *show one`s feelings openly*---After the going away party the salesman was wearing his heart on his sleeve.

**with all one`s heart**- *with great feeling, sincerely*---I tried with all my heart to get my friend to go with me for a holiday but he wouldn`t come.

Horse Idioms

as strong as a horse/lion/ox- *very strong*---The man was as strong as an ox and easily helped us move the sofa.

as stubborn as a mule- *very stubborn*---My friend is as stubborn as a mule and you can never make her change her mind.

back the wrong horse- *support someone or something that cannot win or succeed*---We were backing the wrong horse when we decided to support the new candidate for mayor.

bet on the wrong horse- *misread the future*---He is betting on the wrong horse if he supports the other city in their bid for the games.

by shank's mare- *by foot*---I came to the meeting by shank's mare.

champ/chomp at the bit- *be ready and anxious to do something (a bit is put in a horse's mouth for control of the horse)*---Everyone was chomping at the bit to get started on their holiday.

change horses in midstream- *make new plans or choose a new leader in an activity that has already begun*---They have decided to change lawyers but I told them that they shouldn`t change horses in midstream.

a dark horse- *a candidate little known to the general public*---He was a dark horse in the race to be the next mayor until he gave some good speeches on TV.

dog and pony show- *something that you disapprove of because you think that it has only been organized to impress you (like a dog and pony show in a circus)*---We had serious questions about the viability of continuing with the project but all we got was a dog and pony show when we asked for answers from our business partners.

donkey's years- *a very long time*---I talked to my friend for a long time because I hadn't seen her in donkey's years.

eat like a horse- *eat a lot*---Her brother eats like a horse.

flog/beat a dead horse- *continue fighting a battle that has been won, continue to argue a point that has been settled*---My friend was flogging a dead horse when she wouldn't stop arguing about the mistake on her paycheck.

get off one`s high horse- *begin to be humble and agreeable*---I wish that she would get off her high horse and begin to think about how other people feel about things.

get on one`s high horse - *behave with arrogance*---She is always getting on her high horse and telling people what to do.

hold one`s horses- *wait, be patient*---"Hold your horses for a moment while I make a phone call."

to hoof it- *to walk or run (a hoof is the foot of a horse/sheep/cow etc.)*---I decided to hoof it when I came downtown this morning.

to horse around- *to play around (in a rough way)*---The teacher told the children to stop horsing around and get ready for class.

a horse of a different color- *something totally separate and different*---Changing locations is a horse of a different color. It was never mentioned in any of our meetings.

horse sense- *common sense, practical thinking*---He doesn`t have much horse sense and sometimes makes the wrong decision.

to horse trade- *hard and skillful bargaining*---We had to do some horse trading but finally we reached a deal to buy the new house.

lock the barn door after the horse is gone- *be careful, try to make something certain after it is too late*---Now my friend wants to fix his house but it is like locking the barn door after the horse is gone. There was a flood and the damage is done.

look a gift horse in the mouth- *complain if a gift is not perfect*---He shouldn`t look a gift horse in the mouth and should be happy that he got a present from his friends.

on horseback- *on the back of a horse*---We rode out to the old red barn on horseback.

put (someone or something) out to pasture- *retire someone or something (just as you would put a horse that is too old to work out to pasture)*---We finally decided to put our old car out to pasture and buy a new one.

put the cart before the horse- *do things in the wrong order*---I think that buying a ticket before we make any holiday plans is putting the cart before the horse.

ride herd on (someone)- *watch closely and strictly supervise someone (as a cowboy would supervise a herd of cattle)*---He has been riding herd on his employees so that he can get the job done quickly.

**straight from the horse`s mouth**- *directly from the person who said something, from a dependable source*---I heard straight from the horse`s mouth that she will be leaving the company next week.

wild horses couldn't drag (someone away)- *there is nothing that will force someone to go somewhere or do something*---Wild horses couldn't drag me away from my favorite TV show last night.

work like a horse- *work very hard*---My grandfather worked like a horse when he was a young man.

you can lead a horse to water (but you can't make it drink)- *you can give someone the opportunity to do something but you can't force him or her to do it if they don't want to*---You can lead a horse to water but you can't make it drink and no matter how hard we try to help my cousin get a job he won't make any effort when we introduce him to someone who knows about a job.

Legal Idioms

after the fact- *after something (a crime etc.) has occurred*---We were told, after the fact, that the company would not pay compensation to the fire victims.

an act of God- *an event or accident due to natural causes for which no human is responsible and which could not have been avoided by planning ahead (a storm, an earthquake, a volcano etc.)*---The insurance company refused to pay the money because they said that the forest fire was an act of God.

assemble a case (against someone)- *gather the evidence needed to make a legal case against someone*---The prosecution was unable to assemble a case against the man.

assume liability- *accept the responsibility for paying the cost of something*---The business refused to assume liability for the dangerous products.

at arms length- *at a distance, a transaction in which each person (who is not related to you) acts in their own self-interest*---We purchased the property at arm's length and were not involved in any management decisions.

bail (someone) out- *pay a sum of money that allows someone to get out of jail while waiting for a trial*---The family of the accused criminal paid much money to bail him out.

beyond a reasonable doubt- *a legal phrase meaning that something is almost certain*---The judge sent the man to jail because he believed, beyond a reasonable doubt, that he had committed the crime.

bona fide- *"in good faith" (from Latin), without any element of dishonesty or fraud*---The mediator asked the two sides in the dispute to make a bona fide effort to solve the dispute.

a breach of promise- *the breaking of a promise which may also be a breach of contract*---The couple was accused of breach of promise when they broke the contract to buy the condominium.

a breach of the peace- *causing a disturbance, violent or disorderly behavior*---The man was charged with breach of the peace when he began fighting with the store clerk.

break the law- *fail to obey the law*---The woman was forced to quit her job after it was discovered that she had broken the law.

build a case (against someone)- *gather the evidence needed to make a legal case against someone*---The legal team was working hard to build a case against the suspected car thief.

burden of proof- *the necessity to prove a disputed fact as required by the laws of evidence*---The burden of proof during the trial fell on the man who had accused his employee of theft.

(do something) by the book- *follow all the rules when you do something*---Our lawyer is very good and he does everything by the book.

a case of mistaken identity- *incorrectly identify someone*---The young man was arrested in a case of mistaken identity.

causing a disturbance- *an offence committed by fighting/screaming/shouting/swearing or being drunk in public*---Several of the fans were arrested for causing a disturbance after the football game.

caveat emptor- *"let the buyer beware" (from Latin), a buyer of something is responsible to examine the goods that he or she has purchased*---Caveat emptor is a good concept to remember when you are buying a used car.

to cease and desist- *a legal phrase which means to stop doing something and not start again - often used in the form of a cease and desist order*---The woman's husband was given a cease and desist order to stop bothering her.

circumstantial evidence- *indirect evidence*---My court case was difficult to win as most of my evidence was circumstantial evidence.

citizen's arrest- *an arrest which may be made by somebody without a warrant when somebody commits a crime*---The local politician tried to make a citizen's arrest of the violent beggar.

civil action- *legal action that deals with private or civil matters*---The couple decided to take civil action over their complaints about their neighbor's dog.

civil law- *the area of the law which deals with civil/private matters such as violations of contracts (different from criminal law)*---The lawyer had much experience in civil law and almost none in criminal law.

class action lawsuit- *a lawsuit on behalf of a group of persons in a similar situation or who have suffered a similar wrong*---The workers filed a class action lawsuit against the company for damage to their health.

come by (something) honestly- *get something honestly*---The woman came by a large amount of money honestly but many people wondered where it had come from.

come clean (with someone/about something)- *be completely honest with someone or confess something to someone*---The man decided to come clean with the police and he confessed everything about the crime.

commercial law- *the area of law that governs commerce/trade/ merchandising*---The lawyer has specialized in commercial law since he first became a lawyer.

common law- *the law that is not written in statutes but is based on custom and court decisions of the past (most often with its origin in the old unwritten law of England)*---Through research into previous cases of common law we were able to make a decision on how to proceed with our case.

common property- *real property owned by a group of tenants in a condominium or subdivision which everyone has the right to use, land that*

is owned by the government which everyone can use---The bicycles were common property and anyone in the apartment complex could use them.

community property- *property belonging jointly to a married couple or acquired during their marriage*---The couple decided to divide some of their community property and give it to their children before they left to do volunteer work overseas.

comparative negligence- *in a civil lawsuit where the fault (negligence) of the two parties is taken into account in assessing damages*---The judge determined that it was a case of comparative negligence and the landlord and the tenant were both forced to pay damages.

conclusive evidence- *evidence that is so strong that it proves the point in question beyond reasonable doubt*---The witness offered conclusive evidence that led to the conviction of the criminal.

conditional sale- *a contract where the title to the goods being sold will not go to the purchaser until a certain condition is fulfilled*---The sale of the house was a conditional sale and I had to talk to my bank manager before the deal was complete.

consecutive sentences- *sentences that are given to someone and which run one immediately after another*---The criminal was given three consecutive sentences for the murder of the young girls.

contempt of court- *disobedience of the orders and authority of the court, disrespect for the court process*---The judge ordered the man to be held in contempt of court when he was several hours late for the trial.

crack down on (someone or something)- *enforce a rule or law more strictly*---The police recently decided to crack down on speeding cars.

criminal law- *the law that is concerned with crimes by people against the state/society with the function to punish the offender*---The university law department had one of the best criminal law libraries in the country.

dangerous offender- *a person who has been convicted of a violent or sexual crime and is a continuing threat to others*---Several dangerous offenders escaped from the prison last week.

disorderly conduct- *disturbing the peace*---The football fans were charged with disorderly conduct after the fight during the game.

disturbing the peace- *disorderly/violent/threatening conduct, an interruption of the peace and tranquility of the community*---Two men were arrested for disturbing the peace when they got into a fight in front of the shopping mall.

draw up an agreement/contract- *put something into writing, prepare a written statement*---I spent several hours with my lawyer trying to draw up an agreement to buy the small business.

due process (of law)- *the rights that each individual has to be protected by the law*---Although the man was accused of theft by his employer, he knew that he was entitled to due process of law and would have no problems proving his innocence.

examination for discovery- *an oral examination that is taken under oath in which each side to a lawsuit has the right to examine the other side's witnesses before a trial or hearing*---The man spent several hours in an examination for discovery session in connection with his case.

expert witness- *an expert or specialist whose opinions are used as evidence in a trial or hearing*---The lawyer called in an expert witness to discuss the handwriting of the accused man.

extenuating circumstances- *special circumstances that explain an irregular or improper way of doing something*---Because of extenuating circumstances, the man was able to avoid going to jail for stealing the money.

false arrest- *unlawful physical detention*---It was a case of false arrest when the man was arrested as a suspect in the robbery.

false pretenses- *intentionally misrepresent facts to cheat or defraud someone*---The woman was acting under false pretenses when she went to the bank and asked for a loan.

false witness- *a person who deliberately offers inaccurate evidence*---The man was accused of being a false witness after he testified at the trial.

fee simple- *absolute title or ownership of real estate*---The property was sold fee simple by the woman.

for cause- *reasons which the law accepts as justified*---The man was fired from his job for cause after several violations of his contract.

free and clear- *own something fully with no money owed or other restrictions on the item or property*---My parents own their home free and clear.

give notice- *inform an employer, employee, landlord or tenant that a contractual agreement will end*---The woman gave notice that she will leave her job next month.

go into effect- *a law or rule becomes effective or in use*---The new parking law will go into effect at midnight.

go legit- *begin a legitimate (honest) business after having been operating an illegal business*---The brothers decided to go legit and get the proper licenses for their small business.

go on record- *make an official statement rather than an informal one*---The mayor of the city plans to go on record as being opposed to the new convention center.

goods and chattels- personal *property (as opposed to land and buildings)* ---All of the goods and chattels of the man were seized by the bank to pay for the bad loan.

grace period- *a period of time (often about 30 days) after the due date for something*---I was given a 30-day grace period in which to pay the speeding ticket.

gray area- *an area of a subject that is not clearly defined*---Smoking outside of public buildings is a gray area that the smoking law does not deal with.

grounded in fact- *based on facts*---The decisions that were made during the legal discussions were grounded in fact.

grounds for (something)- *a cause or reason for legal action such as a lawsuit*---The fact that the woman had lied to her employer was grounds for her being quickly fired from the company.

have a brush with the law- *have a brief experience or encounter with the law*---The man had a brush with the law when he was a teenager.

have a case (against someone)- *have lots of evidence that can be used against someone*---The police do not have a case against the young woman.

(do not) have a leg to stand on- *do not have the facts to support or win an argument or a legal charge that is made against you (usually used in the negative)*---The apartment manager tried to evict the young family but he didn't have a leg to stand on and he lost the case in court.

have a run-in with (the law/someone)- *have a bad or unpleasant encounter with the law/ someone*---The couple had a run-in with the law when they were on their holiday.

have (someone) dead to rights- *prove someone absolutely guilty*---The police had the man dead to rights when they videotaped him stealing the car.

have (someone) in one's pocket- *have control over someone*---The businessmen have the mayor of the city in their pocket.

have the right to (do something)- *have the freedom or legal right to do something*
The lawyer did not have the right to ask personal questions during the trial.

a hung jury- *a jury that is divided and unable to agree on a verdict*
There was a hung jury after the trial of the pop star.

implicate (someone) in (something)- *suggest that someone is involved in something*---The president of the company was implicated in the scandal over the expense account.

in abeyance- *the temporary suspension of an activity or a ruling*---My grandfather's estate settlement was in abeyance while the lawyers looked at his will in more detail.

in accordance with (something)- *conforming to something*---The new contract was written in accordance with the new employment law.

in arrears- *late or overdue (usually for bills and money)*---My account at the department store was in arrears so the manager phoned me.

in bad faith- *insincerity, with bad or dishonest intentions, the intention to deceive someone*---The manager was acting in bad faith when she refused to give the documents to the other department.

in consideration of (something)- *after thinking about something*---In consideration of the amount of time that I had spent on the case I charged a lot of money for my services.

in/have custody of (someone or something)- *being guarded or protected by someone or some group*---The police put the man in custody last night.

in debt- *owing money*---The woman is in debt to the furniture store.

in dispute- *something that is in disagreement*---Most parts of the agreement are not in dispute.

in effect- *a law that is necessary to obey*---The new law has been in effect for three months now.

in favor of- *in agreement with*---The members of the panel voted in favor of postponing the meeting.

in good faith- *with good and honest intentions*---I went to the mediation session in good faith to try and resolve the dispute.

in kind- *in goods rather than in money*---We were paid in kind for our time planning for the convention.

in lieu of (something)- *instead of something*---In lieu of being paid for our overtime work we were given extra time off.

in perpetuity- *forever, eternally*---The man was promised by the city that he would receive a discount on his water bill in perpetuity.

in person- *personally, yourself*---The man was asked to appear in the courtroom in person.

in plain English/language- *in simple and easy to understand language* The legal contract was written in plain English so that we could easily understand it.

in private- *secretly, not openly or in public*---The discussion between the two judges took place in private.

in public- *openly so others can see, not secretly*---The new smoking law does not permit smoking in public.

in receipt of (something)- *having received something*---My lawyer was already in receipt of the documents when he phoned me.

in reference to (something)- *concerning/regarding/about something*--- The letter was in reference to my earlier request for legal advice.

in (someone's) name- *in someone's ownership, as someone's property*--- We put the property in my name so that it would be easier to get a loan on it.

in the act of (doing something)- *while doing something*---The man was arrested in the act of stealing money from the cash register in the store.

in the right- *on the legal or moral side of an issue, not guilty*---I believed that I was in the right so I decided to take the case to court.

in the wrong- *on the illegal or wrong side of an issue, guilty*---The man was in the wrong and was easily found guilty by the court.

in trouble with the law- *due to be punished by the law*---The teenager has often been in trouble with the law.

in trust of (someone)- *under the responsibility or care of someone*---The money was given to the child in trust of his grandparents.

invasion of privacy- *the act of doing something so that someone loses his or her privacy*---Some people think that it is an invasion of privacy when there are video cameras in public places.

invest someone with the power or legal right to (do something)- *give someone the power or right to do something*---The police were invested with the power to enforce the decision of the court.

jump bail- *fail to appear in court and therefore give up the money that you paid for bail*---The criminal jumped bail and went to another city to hide.

last will and testament- *one's will (especially its latest edition) - a will is the legal term to describe what a person wants to do with his or her property after they die*---I went to a lawyer in order to write my last will and testament.

law-abiding- *obeying the law*---The couple were law-abiding citizens who never had any problems with the law.

a law unto oneself- *someone who makes his or her own laws or rules*--- The manager was a law unto herself and thought that she could do whatever she liked.

lay down the law- *state firmly what the rules or laws are for something*--- We decided to lay down the law regarding time off from work without pay for our employees.

a leading question- *a question to a witness designed to suggest or produce the reply desired by the questioner*---The lawyer asked the witness a leading question but she didn't answer it in the way that the lawyer had expected.

legal age- *the age when a person can do things such as buy cigarettes or when they are responsible for their actions*
The young men were not of legal age and were unable to buy any cigarettes.

let (someone) go- *free someone from prison or from an arrest*---The courts decided to let the man go because there was no evidence to keep him in prison.

lodge a complaint (against someone)- *make a complaint against someone*---The man decided to lodge a complaint against the company that had built the apartment building.

a matter of record- *a fact or event that is kept officially as a legal record*---It was a matter of record how much the mayor had spent on the foreign trip.

mineral rights- *the right to take minerals or money from the minerals on one's property*---The farmer owned all of the mineral rights on his property.

moral turpitude- *behavior that is contrary to accepted rules of behavior*---The judge accused the lawyer of moral turpitude after his questionable tactics to defend his client.

next of kin- *someone's closest relative or relatives*---The police notified the next of kin of the woman who was killed in the car accident.

null and void- *worthless, canceled*---The check which was written by the company was null and void.

of one's own free will/accord- *by one's own choice*---The woman signed the contract to buy the car of her own free will.

off the record- *unofficial, informal*---The judge told the lawyers off the record what they could expect the lawsuit to settle for.

offensive weapon- *any weapon capable of being used to cause physical injury or harm*---The young man with the knife was charged with carrying an offensive weapon.

on condition that- *providing that*---The man was not sent to prison on condition that he do volunteer work in the community.

on probation- *serving a period of probation - probation is when a person who is guilty of a crime is allowed to be free but is supervised by the government*---The man was on probation for robbing a small store last year.

on record- *an official recorded statement or fact that everyone may know*---The businessman was on record as having refused to accept any illegal money.

out on bail- *released from jail after you pay the bail bond money - the bail bond is the money that you must pay to guarantee that you will appear in court*---The man was out on bail while he was waiting for his trial.

out on parole- *out of jail but being supervised by the police*---While the criminal was out on parole he was forced to meet with a social worker every two weeks.

pay one's debt (to society)- *serve a sentence for a crime (usually in prison)*---The man was forced to pay his debt to society by going to prison for three years.

a peeping Tom- *someone who looks into someone's window (usually a woman) and watches them*---There were several reports of a peeping Tom near our apartment building.

penalty clause- *a section in a contract specifying an amount to be paid if the contract is not fulfilled*---There is a penalty clause in our apartment rental agreement if we decide to move out early.

post mortem- *a medical examination of a body made after death to determine the cause of death*---The authorities performed a post mortem on the dead man to try and determine the cause of his death.

power of attorney- *a legal document granting authority for one person to act as another's representative*---The woman was given power of attorney over her mother's business.

a preliminary hearing- *a hearing before a judge to determine if there is enough evidence to charge someone with a crime*---The man appeared at a preliminary hearing to determine the nature of the crime.

prima facie- *"at first view" (from Latin), something is assumed to be true in the absence of evidence to the contrary*---Prima facie it appeared that the man had enough evidence to take legal action against his employer.

privy to something- *have unique or special knowledge about something*---I was not privy to the conversation regarding the new business plan so I was unable to comment on it.

punitive damages- *extra damages awarded to someone in order to punish them and to deter others*---The patient was awarded a large amount of money as punitive damages in his lawsuit against the hospital.

put (something) down in black and white- *write something down, make or draw up a contract*---I put my strategy for the meeting down in black and white.

quid pro quo- *"something for something" (from Latin), mutual concessions made by the parties in a transaction*---The government and the teachers gave up some of their contract demands in a quid pro quo effort to solve their dispute.

the responsible party- *the party that is legally or morally obliged to do something or accept the blame for something*---The responsible party was forced to compensate the victims of his crimes.

run afoul of the law- *get into trouble with the law*---The young man ran afoul of the law and was taken into police custody.

serve notice on (someone)- *deliver a legal announcement or document to someone*---The company served notice on the union that they would be closing their factory next year.

set (someone) free- *release someone from prison or captivity*---The police set the man free when they decided that there was not enough evidence to keep him in prison.

to show cause- *to give a reason or explanation for something*---The lawyer was asked to show cause as to why the man was guilty of the crime.

to show good faith- *to demonstrate good intentions or good will*---We always show good faith when we meet the opposing side in our contract negotiations.

to sign on the dotted line- *to put your signature on a contract or other important document*---We went to the lawyer's office to sign on the dotted line of the contract to start the new business.

signed, sealed and delivered- *formally and officially sign something*---The contract was signed, sealed and delivered before we went home for the evening.

to skip bail- *to fail to appear in court and therefore give up the money that you paid for bail*---The amount of bail was set very high so the accused criminal would not skip bail.

small/fine print- *the part of a document or contract that may contain important information but is not easily noticed because the print is small*---It is a good idea to read the small print before you buy most products.

stand one's ground- *stand up for one's rights*---I stood my ground and refused to do anything that was not honest and the right thing to do.

the straight and narrow- *a straight and law-abiding route through life*---The young man was back on the straight and narrow after his discussions with the police officer and social worker.

to stretch the truth- *to misrepresent the truth (a little)*---The witness was stretching the truth when she told the judge her excuse for the crime.

subject to (something)- *depending on something*---The sale of the house is subject to our getting a report from the housing inspector.

take effect- *a law or rule becomes effective or in use*---There is a new law related to Internet advertising that will soon take effect.

take the law into one's own hands- *try to administer the law on your own*---The transit supervisor was taking the law into his own hands when he tried to arrest the man.

take precedence over (someone or something)- *have the right to come before someone or something else*---The protection of children and the family takes precedence over the laws regarding evicting people from an apartment after they have a baby.

to the letter- *precisely, exactly*---The lawyer always suggests that his clients follow the judge's decisions to the letter.

trumped-up- *false and exaggerated, invented by fraud or criminal deception*---The business owner was arrested on trumped-up charges.

turn a blind eye to (someone or something)- *pretend not to see someone or something that may be troublesome*---The police often turn a blind eye to people when they cross the street on a red light.

(to be) under a cloud (of suspicion)- *to be suspected of doing something wrong or illegal*---The manager of the coffee shop was fired from her job under a cloud of suspicion.

under age- *below the legal age to do something*---The boy was under age and was not able to buy any cigarettes.

under arrest- *arrested by the police before being charged with a crime*---The man was placed under arrest for stealing a car.

vicarious liability- *the liability of one person through the act of another*---It was a case of vicarious liability when the man was charged because of his friend's behavior.

with impunity- *without risk of punishment*---The man was able to continue to abuse his position and clients with impunity.

with no strings attached- *with no obligations attached*---The man was forced to agree to the terms of the agreement with no strings attached.

Medical Idioms

at death's door- *very near death*---The Prime Minister was at death's door after suffering a serious stroke.

back on one's feet- *physically healthy again*---My mother is back on her feet again after being sick with the flu for two weeks.

black out- *lose consciousness, faint*---The football player blacked out after being hit by the other player.

break out- *begin showing a rash or other skin disorder*---I broke out in a terrible rash after eating the raw shrimp at the restaurant.

breathe one's last- *to die*---The man finally breathed his last after a long illness.

bring around/round- *restore to health or consciousness, cure*---The medical workers were able to bring the man around after the accident.

bring to- *restore to consciousness, wake from sleep/anesthesia/ hypnosis/fainting etc*---The woman was brought to soon after the car accident.

catch a cold- *get a cold*---I caught a bad cold last week and had to miss three weeks of work.

catch one's death of cold- *become very ill (with a cold, flu etc.)*---The little boy was told to be careful in the rain or he would catch his death of cold.

check-up- *a periodic inspection of a patient by a doctor*---I went to have my annual check-up last week.

clean bill of health- *a report or certificate that a person or animal is healthy*---The doctor gave me a clean bill of health when I visited him last month.

come down with- *become sick with, catch*---My niece came down with a bad cold and was unable to visit me last week.

couch doctor- *a psychoanalyst who puts his patients on a couch*---He was sent to see a couch doctor after his continued problems at work.

dose/taste of one's own medicine- *being treated in the same way as one treats others (usually a negative meaning)*---Our boss got a taste of his own medicine when people began to ignore him as he had always done to them.

draw blood- *make someone bleed, get blood from someone*---The doctor decided to draw some blood from the patient to check up on his blood sugar level.

fall ill- *become sick or ill*---The man fell ill last winter and has not recovered yet.

feel on top of the world- *feel very healthy*---I have been feeling on top of the world since I quit my job.

flare up- *to begin again suddenly (illness etc.)*---My mother's skin problems flared up when she started to use the new laundry soap.

flare-up- *a sudden worsening of a health condition*---His arthritis usually flares up every winter.

go under the knife- *be operated on in surgery*---His wife went under the knife at the hospital last evening.

hang out one's shingle- *give public notice of the opening of a doctor's office etc*---The doctor decided to hang out his shingle as soon as he finished medical school.

have a physical (examination)- *get a medical check-up*---Our company sent all the employees to have a physical last week.

head shrinker- *a psychiatrist*---The man was told to go and see a head shrinker after he threatened the woman in the store several times.

just what the doctor ordered- *exactly what is needed or wanted*---A nice hot bath was just what the doctor ordered.

look the picture of health- *be in good health*---My uncle was looking the picture of health when I saw him last week.

on the mend- *healing, becoming better*---My grandfather is on the mend after he broke his leg last week.

out cold- *unconscious, in a faint*---As soon as the patient entered the operating room he was out cold because of the anesthesia.

over the worst- *recovering from an illness*---My brother is over the worst since his skiing accident last month.

pull through- *recover from a serious illness*---The car accident was very bad and I don't think that the driver will pull through.

run a temperature- *have a higher than normal body temperature*---The little boy is running a temperature and should stay in bed all day.

run down- *get into poor condition*---He was working very hard last month and has become very run down.

run some tests- *a doctor does some medical tests on a patient*---The doctor has decided to run some tests on the patient.

splitting headache- *a severe headache*---I have been suffering from a splitting headache all morning.

take a turn for the worse- *become sicker*---My aunt took a turn for the worse last week and is still in the hospital.

take someone's temperature- *measure someone's body temperature*---The nurse took my temperature when I went to the hospital yesterday.

throw up- *vomit*---The woman threw up several times after eating the bad shellfish.

under the weather- *not feeling well*---My boss has been feeling under the weather all week and has not come to work during that time.

Money Idioms

ante up- *pay, produce a necessary amount of money*---I had to ante up a lot of money to get my car fixed.

at all costs- *at any expense of time, effort or money*---He plans to go to school at all costs.

back on one`s feet- *return to good financial health*---My sister is back on her feet after losing her job last year.

bet one`s bottom dollar- *bet all one has on something*---I would bet my bottom dollar that the accounting manager will be late again today.

bet on the wrong horse- *base one`s plans on a wrong guess about the results of something*---He is betting on the wrong horse if he continues to support the other candidate for mayor.

born with a silver spoon in one`s mouth- *born to wealth and comfort, born rich*---The student in our history class was born with a silver spoon in his mouth and has never worked in his life.

bottom dollar- *one`s last dollar*---He spent his bottom dollar on some new clothes to wear for his job interview.

bottom line- *line in a financial statement that shows net income or loss*---The bottom line in the company's financial statement was much worse than expected.

bottom line- *final result, main point*---The bottom line was that we were unable to attend the conference because of our busy schedule.

break even- *have income equal to expenses*---Our company was able to break even after only six months of operation.

break the bank- *win all the money at a casino gambling table*---He broke the bank at the casino and walked away with a lot of money.

bring home the bacon- *earn the family living*---I have been working hard all month bringing home the bacon for my family.

burn a hole in one`s pocket- *money that one wishes or intends to spend quickly (often for something frivolous)*---The money had been burning a hole in his pocket when he decided to go to the casino.

buy off- *give money to someone to stop them from doing their duty*---They tried to buy off the politician but he refused to go along with their plan.

cash-and-carry- *selling something for cash only with no delivery*---We were able to get a good price on a sofa in a cash-and-carry deal at the furniture store.

cash in- *exchange coupons or bonds for their value in money*---I cashed in a large number of my savings bonds in order to get some money to buy a house.

cash in on- *make money from an opportunity*---The former football player cashed in on his popularity to open a very successful restaurant.

cash in one`s chips- *exchange or sell something to get some money*---I decided to cash in my chips to get some money to go back to school.

cash on the barrelhead- *money paid in cash when something is bought*---I had to pay cash on the barrelhead for the used car.

caught short- *not have enough money when you need it*---I was caught short and had to borrow some money from my father last week.

cheapskate- *a person who will not spend much money, a stingy person* My friend is a cheapskate and won't even go to a movie with me.

chicken feed- *a small amount of money*---His son always wants to borrow money and says that it is only chicken feed but little by little it adds up to a lot of money.

chip in- *contribute money or pay jointly*---Everyone in our company chipped in some money to buy a wedding present for our boss.

clean up- *make a lot of money, make a big profit*---I cleaned up at the horse races last year and still have some of the money left.

cold hard cash- *cash, coins and bills*---I paid for the stereo in cold hard cash.

cook the books- *illegally change information in accounting books in a company*---The accountant was cooking the books for over a year before he was caught.

cut-rate- *sell for a price lower than usual*---We went to a cut-rate furniture store to buy some new furniture for our apartment.

deadbeat- *person who never pays the money he owes*---Recently the government has been making an effort to solve the problem of deadbeat dads who don't support their families.

dime a dozen- *easy to get and therefore of little value*---Used computers are a dime a dozen and have very little value.

down and out- *have no money*---My friend was down and out for several years before he got a job and started making money.

Dutch treat- *something where each person pays their own share*---We went to the movie as a Dutch treat so it didn't cost me much money.

face value- *the worth or price printed on a stamp, bond, note or paper money etc*---The face value of the stamp was very low but in reality it was worth a lot of money.

fast buck- *money earned quickly and easily (and sometimes dishonestly)* The company tried to make a fast buck on the property but they actually lost a lot of money.

feel like a million dollars/bucks- *feel wonderful*---Although I have been sick for a few weeks I feel like a million dollars today.

flat broke- *having no money, penniless*---I am flat broke and don't even have enough money to pay my rent.

foot the bill- *pay*---My sister is footing the bill for her daughter's education so she is making sure that she studies hard.

for a song- *at a low price, cheaply*---We bought the car for a song and will try and sell it for a higher price.

fork over- *pay, pay out*---I forked over a lot of money for the painting that is hanging on my wall.

for love or money (usually negative)- *for anything, for any price*---I would not want to have to do that man's job for love or money.

go broke- *lose all one`s money, have no money*---My uncle started a company last year but it quickly went broke.

gravy train- *getting paid more money than the job is worth*---The job was a gravy train and I made a lot of money when I was there.

grease one`s palm- *give a tip, pay for a special favor or extra help, bribe*---The government official was greasing his palm at his office until he was finally fired.

hand-out- *a gift of money (usually from the government)*---After receiving hand-outs from the government for many years they finally had to make money on their own.

hand to mouth- *having only enough money for basic living*---My friend has been living from hand to mouth since he lost his job.

hard up- *not have much money*---His brother is hard up for money and always wants to borrow some.

have sticky fingers- *be a thief*---The new employee has sticky fingers and many things in the store have disappeared.

highway robbery- *charge a high price for something*---The amount of money that the company is charging for its services is highway robbery.

hit the jackpot- *make a lot of money suddenly*---We hit the jackpot at the casino and came home with a lot of money.

in the black- *profitable, making money*---Our company has been in the black since it was first started.

in the hole- *in debt, owing money*---I think that we are going in the hole in our attempts to make our business prosper.

in the red- *unprofitable, losing money*---The company has been in the red for several months now and will soon have to go bankrupt.

keep books- *keep records of money earned and spent*---The accountant has been keeping careful books of all the transactions in the company.

kickback- *money paid illegally for favorable treatment*---The politician received several illegal kickbacks and had to resign from his job.

lay away money- *save money*---I am trying hard to lay away enough money to buy a house.

layaway plan- *a plan in which one pays some money as a down payment and then pays a little more when one can and the store holds the article until the full price is paid*---We brought our furniture on the layaway plan at the store.

lay out- *spend, pay*---I had to lay out a lot of money to get my car fixed so now I don't have any money to go out.

live from hand to mouth- *live on little money*---My friend has been living from hand to mouth on his savings from his last job.

live high off the hog- *have the best of everything, live in great comfort*---My mother and father have been living high off the hog since they won the lottery.

Loaded- *have lots of money*---My uncle is loaded and always has lots of money.

**lose one`s shirt**- *lose all or most of one`s money*---I lost my shirt in a business venture and now I have no money.

make a bundle- *make a lot of money*---I made a bundle on the stock market and have since bought a house.

make a killing- *make a large amount of money*---My sister made a killing when she worked overseas in the oil industry.

make a living- *earn enough money to live*---If you want to make a good living it is necessary to get a good education.

make ends meet- *have enough money to pay one`s bills*---I have been having trouble making ends meet because the rent for my apartment is too high.

make money hand over fist- *make money fast and in large amounts*---My cousin has been making money hand over fist with her business.

money to burn- *very much money, more money than is needed*---My aunt has money to burn and is always travelling somewhere.

nest egg- *money someone has saved up*---I made a nice nest egg when I was working and I am now able to go to school.

on a dime- *in a very small space*---I had to turn my car on a dime when I entered the parking lot.

on a shoestring- *with little money to spend, on a very low budget*---He started his business on a shoestring but now it is very successful.

on the house- *paid for by the owner*---We went to the restaurant and all of the refreshments were on the house.

pad the bill- *add false expenses to a bill*---The plumber who was fixing our plumbing system was padding the bill so we got another plumber.

pass the buck- *make another person decide something, put the duty or blame on someone else*---The foreman is always passing the buck and will never take responsibility for anything that he does.

pay an arm and a leg for something- *pay a high price for something*---I paid an arm and a leg for my car but I am not very happy with it.

pay dirt- *a valuable discovery, the dirt in which much gold is found*---We hit pay dirt when we got the rights to distribute the new product.

pay off- *pay and discharge from a job*---The company paid off their employees and shut down for the winter.

pay-off- *bribe*---The mayor received a pay-off and was forced to resign from his position.

pay through the nose- *pay at a very high price, pay too much*---I paid through the nose when I had to buy gasoline in the small town.

penny for one`s thoughts- *tell someone what you are thinking about*---"I will give you a penny for your thoughts", I said to my friend who was looking out of the window.

penny wise and pound foolish- *wise or careful in small things to the costly neglect of important things*---My friend is penny-wise and pound foolish and economizes on small things but wastes all of his money on big things.

pick up the tab- *pay the bill*---I picked up the tab for my sister and her three children at the restaurant.

piggy bank- *a small bank, sometimes in the shape of a pig for saving coins*---The small boy saved up much money in his piggy bank.

pinch pennies- *be careful with money, be thrifty*---My grandmother always pinches pennies and will never spend her money foolishly.

pony up- *pay*---I had to pony up a lot of money to pay to get my car repaired.

**put in one`s two cents**- *give one`s opinion*---I stood up in the meeting and put in my two cents before I was asked to sit down.

quick buck- *money earned quickly and easily (and sometimes dishonestly)*---The company is only interested in making a quick buck and is not at all interested in quality.

rain check- *a promise to repeat an invitation at a later date*---I decided to take a rain check and go to the restaurant another time.

rake in the money- *make a lot of money*---We have been raking in the money at our restaurant and will soon be able to go on a long holiday.

red cent- *the smallest coin, a trivial sum of money*---I wouldn't give a red cent for my neighbor's car.

salt away- *save money*---My father's uncle salted away thousands of dollars before he died.

scrape together- *gather small amounts of money (usually with some difficulty) for something*---We scraped together some money and bought a present for my mother.

set one back- *cost*---My friend asked me how much my new coat had set me back.

shell out- *pay*---My father shelled out a lot of money to get his house painted.

splurge on something- *spend more money than one might ordinarily spend*---We decided to splurge and go to a nice restaurant for dinner.

stone broke- *having no money, penniless*---His brother is stone broke and won't be able to come to the movie with us.

strapped for cash- *have no money available*---I am strapped for cash at the moment so I won't be able to go with you on a holiday.

strike it rich- *become rich or successful suddenly or without expecting to* My grandfather struck it rich searching for gold but when he died he had no money.

take a beating- *lose money (usually a lot)*---My friend took a beating on the stock market and has now stopped buying stocks..

tighten one`s belt- *live on less money than usual*---We decided to tighten our belt and save up some money for a holiday.

two bits- *twenty-five cents, a quarter of a dollar*---The newspaper was only two bits a copy.

(not worth) two cents- *almost nothing, something not important or very small*---The car that my friend bought is not worth two cents.

two cents worth- *something one wants to say, opinion*---I asked the president for his two cents worth but he didn't want to give us his opinion.

(not) worth a cent- *not worth anything, not of any value*---That antique desk is not worth a cent although everyone thinks it is very valuable.

worth one`s salt- *worth what one is paid*---Our secretary is worth her salt and is a great asset to our company.

Monkey Idioms

go ape (over someone or something)- *become highly excited or angry*
He will go ape if he sees that you have not finished the work that was due today.

make a monkey out of (someone)- *make someone look foolish*
My friend made a monkey out of me when he started arguing with me in front of my boss.

monkey around with (someone or something)- *play with or waste time with someone or something*
The father and son spent the morning monkeying around with the old radio.

monkey business- *unethical or illegal activity, mischief*---He should stop that monkey business and try to do the job the correct way.

a monkey on one's back- *a serious problem that stops someone from being successful at something*---The month without getting a goal was a monkey on the back of the famous soccer player.

monkey see, monkey do- *someone copies something that someone else does*---It is always monkey see, monkey do with the boy. He copies everything that his friend does.

more fun than a barrel of monkeys- *very funny, fun*---The children love the man because he is more fun than a barrel of monkeys and makes everybody laugh.

Mouse Idioms

as poor as a church mouse- *very poor*---My cousin is as poor as a church mouse and never has any money to spend.

as quiet as a mouse- *very quiet, shy*---I was as quiet as a mouse when I left the house early this morning.

the best-laid plans of mice and men- *the best thought-out plans that anyone can make*---The best-laid plans of mice and men could not prevent the problems that we had with our travel plans.

play cat and mouse with someone- *tease or fool someone, change between different types of behavior when dealing with someone*---He is playing cat and mouse with his company about his plans to quit or not.

when the cat's away, the mice will play- *when you are not watching someone they may get into trouble*---When the cat's away, the mice will play and as soon as the teacher left the classroom the students began to move around.

Neck Idioms

break one`s back/neck (to do something)- *do all one possibly can, work very hard to do something*---I broke my neck to try and get the report finished on time.

breathe down (someone`s) neck- *watch someone closely (often by standing right behind them), pressure someone to do something*---My boss has been breathing down my neck all day to try and get me to finish the report.

a crick in one's back/neck- *a painful cramp in one's back/neck*---I woke up this morning with a crick in my neck.

dead from the neck up- *very stupid*---My boss seems to be dead from the neck up.

a kink in one's neck- *a cramp in one's neck that causes pain*---I have a kink in my neck and it hurts every time that I turn my head.

a millstone around (someone's) neck- *a burden or handicap for someone*---My parents' condominium is a millstone around their neck and I hope that they can sell it.

neck and neck- *exactly even in a race or contest*---The two horses were running neck and neck at the end of the race.

a pain in the neck- *an annoying or bothersome person or event*---The customer is a pain in the neck and is always complaining about something.

risk one's neck (to do something)- *risk harm in order to do something*---The fireman risked his neck to save the young child.

save (someone`s) neck/skin- *save someone from danger/trouble/ embarrassment*---The worker tried to save his own neck without thinking of any other people.

stick one`s neck out (for someone or something)- *do something dangerous or risky for someone*---My friend will never stick his neck out to try and help other people.

up to one's neck/ears/eyeballs (in something)- *having a lot of something, much involved/busy with something*---I am up to my neck in work at the moment and won't be able to attend the dinner tonight.

wring (someone's) neck- *be extremely angry at someone*---I plan to wring my friend's neck for breaking my new laptop computer.

a yoke around (someone's) neck- *a burden, something that oppresses people*---The legal problems of my friend were a yoke around his neck which he wanted to deal with.

Negotiation Idioms

(to be) at stake- *to be something that can be lost or gained*---There was a lot at stake during the negotiations between the nurses and the government.

to back down- *to give up a claim for something, to not follow up on a threat*---The government backed down on their threat to stop giving money to the school district.

to back out (of something)- *to get out of an agreement, to fail to keep a promise*---The property developer backed out of the negotiations to build the new city hall.

(to go) back to the drawing board- *to go back and start something from the beginning*---The negotiations for the contract failed so we had to go back to the drawing board.

the ball is in someone's court- *it is the decision of another person/group to do something*---The ball was in the union's court after the company made their final offer.

to beat around the bush- *to talk about things without giving a direct answer*---The manager spent the meeting beating around the bush and never really said anything important.

to bog down- *to slow to a stop*---The negotiations bogged down when the union said they would not negotiate over the issue of part-time workers.

a bone of contention- *the subject or reason for a fight*---The length of the project was a bone of contention during the talks between the city and the developer.

to break down- *to fail, to stop*---The negotiations broke down last night when both sides refused to compromise.

to break off- *to stop or end suddenly*---The government decided to break off talks about extending the trade agreement.

to break through- *to be successful after overcoming a difficulty*---Finally there was a breakthrough in the talks aimed at ending the teacher's strike.

to bring (something) off- *to achieve something*---We were unable to bring off a deal to buy the new computer system for our company.

to bring (someone) to terms- *to make someone agree or do something*---

At first it seemed impossible for the two sides to settle their dispute but we were finally able to bring them to terms.

to bring up (something)- *to begin a discussion of something, to mention something*---I tried hard not to bring up the subject of sales commissions during the meeting.

to call off (something)- *to stop, to quit, to cancel*---The meeting was called off because everybody was busy with other business.

to call (someone's) bluff- *to challenge someone to show that they can actually do what they say they can*---The government called the union's bluff when they threatened to go on strike.

to call the shots- *to be in charge*---During the meeting it looked like the vice-president was calling the shots.

to cave in- *to weaken and be forced to give up*---The company was forced to cave in to the demands of the workers for more money.

to close a deal- *to end a negotiation successfully*---We had to work all night but we were finally able to close the deal.

to close ranks- *to unite and fight together*---During the meeting we closed ranks and refused to compromise on any issue.

to come to terms- *to reach an agreement*---After negotiating all night the government and the company came to terms on an arrangement for sharing the costs of the water system.

to come up- *to become a subject for discussions*---Nothing related to the issue of quality came up during the meeting.

to come up with- *to produce or find a thought or an idea or an answer*---

I was praised by my boss when I came up with some good ideas during the meeting.

common ground- *shared beliefs or interests*---There was little common ground between the two sides and the negotiations did not go well.

to cover ground- *to talk about the important facts and details of something*---The number of questions seemed endless and we were unable to cover much ground during the meeting.

to cut a deal- *to make an agreement, to make a deal*---We were able to cut a deal and left the meeting in a positive mood.

to cut (someone) off- *to stop someone from saying something*---We tried to outline our proposal but we were cut off by our opponents.

(to go/continue) down to the wire- *to run out of time, to near a deadline* ---The negotiations continued down to the wire but finally ended successfully.

to drag on- *to prolong, to make longer*---The talks between the company and the lawyers dragged on for several weeks.

to drag one's heels- *to act slowly or reluctantly*---The government dragged their heels in talks with the union about their new contract.

to draw the line- *to set a limit for what will be done*---The union was willing to compromise on the salary issue but they drew the line at talking about health benefits.

to draw up (something)- *to put something (a contract or a plan) in writing* ---The lawyers drew up a contract for the new housing development on the government land.

to drive a hard bargain- *to bargain hard and make an agreement to one's advantage*---The sales manager drives a hard bargain and it is difficult to negotiate with him.

to drive at (something)- *to mean something, to want to say something*---

I couldn't understand what the other negotiators in the meeting were driving at.

to face down (someone)- *to confront someone boldly*---The government decided to face down the striking transportation workers.

to fall through- *to fail, to be ruined, to not happen*---The deal for the new machinery fell through and we will have to look for another supplier.

fifty-fifty- *equally, evenly*---We shared the profits with the other company fifty-fifty.

to follow through with/on (something)- *to finish an action that you have started*---Our boss said that wages would improve soon but he never followed through with his promise.

to force (someone's hand)- *to make someone do something that they don't want to do at that time*---We decided to force the hand of our opponents as we wanted to finish the negotiations quickly.

to get behind (a person or idea)- *to support, to help*---Although we didn't agree with the president we got behind his proposals at the meeting.

to get down to brass tacks- *to begin the work or business that must be done*---Let's get down to brass tacks and begin talking about the new contract.

to get down to business- *to start working or doing the business at hand*---We decided to get down to business and try to finish the work quickly.

to get the message- *to understand clearly what is meant*---I don't think that the other side got the message regarding the direction that the negotiations were heading.

to get to first base- *to make a good start, to succeed*---We haven't been able to get to first base with the other side about the terms of the new contract.

to get to the bottom of (something)- *to find out the real cause of something*---It was very difficult to get to the bottom of the financial problems in the company.

to get to the heart of (something)- *to find the most important facts or central meaning of something*---We spent the morning trying to get to the heart of the problem with the computer supplier.

to give ground- *to move back or retreat from a position*---We bargained hard but the other sales representatives refused to give ground.

to give in to (someone)- *to do what the other person wants rather than to fight and argue against him or her*---After eight weeks of negotiations we gave in and agreed to sell the machinery at a discount.

to give-and-take- *to share, to give up part of what you want in order to make an agreement*---After much give-and-take we reached an agreement regarding the property transfer.

to go back on (something)- *to not be faithful or loyal to one's word or an agreement*---The company went back on their word to give the employees a salary increase.

to go back to square one- *to go back to the beginning*---The meeting was a failure and we were forced to go back to square one.

to go for broke- *to risk everything on one big effort, to try as hard as possible*---After going for broke at the meeting we finally reached an agreement.

to go over like a lead balloon- *to fail to generate a positive response*---

The sales manager's latest proposal went over like a lead balloon at the meeting

to go over well- *to be liked or successful*---My idea to increase the number of employee evaluations went over well with the new managers.

to hammer out (an agreement/a deal)- *to work something out by discussion and debate*---The negotiations lasted all night but finally we were able to hammer out an agreement.

to hang in the balance- *to have two equally possible results, to be uncertain*---The outcome of the election was hanging in the balance after the two top candidates had an equal number of votes.

(to be) hard-nosed- *to be very strict, to be stubborn*---The negotiators took a hard-nosed position during the talks for a new contract.

to have a card up one's sleeve- *to hide something of value*---I thought that the negotiations would be unsuccessful but my boss had a card up his sleeve that we didn't know about.

to have a poker face- *to not show any reaction or emotion*---Our boss had a poker face when he told us that our office would close.

to hold all the cards/aces/trumps- *to have all of the advantages*---The management group was holding all the cards during the meeting with the union.

to hold out for something- *to keep resisting or refuse to give up until you get the desired results*---The union has been holding out for a better deal and they do not plan to end their strike.

to hold out on (someone)- *to refuse information or something to someone who has a right to it*---The new manager has been holding out on the company and will not tell anyone his plans.

to horse-trade- *to make a business agreement or bargain after careful bargaining and compromise*---After several hours of horse trading we finally reached an agreement to buy the new computers.

(to be) in the bag- *to be certain*---The contract for the new insurance policy is in the bag.

to iron (something) out- *to solve a problem*---After agreeing on the contract we spent a few hours ironing out the final details.

to lay one's cards on the table- *to be open and honest about one's intentions*---He laid his cards on the table during the meeting to sell the excess inventory.

to make headway- *to make progress*---We have been bargaining hard all week and are finally making headway with the new agreement.

to meet someone halfway- *to compromise*---The asking price for the chemicals was too high but we met the salesmen halfway and made an agreement.

to nail (something) down- *to make certain or sure*---We worked hard to nail down an agreement to finish the staff room as quickly as possible.

(to be) off the record- *to be not published or revealed, to be a secret*---I told my boss off the record that I would not be returning after the summer holiday.

to paint oneself into a corner- *to get into a bad situation that is difficult or impossible to escape*---The negotiations were difficult but we won when the other side painted themselves into a corner over the bad insurance policy.

to play hardball with (someone)- *to act strong and aggressive with someone*---The union has been playing hardball during the contract talks.

to play into (someone's) hands- *to do something that another person can use against you*---By losing his temper our manager played into the hands of the other side during the meeting.

to play one's ace- *to use one's best resources (the ace is the most powerful card), to use all of one's power*---I played my ace when I went in to ask my boss for more money.

to play one's cards close to one's chest- *to be secretive and cautious about something*---My colleague was playing his cards close to his chest when he began to talk to our competitor.

to pull (something) off- *to succeed in doing something difficult or impossible*---The contract seemed impossible to win but we pulled it off through our skillful negotiating.

to pull (something) out of a hat- *to get something as if by magic, to invent, to imagine*---We couldn't solve the problem but at the last moment we were able to pull a solution out of a hat.

to put one's cards on the table- *to be open and honest about one's intentions*---It looked like the meeting was going to fail so we put our cards on the table to give it one last try.

to raise/up the ante- *to increase what is at stake or under discussion in a dispute or conflict*---The small country raised the ante in the trade dispute with the larger countries.

a raw deal- *treatment that is not fair*---The sales manager was given a raw deal when he was forced to give up his position as chief negotiator.

to reach a stalemate- *to arrive at a position where no progress is being made*---The talks to buy the new computers reached a stalemate and it will be difficult to get them started again.

to reach first base- *to make a good start, to succeed*---We were unable to reach first base in our discussions with our competitors.

to read between the lines- *to understand the meaning of something by guessing at what is not said*---The salesman didn't say that he had no products available but we read between the lines and saw that he didn't have any.

a setback- *a delay or handicap*---The bad weather was a setback in our efforts to get the material delivered on time.

to smooth (something) over- *to make something seem better or more pleasant*---We tried to smooth over the problem between our boss and the president of the other company.

to stack the deck (of cards) against (someone)- *to trick someone, to arrange things unfairly*---The manager had stacked the deck against his opponent when he went into the meeting.

to stand one's ground- *to maintain and defend one's position*---Although the other negotiating team was very aggressive we stood our ground and bargained very hard.

to start/get the ball rolling- *to start/ begin an activity or action*---It was time to get the ball rolling so we began the meeting at once.

to stick to one's guns- *to defend an action or opinion despite an unfavorable reaction*---We stuck to our guns during the meeting and asked for more time to consider the proposal.

to take sides- *to join one group against another in a debate or quarrel*---

I was very careful not to take sides in the discussion about buying a new computer.

to talk (someone) into (something)- *to get someone to agree to something, to persuade someone*---We were unable to talk the other members of our team into delaying the meeting until next week.

to talk (someone) out of (something)- *to persuade someone not to do something*---I tried to talk our vice-president out of offering a price that was too low.

to talk (something) over- *to discuss something*---We asked for some time during the meeting to talk over the new proposal.

to throw (someone) a curve- *to mislead or deceive someone*---The purchasing manager threw us a curve when he said that he wouldn't need any of our products until next year.

(do something) to the letter- *do something exactly, do something with nothing done wrong or left undone*---The union representative followed the contract agreement to the letter.

a trump card- *something that is kept back to be used to win success if nothing else works*---Although we appeared weak during the meeting we had some secret information to use as our trump card.

to turn thumbs down on (something)- *to reject something*---The other negotiating team turned thumbs down on our wish to postpone the meeting until tomorrow.

under the wire- *at the very last moment*---We were finished the documents and sent them to the lawyer right under the wire.

to water (something) down- *to change and make something weaker*---

They tried to water down our proposal for the new quality control system.

to wind up- *to bring or come to an end, to finish, to stop*---The meeting wound up at midnight and we were able to go home.

to wrap up- *to finish (a job)*---We wrapped up the meeting early and went home for the weekend.

Numbers Idioms

all in one- *combined*---I was able to use my car for travelling and sleeping all in one.

all rolled up in one- *combined*---His brother is president and vice-president all rolled up in one.

at one time- *at a time in the past*---At one time the man had no money but now he is very rich.

at one with someone- *share the same view as someone*---The other members of the committee are at one with me over my decision to fire the lazy worker.

at sixes and sevens- *in a state of confusion*---Everyone was at sixes and sevens after the announcement that the company was going out of business.

back to square one- *back to where one started*---We were forced to go back to square one in our efforts to change the name of the company.

cut both/two ways- *be capable of having two opposite effects*---My decision to complain to our boss could cut two ways and cause him to be pleased as well as angry at me.

dressed to the nines- *dressed in one's best clothes*---The woman who we saw at the concert was dressed to the nines.

(I/you/he etc.) for one- *as one example*---I for one do not believe that our president will really change the company policy related to hiring new staff.

for one thing- *for one reason (among others)*---It is not possible to use the old building. For one thing it will not pass the fire regulations.

forty winks- *a short sleep during the day*---As soon as I arrived home I lay down and had forty winks.

give three cheers for someone- *give praise or approval for someone who has done well*---The crowd gave three cheers for the team after they won the final game.

great one for something- *a great enthusiast for something*---My friend is a great one for staying up all night and watching horror movies.

hundred to one shot/chance- *a small chance not likely to bring success*---He only has a hundred to one shot at getting the job that he has applied for.

hundred/thousand/million and one- *very/too many*---I can think of a hundred and one reasons why the new employee is not capable of doing his job.

in two minds about something- *undecided*---My niece is in two minds about whether or not she will come and visit me this summer.

in two shakes of a lamb's tail- *very quickly and without difficulty*---Wait one minute. I will be able to help you in two shakes of a lamb's tail.

kill two birds with one stone- *achieve two aims with one effort/action*---If you take the course now you may be able to kill two birds with one stone and receive credit for it on a future program.

new one on me- *something surprising that one did not know before*---My friend's desire to go to London is a new one on me.

nine-day wonder- *someone/something who briefly attracts a lot of attention*---The man was a nine-day wonder but soon was forgotten by most of the people at his former company.

nine times out of ten- *almost always*---Nine times out of ten if you have a problem on the computer it is something small that can be easily fixed.

nine-to-five job/attitude- *a routine job in an office, attitude to life that reflects routine*---He has a nine-to-five attitude and is not doing very well as a salesperson in his company.

number one (look after/take care of number one)- *oneself*---His attitude is to always look after number one without thinking about anybody else.

on all fours- *on one's hands and knees*---The man was down on all fours in the store looking for the keys to his car.

on cloud nine- *very happy*---My sister has been on cloud nine since she won the new car in the contest.

one and only- *the only person or thing*---The company has been selling the one and only compatible printer in the world.

one and the same- *exactly the same*---Doing the job at home or at the company is one and the same to me so feel free to do what you want.

one by one- *individually, one at a time*---The children entered the school building one by one and very quietly.

one for the road- *one last drink (of alcohol) before one leaves for home*---We decided to stay at the party and have one for the road before taking a taxi home.

one good turn deserves another- *if someone helps you it is fair to help them in return*---One good turn deserves another so we made a great effort to help those people who had helped us in the past.

one hell/heck of a something- *the emphasis that something is very good or bad*---The residents of the town gave the Prime Minister one heck of a welcome when he visited them last winter.

one in a million- *a great or unique person*---He is one of the finest coaches in the world and is definitely one in a million.

one of the boys- *an accepted member of a group*---He always tries to act like one of the boys but in reality nobody really likes him.

one of these days- *soon, before long*---One of these days they say that they will open a new movie theater but still we have been waiting many years.

one of those days- *a bad day where nothing goes right*---It was one of those days and right from early morning things went wrong.

one of those things- *something is unfortunate but must be accepted*---Her sudden illness is one of those things and there is nothing we can do about it.

one or two- *a few, a small number*---There were only one or two people at the meeting so it was postponed until later.

(the) one that got away- *referring to a fish that you didn't catch or an opportunity that you missed*---My father said that he had caught many fish but the biggest one was the one that got away.

one too many- *too much alcohol*---The man drank one too many so his friends would not let him drive home.

one up on someone- *have an advantage over someone*---I am one up on my best friend because he is still looking for a job while I have already found one.

one's lucky number comes up- *someone is lucky or has good fortune*---My lucky number finally came up when I was chosen to go to Los Angeles in order to represent our company at the conference.

one's number is up- *something bad will happen to someone*---I think that the manager's number is up and he will soon be fired from his job.

one's opposite number- *someone who has the same position as oneself in another company or organization*---I spoke with my opposite number in the other company but he didn't agree with me about the new sales policy.

pull a fast one (on someone)- *cheat someone*---They tried to pull a fast one on me at the car repair shop but I stopped them easily.

put two and two together- *make a correct guess*---We were able to put two and two together and discover who was sending the unwanted E-mail.

quick one- *a single drink of alcohol taken before one does something else*---We stopped for a quick one on the way home but stayed for more than an hour.

seventh heaven- *in a situation of great happiness*---She has been in seventh heaven since she moved to the new department.

six feet under- *dead and buried*---My uncle has been six feet under for over five years now.

six of one and a half dozen of the other- *there is little difference between two things/situations*---Whatever you do is no problem for me. It is six of one and half a dozen of the other.

(a) stitch in time saves nine- *any damage or mistake should be corrected immediately in order to prevent it getting worse*---You should try and repair your car before it becomes worse. Remember, a stitch in time saves nine.

ten to one- *very likely*---I will make a bet that ten to one he comes to work late again today.

there are no two ways about it- *there is no alternative*---His boss told him that there are no two ways about it and he will have to change his habits or he will be fired.

two can play that game- *you can also treat someone in the same way as they have treated you*---The employees told the boss that two can play that game and if he was too strict they would also be inflexible at work.

two heads are better than one- *it is better to work with another person to solve problems etc*---Two heads are usually better than one when you are trying to solve a difficult problem.

two wrongs don't make a right- *you can't justify a wrong action by saying that someone else did the same thing to you*---Two wrongs don't make a right and if someone does something bad to you you should not try and hurt them as well.

two's company (three's a crowd)- *better to leave two people together than for a third person to interfere*---My friend wanted to come along on the date with me and my girlfriend but I told him that two's company and three's a crowd so he stayed home.

three R's- *the three basic skills from school - reading, (w)riting, (a)rithmetic*---Many people believe that teaching the three R's is the most important role for schools.

Pig/Hog Idioms

as fat as a pig- *very fat*---The woman in the supermarket was as fat as a pig.

buy a pig in a poke- *buy something without seeing it or knowing if it will be satisfactory*
You can buy the used computer but it will be like buying a pig in a poke if you don't look at it first.

cast pearls before swine- *waste something on someone who won`t be thankful or won't care about it*
Giving the jewellery to her will be casting pearls before swine. She will not appreciate it at all.

eat high on/off the hog- *eat good or expensive food*---We were eating high off the hog during our ocean cruise.

go hog-wild- *behave wildly*---The young soccer fans went hog-wild when they arrived in the city for the game.

go whole hog- *do everything possible, be extravagant*---They went whole hog in their effort to make sure that the convention was a success.

**in a pig`s eye**- *unlikely, not so, never*---In a pig`s eye will he be able to save enough money to go to Mexico for the winter.

live high on/off the hog- *have the best of everything*---He has been living high on the hog since he changed jobs.

make a silk purse out of a sow's ear- *create something of value from something with no value*---You can't make a silk purse out of a sow's ear and there is no point in trying to teach the woman any manners.

piggyback- *sitting or being carried on someone`s back and shoulders*---
The boy was riding piggyback on his father`s shoulders.

piggy bank- *a small bank (sometimes in the shape of a pig) for saving money*---The boy has been putting money into his piggy bank to save for a bicycle.

a road hog- *a car driver who takes more than his share of the road*---The person in front of me on the highway was a road hog but I tried not to get angry.

Rat Idioms

rat on (someone)- *report someone's bad behavior to someone*---The little boy ratted on his friend at school.

rat out on (someone)- *desert or betray someone*---He ratted out on his friends and now they won`t talk to him.

rat race- *a rushed and confusing way of living that does not seem to have a purpose*---He is tired of being in the rat race every day and plans to quit his job soon and do something else.

smell a rat- *be suspicious, feel that something is wrong*---I smell a rat. There is something wrong with the offer of a free credit card.

Relationships & Love Idioms

ask for someone's hand in marriage- *ask someone to marry you*---After dating his girlfriend for several years he finally asked for her hand in marriage.

attracted to (someone)- *feel a physical or emotional attraction to someone*---I was attracted to the woman at the party from the moment that I first met her.

blind date- *a date where the two people have never met before*---I went on a blind date in university but it did not work out very well.

break someone's heart- *cause someone emotional pain*---The man broke his girlfriend's heart when he told her that he was no longer in love with her.

break up- *end a relationship*---They broke up after dating for more than three years.

crazy about (someone)- *think that another person is wonderful*---My cousin has been crazy about the bank manager for many months now.

date someone- *go on or have a date with someone*---My sister has been dating her boyfriend for over two years now.

dig someone - *like someone a lot (dig someone is not a commonly used idiom now)*---She really digs the boy in her chemistry class.

double date- *a date where two couples get together to do something*---It was a good idea to go on the double date even though everybody wanted to do something different.

dump someone- *end a relationship by telling someone that you don't want to see him or her*---The woman dumped her boyfriend after they began to have many fights.

fall for (someone)- *fall in love with someone*---She always seems to fall for the wrong person and is never happy.

fall in love (with someone)- *begin to feel love for someone*---He fell in love with a woman from his university class and they got married several months later.

find Mr. Right- *find the right or perfect person*---She is always hoping to find Mr. Right but so far she hasn't had any luck.

first love- *the first person that one falls in love with*---Her first love was with a boy in her high school art class.

get along with someone- *have a good friendly relationship with someone*---The woman gets along with her friends very well.

get back together- *return to a relationship or marriage after breaking up* The man got back together with his girlfriend after separating for several months last winter.

get engaged- *decide to marry someone*---He got engaged to his wife several years before they actually got married.

get hitched- *get married*---My sister and her boyfriend surprised everyone by suddenly getting hitched last weekend.

get serious- *a relationship becomes serious and long-term*---The two students dated for several months before they began to get serious.

give someone (or something) a second chance- *try to save a relationship by forgiving and welcoming the other person back*---The girl's boyfriend left her for several months but when he wanted to come back she was happy to give him a second chance.

go dutch- *a date where each person pays half of the expenses*---In university many of the students had little money so they often went dutch when they were on a date.

good together- *two people who get along well with each other*---They are very good together and nobody has ever seen them argue.

go out with someone- *go on a date or be dating someone*---I have been going out with a woman from my hiking club for several months now.

go steady- *date one person regularly (not so common recently but at one time used often by teenagers)*---The two students have been going steady for three years now.

have a crush (on someone)- *have strong feelings of love for someone (often for a short time and with no results)*---The young girl had a crush on her teacher in junior high school but of course it was an impossible situation.

have a thing for (someone)- *be attracted and care a lot about someone* She seems to have a thing for the new guy who just started to work at her company.

head over heels in love with someone- *be very much in love with someone*---My friend is head over heels in love with the accountant in his new company.

hit it off (with someone)- *get along well with someone (usually from the beginning)*---I hit it off with a woman in my photography class and we have been dating for several months now.

hung up on someone- *be obsessed with another person*---The young woman has been hung up on a member of her tennis club for many months now.

interested in (someone)- *have a romantic interest in someone and possibly want to date that person*---My sister has been interested in one of the students in her university biology class for many months now.

kiss and makeup- *become friends again after a fight or argument*---After they have a fight the couple is always very quick to kiss and make up.

leave someone for someone else- *end a relationship with your partner and start a relationship with someone else*---The man left his wife for his secretary but soon discovered that his life was worse than before.

love at first sight- *fall in love with someone (or something) the first time that one sees him or her*---When I saw the woman at the party it was love at first sight and I knew that I wanted to meet her.

made for each other- *two people who get along extremely well*---*A*lthough we had some differences we got along very well together and seemed to be made for each other.

make eyes at someone- *look at someone in a way that makes it clear that you like that person and find them attractive*---The man became angry when he thought that his girlfriend was making eyes at someone else at the party.

make up- *when two people forgive each other after an argument or begin to see each other again after ending a relationship*---The couple had a big fight at the restaurant but they quickly made up and things quickly got back to normal.

a match made in heaven- *a couple who get along perfectly*---When the two people finally got together it was a match made in heaven and everyone thought that they would stay together forever.

meet/find the right girl/guy- *find the right partner, the one to marry*---When she moved to Madrid she joked that she would never return home if she met the right guy.

on the rocks- *a relationship or a marriage that is experiencing problems*---They are experiencing many problems at the moment and their relationship appears to be on the rocks.

the one (for someone)- *the right partner, the one to marry*---As soon as I introduced my girlfriend to my mother she said that she was probably the one for me.

one and only- *the only person that one loves*---She was his one and only and he felt lost when the relationship ended.

patch up a relationship- *repair a broken relationship*---Although the couple had been fighting and wanted to separate they managed to patch up their relationship and are now very happy together.

perfect couple- *two people who appear to get along perfectly*---Our neighbors have always seemed to be the perfect couple.

pop the question- *ask someone to marry you*---He put much thought into his possible wedding before he actually decided to pop the question.

puppy love- *infatuation (strong feelings of love) between school-age children or teenagers*---The two teenagers thought that their love was the greatest in the world but everyone knew that it was only puppy love.

say "I do"- *get married (during a wedding ceremony it is common to say "I do" when you agree to marry your partner)*---He loved the woman very much and was hoping that she would say "I do" as soon as they could make the wedding arrangements.

seeing someone- *be dating someone on a regular basis*---The woman was not seeing anyone when she met a man who she liked at the party.

set a date- *decide on a date for a wedding*---After thinking about marriage for a long time they have finally decided to set a date.

settle down- *establish a regular routine after getting married*---After dating dozens of women the young man finally decided to settle down.

split up- *two people in a relationship decide to end their relationship*---My sister's daughter and her boyfriend decided to split up after being together for seven years.

steal someone's heart- *cause someone to fall in love with you*---She quickly stole the heart of the man who was working beside her at her office.

take one's vows- *get married and take your wedding vows (promises)*---They were taking their vows down at the county courthouse when I came for a visit.

those three little words- *the words "I love you"*---After several months of dating the young man finally said those three little words to his girlfriend.

tie the knot- *get married*---After dating for several years the young couple suddenly decided to tie the knot.

true love- *a genuine feeling of romantic love*---It seemed like true love until we began to fight all of the time.

unrequited love- *love that is not returned, one-way love*---The woman was in love with the president of her company but from the beginning it was a case of unrequited love.

walk down the aisle together- *get married (in this case in a Christian church where many weddings take place and where the bride walks down the aisle to the altar)*---They get along very well and they have finally decided to walk down the aisle and begin their life together.

walk out on- *abandon your partner and end a relationship*---The man walked out on his wife and their small baby and nobody knew the reason why.

whisper sweet nothings in someone's ear- *romantic, intimate talk*---The movie was rather romantic and most of the scenes had the actor whispering sweet nothings in the ear of the actress.

Sheep/Goat Idioms

as gentle as a lamb- *very gentle*---The girl is as gentle as a lamb when she is with her little sister.

as innocent as a lamb- *having no guilt, naïve*---The little girl is as innocent as a lamb and everyone loves her.

as meek as a lamb- *quiet, docile, meek*---The secretary was as meek as a lamb when she went to ask her boss for a salary increase.

the black sheep of the family- *the worst or an unpopular/disliked member of a family*---My cousin is the black sheep of the family and nobody likes to talk about him.

get (someone`s) goat - *annoy someone*---She is always complaining about the way that I do things which gets my goat.

in two shakes of a lamb's tail- *very quickly*---I promised that I would meet my friend in two shakes of a lamb's tail.

like lambs to the slaughter- *quietly and without complaining about the dangers that may lie ahead*---The football team went like lambs to the slaughter to meet the best football team in the country.

separate the sheep from the goats- *divide people into two groups*---We had to separate the sheep from the goats when we began to make selections for the school choir.

Shoulder Idioms

carry the weight of the world on one's shoulders - *appear to be dealing with all the problems in the whole world*---My friend has a lot of stress and thinks that he is carrying the weight of the world on his shoulders.

get the cold shoulder (from someone)- *be ignored, be rejected*--- Yesterday, one of the women who I work with gave me the cold shoulder all day.

give (someone) the cold shoulder- *ignore someone, reject someone*---The office staff gave me the cold shoulder when I did not go to the farewell party.

have a chip on one's shoulder- *have a tendency to try to get in a conflict with others*---Our supervisor has a chip on his shoulder and is not an easy person to work with.

have broad shoulders- *have the ability to work hard and take on responsibilities and accept criticism (because you are strong with broad shoulders)*---The man has broad shoulders and does much more than his share of work in our company.

head and shoulders above (someone or something)- *be superior to someone or something*---Our soccer coach is head and shoulders above the other coaches in the city.

look over one's shoulder- *be worried that something dangerous or bad may happen to you*---I always look over my shoulder when I am walking next to a construction site.

on (someone's) shoulders- *someone's responsibility*---I don't want to have the failure of the project on my shoulders.

put one's shoulder to the wheel- *get busy and do some work*---We must put our shoulders to the wheel and get our work done on time.

rub elbows/shoulders with (someone)- *be in the same place as others, meet and mix with others*---We went to the party in order to rub shoulders with some interesting artists.

a shoulder to cry on- *someone who you can tell about your problems and ask for sympathy and advice*---I gave my friend a shoulder to cry on when I met him at the coffee shop.

shoulder to shoulder- *side by side, with a shared purpose*---The children were standing shoulder to shoulder during the exercise class.

straight from the shoulder- *an open and honest way of speaking*---He was speaking straight from the shoulder when he told the workers about the possible factory closing.

Skin Idioms

as soft as a baby's bottom- *very soft and smooth*---My new silk pajamas are as soft as a baby's bottom.

get under (someone`s) skin- *bother/irritate someone*---She is beginning to get under my skin with her constant complaining about the noise.

goose bumps- *the bumpy skin (like a goose) that one gets because of excitement or fear*---I got goose bumps when the woman began to talk about her sick child.

jump out of one`s skin- *be badly frightened, be very surprised*---I almost jumped out of my skin when I saw my boyfriend at the movie theater with another girl.

save (someone`s) neck/skin- *save someone from danger/trouble/ embarrassment*---The worker tried to save his own neck without thinking of any other people.

skin and bones- *a person or animal that is very thin/skinny*---The dog was skin and bones after his owner stopped giving him food.

skin-deep- *only on the surface, not having any deep or honest meaning*--- I believe that the speaker's interest in the environment is only skin-deep.

soaked to the skin- *one's clothing is wet right through to the skin*---I was soaked to the skin after walking in the rain for only a few minutes.

thick-skinned- *insensitive, not easily upset or hurt*---You really must be thick-skinned if you decide to get involved in politics.

thin-skinned- *easily upset or hurt, very sensitive*---My friend is rather thin-skinned and is always upset about something that someone may have said to her.

Sports Idioms

across the board- *applying to all (in horse racing a bet where an equal amount of money is placed on a horse to finish in any top winning position)*---The workers received an across the board wage increase and most of them were happy.

arrow in one's quiver- *have a number of resources or strategies that one can follow*---His ability with languages was another arrow in his quiver and helped him in his business life.

at this stage of the game- *at some point, at some time during an activity*---At this stage of the game I don't think that we should spend more money on the project.

back the wrong horse- *make the wrong choice, support the wrong thing (from horse racing)*---The students backed the wrong horse in the election for school president and were very surprised at the winner.

ball is in someone's court- *it is that person's turn to act next (from tennis or a similar game)*---We made an offer to buy the business and now the ball is in the owner's court to accept our offer or not.

ballpark estimate/figure-*a guess in a certain area or range*---We were given a ballpark estimate as to how much it would cost to buy the business.

bat a thousand- *be successful in everything that you do*---The salesman was batting a thousand during his sales trip to Europe.

beat the gun- *do something before the ending signal of a game etc*---We were able to beat the gun and applied before the final deadline to get the free basketball tickets.

behind the eight ball- *at a disadvantage (from the black ball which is numbered eight in the game of pool)*---Our friend was behind the eight ball when he discovered that he was last in line to register for his classes.

beyond one's depth- *in water that is too deep, do something that is too difficult*---The executives appeared to be beyond their depth when they chose to pick a fight with the unions.

blow the whistle on someone- *reveal information about someone (from sports where the referee blows a whistle when someone does something wrong)*---The secretary blew the whistle on her boss for his responsibility in wasting much money in his department.

bounce something (an idea) off someone- *test someone's reaction to an idea*---I bounced my idea for the new restaurant off my friend.

call the shots- *control something, make the rules (from calling the shots in billiards/pool)*---My friend has been calling the shots in his company for several years now.

carry the ball- *be in charge (from carry the ball in American football)*---The director decided to let his assistant carry the ball on the assignment for the new sale's contract.

clear a hurdle- *overcome an obstacle (from a hurdle in a race)*---We finally cleared a major hurdle in our effort to get a license to sell our products.

come out of left field- *be completely unexpected*---His idea about going to Turkey came right out of left field.

cover all of one's bases- *thoroughly prepare for or deal with a situation*---He covered all of his bases before going to the job interview and performed very well.

(be) cricket- *fair play, gentlemanly conduct (usually used in the negative)*---The way that the government treated the union leaders was not cricket.

dive right into something- *begin to do something without hesitating*---When university started some of the students decided to dive right into their studies.

down/out for the count- *defeated, unconscious (in boxing a boxer who is on the ground must get up before the count of ten or he will lose)*---The

political candidate seemed to be down for the count when no major figures supported him.

down to the wire- *at the very last minute (from the wire at the end of a horse race)*---The election went down to the wire but in the end the President was re-elected to another term in office.

draw first blood- *the first point or advantage gained in a contest (often in boxing or fighting with swords)*---The heavyweight champion drew first blood in the boxing match but in the end was defeated by his opponent.

drop the ball- *make an error or mistake, handle things badly*---The government dropped the ball on their decision to expand the airport runway without consulting the local residents.

first out of the gate- *be the first person to begin a project*---He was first out of the gate in the effort to raise money for the new concert hall.

first past the post- *winning a race by being the first to reach the finishing line (in a horse race)*---The young horse was first past the post and won a large amount of money in the race.

get off to a flying start- *have a very successful beginning*---The meeting got off to a flying start when the company directors announced that they had won a large contract.

get one's feet wet- *start a new project cautiously*---Before getting my feet wet I spent many months studying the plans for the new project.

get the ball rolling- *begin*---We got up early to get the ball rolling on our project.

get to (reach) first base with someone or something- *make an advance with someone or in some undertaking (from first base in baseball)*---I spent several hours talking about changing my work hours but I wasn't able to get to first base with my boss.

get two/three strikes against someone- *get several things against one, be in a situation where success in unlikely (in baseball a batter is finished after three strikes)*---His absence from work and being late were serious

problems. He now had two strikes against him. Any more problems and he would have to be fired.

go to bat for someone- *support or help someone (in baseball you sometimes substitute one batter for another)*---The young woman's teacher went to bat for her when she was having problems with the school administration.

go to the mat- *argue strongly on behalf of someone or something*---The coach would always go to the mat for his players when they were having problems.

hand the torch/baton to someone- *hand over a particular duty or responsibility to someone (from the baton or torch that is passed from one runner to the next in a relay race)*---The president of the company handed the torch to his son when he decided to retire.

hard to call- *hard to decide or determine something (referees in sports sometimes have to make difficult decisions)*---The election was hard to call and nobody knew who was going to win.

have had a good innings- *have enjoyed a long period of positive action or opportunity (from cricket where an innings is the time that a team spends batting and a good innings is when they score a lot of runs)*---The team had a very good innings and won the match easily.

have the inside track- *have an advantage (if you have the inside track in running a race you have an advantage)*---I had the inside track when I applied for the job at the bank.

hit someone below the belt- *unfair, not following the rules (from hitting low in boxing)*---It was a case of hitting someone below the belt when the girl stole her best friend's boyfriend from her.

hit the bull's-eye- *achieve your goal perfectly*---We hit the bull's-eye when our sales target was met for the year.

in full swing- *full capacity, greatest activity*---The basketball season was in full swing when we decided to buy season's tickets.

in someone's corner- *on someone's side, supporting someone (in a boxing match each boxer has his own corner)*---The young man gained confidence when he realized that there were many people in his corner.

in the ballpark- *in a particular area or range (from a baseball field)*---The value of my business was not in the same ballpark as what I had been offered so I decided not to sell it.

in the bullpen- *a baseball player is in a special area getting ready to pitch in a game*---The new pitcher practiced in the bullpen while he waited for a chance to enter the game.

in the homestretch- *be close to completion*---The project to build the new bridge is now in the homestretch

in the running- *to be a candidate (from horse racing when two horses are running evenly)*---The lawyer is in the running for a job on the city school board.

in the same league as someone- *be at the same level as someone*---The boys soccer team was not in the same league at their opponents.

jockey for position- *try to put yourself in a better position at the expense of others (as a jockey would do in a horse race)*---The salesmen started to jockey for position as soon as they learned that the sales manager was leaving the company.

jump the gun- *start before the starting signal or before you should start (as in a race)*---My friend jumped the gun and applied for the job before applications were being accepted.

keep one's eye on the ball- *remain alert, keep one's attention focused on the ball or the matter at hand*---He was told that during the meeting he must keep his eye on the ball and concentrate on the matter at hand.

keep the ball rolling- *maintain the momentum of an activity*---My friend is always able to keep the ball rolling when we are gathered for dinner and everyone becomes silent.

kick off- *kick the ball and start the game in American football, begin, start*---They kicked off the campaign to raise money for the hospital with a large fund raising event at a restaurant.

know the score- *know the facts about something*---The new secretary doesn't really know the score about how the company operates.

level playing field- *a situation where everyone has an equal chance at success*---We were able to achieve a level playing field with the other schools when the government made some new rules regarding the competition.

make it to first base- *successfully taking the first step with someone or when doing something*---I was not able to make it to first base in my attempt to have my boss change my work schedule.

make the cut- *meet or come up to a required standard (from golf where a player must do equal or better than a certain score to continue)*---The young player did not make the cut and was unable to join the team that year.

meet one's match- *encounter one's equal*---The boxer finally met his match when he was offered the fight with the other wrestler.

miss the cut- *fail to come up to or meet a required standard (from golf where a player must do equal or better than a certain score to continue)*---After several successful tournaments the golfer missed the cut and could not enter the next tournament.

move the goalposts- *unfairly change the conditions or rules of something that you are doing*---Although we followed the rules when applying for the license, the government officials moved the goalposts and our application was rejected.

neck and neck- *exactly even (as in a horse race)*
The two candidates were running neck and neck in the election until the last ballots were counted late in the evening.

nip and tuck- *almost even or tied*---The two horses were running nip and tuck for most of the race but finally the younger horse won the race.

not in the same league- *much inferior to someone*---Our soccer team was not in the same league as the Brazilian players who we met at the tournament.

odds are against one- *there is little chance that you will succeed*---The odds were against the boy joining the team but he tried very hard anyway.

off and running- *make progress in something from the beginning (from horses who run quickly from the start of a race)*---The two candidates were off and running in the race to become mayor of the city.

off base- *wrong, unrealistic*---The general was off base with his estimate about how many soldiers were needed for the battle.

off to a running start- *start with a good fast beginning*---Everyone was off to a running start when the campaign to collect money for the new hospital began.

on a par with- *equal in importance or quality to something or someone (par is the usual number of strokes that are needed to get around a golf course)*---The recent scandal involving steroids in sports was on a par with other major scandals of several decades ago.

on side- *supporting or part of the same team as someone else*---We finally got the directors on side in our bid to host the local basketball championships.

on the ropes- *in a desperate situation or near defeat (from boxing where the losing boxer is forced back against the ropes)*---The boxer was on the ropes and it seemed impossible for him to win the match.

on your marks- *used to tell runners in a race to get into the correct starting position*---The race began as soon as the judge yelled, "on your marks, get set, go."

out in left field- *offbeat, unusual (as in the back and left side of a baseball field)*---Our teacher's ideas are usually out in left field and everyone is surprised to hear them.

out of one's league- *not equal to or in the same class as someone (a league is a group of sports teams that compete against each other)*---The artist was totally out of his league when he went to Paris and tried to enter the art world.

out of the running- *eliminated from a contest, no longer being considered*---Our friend was out of the running for the director's job so she decided to return to school and continue her education.

paddle one's own canoe- *do something alone, be independent*---The company director was left to paddle his own canoe when the other members of the company resigned their positions.

par for the course- *what is normal or expected in a given situation (in golf par is the usual number of strokes needed to go around a golf course)*---A bad attitude at work is par for the course for that supervisor and it is something that management must deal with.

pass the torch/baton to someone- *hand over a particular duty or responsibility to someone (from the baton or torch that is passed from one runner to the next in a relay race)*---The head of the soccer association passed the torch to his director after spending many years in the sport.

play ball (with someone)- *cooperate with someone*---The young men refused to play ball with the police and were taken to the police station for questioning.

play by the rules- *follow the generally accepted rules of something*---The team members refused to play by the rules so they were asked to leave the tournament.

play fair- *avoid cheating*---The boxer was an honorable athlete and always played fair when he was in the boxing ring.

play hardball with someone- *behave in an extremely determined way to get what you want (hardball and softball are from the game of baseball)*---The owners of the football club decided to play hardball when they began negotiating with the top player.

pump iron- *exercise with weights*---Her brother has been pumping iron for more than two years now.

put in one's oar- *give help, give advice without being asked*---We were doing very well until our supervisor came along and put in his oar. We would have done better without him.

rally around someone or something- *join together to support someone or something*---The city rallied around the basketball team when they went to the national championships.

rest on one's oars- *relax one's efforts*---The negotiating team decided to rest on their oars and wait until their partners had a chance to consider the offer.

right off the bat- *at the very beginning, immediately (like the ball leaving a baseball or cricket bat)*---After arriving at the resort, we were told right off the bat that we would have to pay extra to use the pool and the training room.

roll with the punches- *adapt to difficult circumstances (from boxing where a boxer moves away or rolls from a punch to lessen its impact)*---My sister is able to roll with the punches and can handle the many problems in her work very well.

run interference- *intervene on behalf of someone to protect them from something (from American football)*---They ran interference on their top salesman to protect him from the scandal.

safe bet- *a certainty (a horse that is expected to win a race)*---It was a safe bet that we would win the large contract if we bid for it.

saved by the bell- *rescued from a bad situation at the last minute (as in the bell at the end of each round in a boxing match)*---We were saved by the bell when the meeting ended before we had to deliver our badly prepared presentation.

score points with someone- *gain the favor of someone*---The salesman always worked extra hours in order to score points with his boss.

send someone to the showers- *send a player off the field and out of a game*---The referee sent the top player to the showers after he refused to stop arguing.

set the pace- *establish the speed or pace of something*---The runner set the pace for the other runners during the marathon.

smooth sailing- *something is working out well and has no problems*---After we left the city it was smooth sailing on the highway until we got to our destination.

sporting chance- *some possibility of success*---The tennis player was not given a sporting chance to win the tournament but still she tried very hard to win.

sport of kings- *horse racing*---Horse racing has been the sport of kings for many years.

steal a base- *sneak from one base to another in baseball*---The young baseball player won an award for stealing the most bases in one year.

sticky wicket- *an awkward situation (from cricket where rain has made it difficult to bat on the field)*---The rain had made a sticky wicket out of the field and neither side was able to play very well.

strike out- *fail*---The criminal struck out in his attempt to change the punishment that he had received from the judge.

tackle a problem- *attack a problem with much effort (from American football where one player tackles another player)*---All of the members of the sales team gathered to tackle the problem of decreasing sales.

take one's eye off the ball- *fail to keep one's attention focused on the ball or the matter at hand*---He took his eye off the ball for only a second and the other team quickly scored a goal.

take the chequered flag- *finish first in a race (from the flag that is used in car racing when the winner finishes the race)*---The Brazilian driver took the chequered flag for the third time this year.

take the wind out of one's sails- *become discouraged and lose one's enthusiasm*---It took the wind out of his sails when he was told that he was not doing a good job.

team player- *someone who works well with others to achieve some goal*---The man is a team player and works well with all of the other members of the staff.

test the water- *check to see if a plan will work before you start*---The fruit juice company tested the water before they began to sell the lemon fruit juice.

"**That's the way the ball bounces.**"- *that's life, there is nothing you can do about something*---The man replied, "That's the way the ball bounces", when he told his friend about the job that he had lost.

throw in the towel/sponge- *admit defeat, stop fighting (in a boxing match a towel is thrown into the ring to admit defeat)*---The candidate threw in the towel early in the evening of the election when it became impossible for her to win.

throw one's hat into the ring- *be willing or decide to enter a contest or take up a challenge*---The young woman decided to throw her hat into the ring for the election for school president.

throw/pitch someone a curve- *pitch a curve in baseball, confuse someone by doing something unexpected*---My friend threw me a curve when he changed the dates of our plan to go on a holiday together.

too close to call- *so evenly balanced that it is not possible to predict the outcome (in a contest, race, election)*---The game was too close to call until the last few minutes of the game.

toe the line- *accept the authority or policies of a particular group (competitors in a race line up with their toes on the starting line)*---The worker refused to toe the line and was fired from his job.

touch base with someone- *briefly meet or make contact with someone*---I touched base with my uncle before he left on his trip to Mexico.

two strikes against someone- *do two things that are wrong or bad and have only one more to do to cause you serious trouble (from baseball where a batter is finished after three strikes)*---The young boy had two strikes against him when he went to hear the judge's decision about his crime.

up to par- *at an expected or usual level or quality (par in golf is the usual number of strokes used to get around a golf course)*---The product was not up to par and was sent back to the factory for further improvement.

whole new ball game- *a new set of circumstances (from a new game of baseball)*---The election had become a whole new ball game when the main candidate quit because of a scandal.

win by a neck- *succeed by a small amount (in horse racing a horse may win by the length of its head only)*---The race was very close but at the end the young horse pulled ahead and won the race by a neck.

win by a nose- *win by a very small amount (the narrowest margin that a horse can win in a horse race)*---There was a dispute as to who won the horse race but the judges settled the matter and declared that one of the horses had won the race by a nose.

Stomach Idioms

can't stomach (someone or something)- *dislike someone or something very much*---I can't stomach the new woman who I have to work with.

contemplate one's navel- *spend a lot of time thinking about one's own problems rather than being concerned about more important things*---I spent the summer contemplating my navel and didn't do a thing.

difficult to stomach (someone or something)- *be unable to accept someone, be unable to accept something that you think is unpleasant or wrong*---It is difficult to stomach my friend when she begins to complain about her apartment.

eyes are bigger than one's stomach- *take more food than one can eat*---My eyes were bigger than my stomach when I went to the buffet table and put too much food on my plate.

hard to stomach (someone or something)- *be unable to accept something or do something that you think is unpleasant or wrong*---I find some of my classmates and their attitude to studying hard to stomach.

have/get butterflies in one`s stomach- *have/get a feeling of fear or anxiety in one's stomach*---The little boy had butterflies in his stomach when he had to give the speech in front of the class.

not have the stomach for (something)- *have no desire to do something because you think that it is unpleasant or wrong*---I do not have the stomach to talk with my friend about his work and financial problems.

turn (someone`s) stomach - *make one feel sick, disgust someone*---The sight of the dead dog on the road turned my stomach.

Sweat Idioms

blood, sweat, and tears- *great personal effort*---We put a lot of blood, sweat, and tears into fixing our old house.

break into a cold sweat (about something)- *become nervous or frightened about something*---I broke into a cold sweat when I went to tell my teacher what I had done wrong.

by the sweat of one's brow- *by one's hard work or effort*---The restaurant owner built his business by the sweat of his brow.

sweat blood- *be very anxious and tense*---I began to sweat blood when I heard that some of our staff would be transferred to another city.

sweat it out- *wait patiently until something bad or unpleasant ends*---We had to sweat it out in a small town with no food while our car was being repaired.

Throat Idioms

at each other's throats- *fight/argue all the time*---The two boys were at each other's throats as soon as they entered the room.

cut/slit one`s (own) throat- *experience certain failure, do something that will cause problems now or in the future*---He is cutting his own throat if he doesn't make an effort to find a new job quickly.

get/have a frog in one's throat- *get soreness in your throat that prevents you from talking well*---I got a frog in my throat just as I answered the phone to talk to my professor.

get/have a lump in one's throat- *feel like there in something in your throat as if you were going to cry*---I got a lump in my throat as I listened to the tragic story of the woman's family.

grab (someone) by the throat- *a performance/book/idea makes one feel very interested/excited/frightened*---The ballet performance grabbed the audience by the throat and everyone left the auditorium speechless.

jump down (someone`s) throat- *suddenly become very angry at someone*---The man's wife jumped down his throat when he came home late for the third day in a row.

shove/force/ram (something) down (someone`s) throat- *force someone to do or agree to something that they don't want or like*---The workers were angry because the boss tried to shove the new regulations about uniforms down their throats.

stick in (someone's) throat/craw- *an idea or situation is difficult for you to accept and irritates or displeases you*---The customer's attitude sticks in my throat and I am always happy to see him leave.

wet one's whistle- *have a drink (one's whistle is one's throat)*---I stopped at a small cafe near the beach in order to wet my whistle.

words stick in one's throat- *one can hardly speak because he or she is so overcome by emotion*---I tried to ask the girl in my class out for a date but the words stuck in my throat and I couldn't say a thing.

Wolf Idioms

cry wolf- *give a false alarm, warn of a danger that is not there*---He is crying wolf. There is no danger that the electrical system will cause a fire.

keep the wolf from the door- *maintain oneself at the most basic level*---My friend's part-time job is enough for him to keep the wolf from the door.

a lone wolf- *someone who prefers to spend time alone and has few friends*---The boy was a lone wolf and spent most of his time alone.

throw (someone) to the wolves- *send someone into danger without protection, sacrifice someone*---He decided to throw his co-worker to the wolves when he asked him to meet the angry customer.

to wolf down (something)- *to gulp down, to eat quickly*---I wolfed down my dinner and left the house for the movie.

**a wolf in sheep`s clothing**- *a person who pretends to be good but really is bad*---"Be careful of that man. He is a wolf in sheep`s clothing."

The End

مُصنّف کی اورکتابیں

